

Amazon PPC Wiki

Beginner's Complete Knowledge Base

A friendly-mentor handbook for fresh graduates with zero Amazon knowledge. Covers all 32 sections of the Amazon PPC Wiki, from foundations through app-building, with realistic examples and a complete training layer (learning aid + quiz + teaching guide + handout) on every content section.

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Generated by Z.ai

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This handbook walks a fresh graduate with zero Amazon knowledge through every section of the Amazon PPC Wiki. Each section is explained in plain, friendly language with realistic numbers, worked examples, and a complete training layer (learning aid + quiz + teaching guide + handout).

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0 Front Matter

Welcome. This is the welcome mat for the entire wiki. Before you dive into campaign types, bids, and metrics, this section explains what you're looking at, who built it, how it's organized, and how to find your way around. Think of it as the orientation briefing on your first day at a new job.

0.1 Home / Landing Page

What this wiki covers and who it's for

This wiki is the single source of truth for everything related to advertising on Amazon. It covers Sponsored Products, Sponsored Brands, Sponsored Display, Sponsored TV, Amazon DSP, and the supporting stack (AMC, Brand Analytics, Bulk Operations, the Ads API). It is written for five overlapping audiences: virtual assistants (VAs) who execute daily optimization tasks, junior strategists who need to understand the why behind the clicks, senior strategists who design full-funnel plans, brand owners who need to make sense of agency reports, and agency owners who manage multiple accounts and need a training asset to onboard new hires. If you fall into any of those buckets, there's a path through this wiki designed for you.

How to navigate

The wiki is structured as 32 numbered sections plus appendices. Each section opens with a friendly-mentor explanation, then drills into sub-sections, and (for sections 1 through 27) ends with a complete training layer: a learning aid, a 5-question quiz with answers and explanations, a teaching guide for instructors, and a one-page handout. If you're reading on screen, use the Table of Contents to jump. If you're reading on paper, flip to the section number you need - the structure is consistent throughout.

'Start Here' paths by role

Different readers need different routes. A Beginner VA should read sections 1 through 9 in order, then jump to section 22 for daily operations. A Junior Strategist adds sections 10 through 11 (metrics and reporting) and section 18 (strategy by lifecycle stage). A Senior Strategist adds sections 12 through 13 (AMC and DSP) and section 25 (emerging topics). A Brand Owner can skim sections 1 through 3, then focus on sections 10, 11, and 23 (communication). An Agency Owner should focus on sections 22, 23, 27, and 31 (training layer) since those govern how the team operates and how knowledge is transferred.

Last-updated log + version number

Every page carries a version number and a 'last verified against live console' date. Amazon changes its advertising console constantly - new report tabs, renamed metrics, retired features - so this field tells you whether the screenshot you're looking at is two weeks old or two years old. As a rule of thumb, anything older than 90 days should be double-checked against the live console before you act on it.

0.2 How to Use This Wiki

Reading order for new hires vs. reference use for veterans

New hires should read sequentially - the wiki builds on itself. Match types (section 4) won't make sense if you haven't read campaign types (section 3). Bidding (section 6) requires understanding match types. Negation (section 9) requires both. Veterans can use it as a reference: jump straight to the section you need. The Table of Contents lists every subsection so you can land precisely where you need.

Notation conventions

Metrics are abbreviated in their canonical form: ACOS (Advertising Cost of Sale), TACOS (Total Advertising Cost of Sale), ROAS (Return on Ad Spend), CTR (Click-Through Rate), CVR (Conversion Rate), CPC (Cost Per Click). Worked examples use realistic but fake numbers - they're labeled as such so no one mistakes them for a real account. Internal cross-references use `[[double brackets]]` in the source markdown; in this PDF they appear as plain bold text. Console button names are shown in italics, like *Create campaign*.

Link to Glossary and Formula Appendix

If you encounter a term you don't recognize, flip to section 28 (Glossary & Acronyms). If you need a formula, flip to section 29 (Appendix: Formulas & Calculators). These two sections are reference material - you don't read them start to finish, you look things up.

0.3 Contributor / Maintenance Guide

Style guide for adding new pages

If you're adding a new page, follow the existing pattern: friendly mentor tone, 1-2 paragraphs per bullet, realistic example with numbers, and the training layer stamp (learning aid + quiz + teaching guide + handout). Use `[[double bracket]]` internal links for any term that has its own glossary entry. Screenshots must be named with the convention `section-topic-assettype-version.png` so they can be programmatically referenced.

Review/approval workflow

Every new page or major edit goes through a one-week review window. A senior strategist reviews for accuracy, a separate reviewer checks for clarity and tone, and the contributor addresses any flagged issues. Pages cannot be marked 'verified' until two reviewers sign off. This process is intentionally slow - the cost of publishing wrong information is higher than the cost of a slow review.

Deprecation policy

Amazon changes constantly. When a feature is retired or a UI is redesigned, the page is marked **STALE - needs update** at the top, the original content stays in place (so historical context isn't lost), and a new page is created to replace it. After 12 months, stale pages are archived to a separate section. After 24 months they're deleted.

Changelog page template

Every edit creates a changelog entry: date, contributor name, section affected, summary of change, and version bump. The changelog lives in section 30 and is the single most useful page for returning contributors who need to know what's been touched since they last visited.

TRAINING LAYER

Learning Aid

Key Terms

Wiki: A structured knowledge base where each topic lives on its own page and pages link to each other.

Training Layer: A four-part stamp (learning aid, quiz, teaching guide, handout) applied to every content page.

Stale page: A page whose content no longer matches the live Amazon console; flagged but not deleted.

COMMON MISTAKES

New hires try to read the entire wiki in one sitting and burn out. Instead, follow the Start Here path for your role.

WORKED EXAMPLE

A VA joins the team. Their manager says "read sections 1-9 in your first week, then section 22." That is roughly 50 pages of friendly-mentor content plus a quiz per section. Plan ~2 hours per section including the quiz.

Quiz: Test Your Understanding

Q1. [Foundational] Who is the primary audience for this wiki?

- A. Only senior strategists
- B. Only brand owners
- C. VAs, strategists, brand owners, and agency owners

D. Only Amazon employees

Answer: C

Why: The wiki is explicitly written for five overlapping audiences - VAs, junior and senior strategists, brand owners, and agency owners.

Q2. [Foundational] What does the "Start Here" path for a Beginner VA cover?

- A. All 32 sections in order
- B. Sections 1-9 plus section 22
- C. Only sections 1 and 2
- D. Sections 10 and 11 only

Answer: B

Why: A Beginner VA needs the operational core (1-9) plus the team operations section (22) to understand daily execution.

Q3. [Applied] What does the "last verified against live console" date tell you?

- A. When the page was first written
- B. When the screenshot was last confirmed to match the live Amazon console
- C. When the contributor last logged in
- D. The page expiration date

Answer: B

Why: This field tells you whether the content (especially screenshots and UI workflows) still matches what Amazon currently shows.

Q4. [Applied] What happens when a feature is retired by Amazon?

- A. The page is immediately deleted
- B. The page is marked STALE, original content stays, new page created
- C. The page is left untouched
- D. The page is moved to the glossary

Answer: B

Why: Stale pages are flagged but kept for historical context, then archived after 12 months and deleted after 24.

Q5. [Advanced] Why does the review/approval workflow take a full week?

- A. Because contributors are slow
- B. Because two reviewers must sign off and the cost of publishing wrong information is high
- C. Because Amazon requires it
- D. Because the wiki tool only allows one update per week

Answer: B

Why: Accuracy matters more than speed - a wrong page can mislead dozens of operators, so two-reviewer sign-off is mandatory.

Teaching Guide

Suggested delivery time: 15 min lecture + 10 min Q&A;

Talking Points

- Frame the wiki as the "single source of truth" - if it is not in the wiki, it does not exist as official team knowledge.
- Walk through the five audience paths so each new hire sees their own route.
- Show the version number and last-verified date on a sample page.
- Explain the training layer pattern: every content section has the same four sub-pages.
- Stress that "STALE" pages are not failures - they are flags.

Live-Demo Checklist

- Open the wiki home page in a browser.
- Click through the Table of Contents to show navigation.
- Open any section and scroll to the Training Layer at the bottom.
- Show the changelog page (section 30) and read the most recent entry aloud.

Discussion Prompts

- Which Start Here path fits you best, and why?
- What is one Amazon Ads feature that recently changed that we should flag as STALE?
- If you found a typo in a page right now, what would the workflow look like to fix it?

Handout Summary

DEFINITION

The Front Matter section is the orientation layer of the wiki. It explains the audience, navigation, contributor workflow, and deprecation policy. Every reader should read this section once before going deeper.

On-the-Job Checklist

- I know which Start Here path applies to my role.
- I can identify the version number and last-verified date on any page.
- I know how to flag a page as STALE if I spot outdated content.
- I know where the changelog lives and how to read it.

1 Foundations & Fundamentals

This is where it all begins. Before you can touch a campaign, you need to understand what Amazon PPC actually is, where it sits in the broader Amazon ecosystem, and the basic vocabulary every strategist uses. Read this section slowly. The concepts here get referenced in every other section.

1.1 What is Amazon PPC

Where it sits in the Amazon Flywheel

Amazon PPC (pay-per-click advertising) is one piece of a four-part flywheel: advertising drives traffic, traffic drives sales, sales drive organic ranking, and organic ranking drives more traffic. Picture the flywheel as a wheel that spins faster as each piece feeds the next. When you launch a new product with no reviews and no organic rank, PPC is the only thing that puts eyes on your listing. Once PPC drives enough sales, Amazon's algorithm starts ranking your product organically for those search terms. As organic rank improves, you can shift some PPC budget toward new keywords - the flywheel keeps spinning.

Auction-based model basics (second-price auction mechanics)

Amazon runs a second-price auction. That means you don't pay your full bid - you pay one cent more than the next highest bidder. If you bid \$1.50 and the next bidder bid \$0.80, you win the auction and pay \$0.81. This is important because it means bidding high is relatively safe: you only pay what's needed to win, not your full bid. The catch is that Amazon also factors in relevance (click-through rate, conversion rate, listing quality) so the highest bidder doesn't always win. A \$1.00 bid on a high-converting listing can beat a \$2.00 bid on a poor listing.

EXAMPLE

Imagine three sellers competing for the keyword 'yoga mat'. Seller A bids \$1.50, Seller B bids \$1.00, Seller C bids \$0.75. Seller A wins the top slot. If a shopper clicks, Seller A pays \$1.01 (one cent above Seller B's bid), not \$1.50.

PPC vs. DSP vs. organic - how they interrelate

PPC (Sponsored Products, Brands, Display) appears inside Amazon search results and on product detail pages. DSP (Demand Side Platform) appears on Amazon-owned sites (IMDb, Twitch) and across the open web via Amazon's ad network. Organic ranking is the unpaid listing position determined by Amazon's algorithm. PPC drives immediate traffic, DSP builds awareness and retargets, and organic is the long-term dividend of doing both well. A healthy account uses all three.

1.2 The Amazon Advertising Ecosystem

Seller Central vs. Vendor Central differences in ads access

Sellers (third-party sellers, or 3P) use Seller Central and have full access to Sponsored Products, Sponsored Brands, and Sponsored Display. Vendors (first-party, or 1P - Amazon buys their inventory wholesale) use Vendor Central and historically had different ad access, but Amazon has been consolidating both into the Amazon Ads Console. As of 2024, most ad types are available to both, but Vendor Central users sometimes see lagging feature rollouts. If you work at an agency, you'll encounter both account types and need to know which you're looking at.

Advertising Console overview

The Amazon Ads Console (advertising.amazon.com) is your home base. The left navigation includes Campaign Manager (where you build and edit campaigns), Reports (where you download search term reports, placement reports, etc.), Stores (where you build brand stores), Audiences (where you build retargeting segments for SD and DSP), and Bulk Operations (where you upload/download spreadsheets to make mass changes). Each tab has sub-tabs - spend an hour clicking through before you start building anything.

Account types: Individual, Agency, Brand-owned, Managed accounts

An Individual account is owned by a single seller. An Agency account can manage multiple client accounts from one login. A Brand-owned account is tied to a brand owner with Brand Registry. A Managed account (also called an Amazon-managed account) is one where an Amazon account manager handles strategy and execution for a fee - usually reserved for large advertisers. The distinction matters because some features (like Sponsored TV or DSP self-service) are gated by account type and spend history.

Amazon Ads API vs. UI-only management

Most VAs and junior strategists manage campaigns through the UI (the web console). The Ads API lets developers programmatically create, modify, and report on campaigns - useful for automation, custom dashboards, or managing hundreds of campaigns across dozens of accounts. API access requires registering as a developer and getting approved. If you're new, ignore the API for now. It only matters once you're scaling automation or building internal tools.

1.3 Core Terminology Primer

Impressions, clicks, CTR, CVR, ACOS, TACOS, ROAS

Impressions are how many times your ad was shown. **Clicks** are how many times shoppers clicked it. **CTR** (Click-Through Rate) is clicks divided by impressions - a 1% CTR means 1 click per 100 impressions. **CVR** (Conversion Rate) is orders divided by clicks - a 10% CVR means 1 order per 10 clicks. **ACOS** (Advertising Cost of Sale) is ad spend divided by ad sales - if you spent \$20 to make \$100 in ad sales, ACOS is 20%. **TACOS** (Total ACOS) is ad spend divided by total sales (ad + organic) - this matters because ad campaigns lift organic sales too. **ROAS** (Return on Ad Spend) is the inverse of ACOS: ad sales divided by ad spend. A 5x ROAS = 20% ACOS. Deep dives on each live in section 10.

Campaign vs. Ad Group vs. Ad vs. Keyword/Target hierarchy

Amazon's ad structure is a four-level hierarchy. At the top is the **Campaign** (where you set budget, bidding strategy, and dates). Inside a campaign are one or more **Ad Groups** (where you group related ads and set default bids). Inside an ad group are **Ads** (the actual creative - a product card with image, title, price). And inside an ad group are **Keywords** or **Targets** (what triggers the ad to show). One campaign can contain many ad groups, one ad group can contain many keywords, and one keyword triggers many ads. Getting this hierarchy wrong is the #1 cause of messy accounts.

EXAMPLE

A campaign named 'YogaMat-Exact-2024' contains one ad group named 'PremiumMats'. Inside that ad group are 3 SKUs (ads) and 15 keywords. Each keyword triggers any of the 3 SKUs when a shopper searches it.

Link to full Glossary

Section 28 has the full A-Z glossary with cross-references back to the deep-dive pages. If you encounter an acronym you don't recognize, go there.

1.4 Eligibility & Prerequisites

Buy Box requirement

To run Sponsored Products, you must own the Buy Box for that SKU. The Buy Box is the white 'Add to Cart' box on the right side of a product detail page. If another seller has the Buy Box (because they're cheaper, have faster shipping, or you ran out of stock), your Sponsored Products ads stop showing. This is the most common reason ads suddenly stop spending - always check Buy Box status first when troubleshooting.

Brand Registry requirements (for SB/SD/Stores)

Sponsored Brands, Sponsored Display, and Brand Stores require Brand Registry, which requires an active registered trademark. If you sell generic products without a trademark, you can only run Sponsored Products. Brand Registry takes 1-3 weeks to process and requires proof of trademark (USPTO registration number or equivalent in your country).

Account health thresholds that block advertising

Amazon tracks account health metrics like Order Defect Rate (ODR), Late Shipment Rate, and Cancellation Rate. If any of these exceed thresholds (typically $ODR > 1\%$), your account can be suspended, which immediately stops all advertising. A suspended account cannot run ads, and existing campaigns stop spending. Always check Account Health before assuming a campaign is broken.

TRAINING LAYER

Learning Aid

Key Terms

Second-price auction: You pay one cent more than the next highest bidder, not your full bid.

Buy Box: The white Add to Cart box on a product page; you must own it to run Sponsored Products.

Brand Registry: Amazon's program requiring an active trademark; gates SB, SD, and Stores access.

Flywheel: The self-reinforcing loop: ads drive sales, sales drive organic rank, rank drives more sales.

COMMON MISTAKES

New strategists assume the highest bid always wins. It does not - Amazon weighs relevance (CTR, CVR) heavily, so a lower bid on a better-converting listing can outrank a higher bid on a weak listing.

WORKED EXAMPLE

You sell a \$29.99 yoga mat. You bid \$1.20 on "yoga mat". The next bidder bid \$0.90. You win the auction and pay \$0.91 per click. If your CVR is 12% (1 order per ~8 clicks), your cost per order is roughly \$7.28. Your ACOS on that order is $\$7.28 / \$29.99 = 24.3\%$.

Quiz: Test Your Understanding

Q1. [Foundational] In a second-price auction with your bid at \$1.50 and the next bid at \$0.80, how much do you pay per click?

- A. \$1.50
- B. \$0.80
- C. \$0.81
- D. \$1.15

Answer: C

Why: Second-price auction: you pay one cent above the next-highest bid, so \$0.81.

Q2. [Foundational] Which condition must be true to run Sponsored Products?

- A. You must have Brand Registry
- B. You must own the Buy Box
- C. You must have 100+ reviews
- D. You must be Vendor Central

Answer: B

Why: Sponsored Products requires Buy Box ownership. Brand Registry is needed for SB, SD, and Stores, not SP.

Q3. [Applied] What is the relationship between ACOS and ROAS?

- A. They are the same thing
- B. ROAS is the inverse of ACOS
- C. $ROAS = ACOS \times 100$
- D. They are unrelated

Answer: B

Why: $ROAS = \text{ad sales} / \text{ad spend}$. $ACOS = \text{ad spend} / \text{ad sales}$. So $ROAS = 1 / ACOS$. A 20% ACOS equals 5x ROAS.

Q4. [Applied] A new product has zero reviews and no organic rank. Which channel is the ONLY one that can put eyes on the listing initially?

- A. Organic search
- B. PPC
- C. Brand Store traffic
- D. External backlinks

Answer: B

Why: Without reviews or rank, organic search won't surface the product. PPC is the only way to drive initial traffic and kick off the flywheel.

Q5. [Advanced] Your Sponsored Products ads suddenly stopped spending. What is the FIRST thing to check?

- A. Bid amount
- B. Campaign budget
- C. Buy Box ownership
- D. Keyword match type

Answer: C

Why: Lost Buy Box is the most common cause of ads stopping. Always check Buy Box status first before adjusting bids or budget.

Teaching Guide

Suggested delivery time: 25 min lecture + 15 min practice

Talking Points

- Open with the flywheel analogy - it sets the mental model for the entire wiki.
- Draw the second-price auction on a whiteboard with three example bids.
- Walk through the campaign hierarchy (Campaign > Ad Group > Ad > Keyword) - draw it as a tree.
- Show a real product detail page and point out where each ad type appears.
- End with the Buy Box point - it is the #1 troubleshooting culprit and saves hours of misdiagnosis.

Live-Demo Checklist

- Open advertising.amazon.com and walk through the left navigation.
- Open Campaign Manager and show one existing campaign's structure.
- Open a product detail page on amazon.com and identify Sponsored Products placements.
- Open Account Health dashboard and show where Buy Box issues surface.

Discussion Prompts

- Why does Amazon weigh relevance in the auction instead of just taking the highest bid?
- If you had to explain the flywheel to a non-technical brand owner in one sentence, what would you say?
- What is one scenario where losing the Buy Box could happen suddenly and how would you spot it?

Handout Summary

DEFINITION

Amazon PPC is a pay-per-click advertising system using a second-price auction where relevance (CTR/CVR) and bid together determine ad placement. It is one of three traffic channels (PPC, DSP, organic) that together form the Amazon flywheel.

KEY FORMULA

Effective Cost Per Click = Next Highest Bid + \$0.01 (in a second-price auction)

On-the-Job Checklist

- I can define impressions, clicks, CTR, CVR, ACOS, TACOS, ROAS in one sentence each.
- I can draw the campaign > ad group > ad > keyword hierarchy from memory.

- I know that Buy Box loss is the first thing to check when ads stop spending.
- I know that Brand Registry is required for SB, SD, and Stores (not SP).

2 Account & Campaign Architecture

Architecture is the skeleton of your advertising. Get it wrong and every optimization becomes 10x harder. Get it right and your account runs cleanly for years. This section is unglamorous but critical - read it twice.

2.1 Account Structure Philosophy

Single vs. multi-account strategy

Most beginners run everything from one Seller Central account. That works until you have multiple brands under one LLC, or you start an agency managing multiple clients. At that point, splitting into multiple accounts makes sense because: (1) it isolates risk - a policy violation on one brand doesn't kill all your brands; (2) it simplifies reporting - each brand has its own P&L; (3) it enables different agency structures per brand. The downside is more logins and more overhead. A common rule of thumb: split when you have more than 2 distinct brands or when a single brand exceeds ~\$500K/year in ad spend.

Portfolio structure and naming conventions

Portfolios are Amazon's way to group campaigns for budget caps and reporting. A good portfolio structure groups campaigns by brand, by product line, or by P&L; owner - whichever maps to how the business thinks about money. A bad portfolio structure groups by campaign type ('all SP campaigns here, all SB campaigns there') because that doesn't match how anyone reads reports.

Naming convention systems

Your naming convention is the single most important documentation choice you'll make. A good convention encodes: brand, product line, match type, campaign purpose (launch/defense/scaling/harvesting), and year. Example:

YogaMat-Premium-Exact-Defense-2024. From that name alone, anyone can tell what the campaign does without opening it. Document your convention in section 27.2 and stick to it religiously - inconsistent naming makes reporting and bulk operations painful.

2.2 Campaign Structuring Models

SKU-level vs. category-level campaigns

SKU-level campaigns put one SKU per campaign. This gives maximum control (you can pause, scale, or pivot each SKU independently) but creates campaign sprawl - 50 SKUs means 50+ campaigns. Category-level campaigns put multiple SKUs from the same category in one campaign. This is lighter to manage but you lose per-SKU budget control. Most agencies use SKU-level for hero products and category-level for long-tail SKUs.

Match-type-segmented structure

The most common professional structure is match-type-segmented: one campaign for Exact match keywords (high-converting, defense), one for Phrase match (discovery + scale), one for Broad match (raw discovery), and one for Auto (Amazon's algorithm picks targets). This segmentation lets you set different bids and budgets per match type - Exact gets the highest bids because those keywords convert best, Broad gets lower bids because it's exploratory.

EXAMPLE

For a yoga mat brand, you might have: 'YogaMat-Exact-2024' (15 keywords, \$50/day budget, \$1.20 bids), 'YogaMat-Phrase-2024' (30 keywords, \$30/day, \$0.70 bids), 'YogaMat-Broad-2024' (10 keywords, \$20/day, \$0.40 bids), and 'YogaMat-Auto-2024' (4 match types, \$15/day, \$0.30 bids). Total: \$115/day.

Funnel-stage structure

Funnel-stage structure groups campaigns by where they sit in the purchase funnel: Awareness (broad keywords, low bids, SD display ads), Consideration (phrase match, competitor ASIN targeting, mid bids), Conversion (exact match, brand defense, high bids). This structure is more strategic but harder to execute - it requires you to know which keywords map to which stage, which is more art than science.

Defense vs. Offense campaigns

Defense campaigns target your own brand name and product names - they stop competitors from stealing your branded traffic. Offense campaigns target competitor brand names and keywords - they try to steal competitor traffic. Defense typically has very low ACOS (under 5%) because shoppers searching your brand are already sold. Offense has higher ACOS (often 30-50%) because you're convincing shoppers to switch. Both belong in a mature account.

Launch vs. Mature/Scaling vs. Harvesting structure

Launch campaigns have aggressive bids, high ACOS tolerance (often 50%+), and run for 4-8 weeks to kick-start the flywheel. Mature/Scaling campaigns have settled bids, target ACOS of 15-25%, and run indefinitely. Harvesting campaigns are dedicated pipelines that take high-performing search terms from Auto/Broad and promote them into Exact. Different structures for different lifecycle stages - covered in depth in section 18.

2.3 Ad Group Best Practices

One-theme-per-ad-group principle

An ad group should contain keywords that share a single theme - same search intent, similar CVR, similar CPC. If you mix 'yoga mat' (intent: buy a mat) with 'yoga class' (intent: find a class) in one ad group, you'll have to set one bid that doesn't fit either well. Splitting them into separate ad groups lets you bid appropriately for each intent.

Single keyword ad groups (SKAGs) - pros/cons

SKAGs put one keyword per ad group. Pro: maximum control - you can set an exact bid for that keyword and see clean search term data. Con: campaign sprawl - 100 keywords means 100 ad groups, which is exhausting to manage. Modern consensus is that SKAGs are overkill for most accounts. Use them only for top 5-10 hero keywords where granular control justifies the overhead.

Ad group-level bid vs. keyword-level bid overrides

Each ad group has a default bid. Each keyword inside it can override that default. If you set ad group default at \$0.80 and a specific keyword at \$1.50, that keyword uses \$1.50. New strategists often forget about keyword overrides and wonder why their ad group default isn't controlling spend. Always check both levels when troubleshooting bid behavior.

2.4 Portfolio & Budget Grouping

Portfolio budget caps

A portfolio can have a budget cap - a hard ceiling on total daily spend across all campaigns inside. This is useful when a brand has a fixed monthly ad budget and you need to prevent overspend. Set the cap at $(\text{monthly budget} / 30 \text{ days}) \times 1.1$ (10% buffer for daily variance). Without the buffer, you'll hit the cap on high-traffic days and miss sales.

Grouping by product line, season, or P&L; owner

How you group portfolios depends on the business. A skincare brand might group by product line (Cleansers, Serums, Moisturizers). A seasonal brand might group by season (Holiday, Summer, Back-to-School). An agency might group by client (each client = one portfolio). The right grouping makes monthly reporting trivial - you can pull one report per portfolio and send it to the relevant stakeholder.

TRAINING LAYER

Learning Aid

Key Terms

Portfolio: A grouping of campaigns used for budget caps and reporting rollup.

Match-type-segmented: Campaign structure where Exact, Phrase, Broad, and Auto each get their own campaign.

SKAG: Single Keyword Ad Group - one keyword per ad group for maximum control.

Defense campaign: Campaign targeting your own brand terms to prevent competitor conquest.

COMMON MISTAKES

Putting all match types in one campaign. This makes bid management impossible because Exact needs higher bids than Broad, but they share a default bid.

WORKED EXAMPLE

You launch with one Auto campaign at \$30/day. After 2 weeks, the Search Term Report shows "yoga mat thick" converted 5 times at \$0.40 CPC. You create an Exact campaign and add "yoga mat thick" at \$1.20 bid. You also add it as a negative in the Auto campaign to avoid cannibalization. Total daily budget is now \$30 (Auto) + \$20 (Exact) = \$50.

Quiz: Test Your Understanding

Q1. [Applied] You have 3 brands under one LLC. When should you split into multiple Amazon accounts?

- A. Never - one account is always best
- B. When you have 2+ distinct brands or one brand exceeds ~\$500K/year in ad spend
- C. Only when Amazon requires it
- D. Always split immediately

Answer: B

Why: Splitting isolates risk and simplifies per-brand reporting. The 2-brand / \$500K threshold is a common rule of thumb.

Q2. [Foundational] What does the naming convention "YogaMat-Premium-Exact-Defense-2024" tell you?

- A. Brand, product line, match type, purpose, year
- B. Brand, SKU, price, category, year
- C. Brand, color, size, material, year
- D. Brand, agency, region, channel, year

Answer: A

Why: Each segment encodes a different attribute so anyone can understand the campaign without opening it.

Q3. [Applied] Why segment campaigns by match type (Exact / Phrase / Broad / Auto)?

- A. Amazon requires it
- B. Each match type needs different bids and budgets because conversion rates differ
- C. It's the only way to get reports
- D. To reduce campaign count

Answer: B

Why: Exact typically converts at 2-4x the rate of Broad, so it deserves higher bids. Segmentation lets you set those bids appropriately.

Q4. [Applied] You see your ad group default bid is \$0.80 but a keyword inside is spending at \$1.50. Why?

- A. Amazon raised the bid automatically

- B. The keyword has a keyword-level bid override set to \$1.50
- C. The campaign budget was too high
- D. Dynamic bidding up/down is on

Answer: B

Why: Keyword-level bids override ad group defaults. Always check both layers when troubleshooting bid behavior.

Q5. [Advanced] Why use SKAGs (Single Keyword Ad Groups)?

- A. To reduce campaign count
- B. To get maximum bid control and clean search term data per keyword
- C. Because Amazon requires them
- D. To automate bidding

Answer: B

Why: SKAGs give granular control but create sprawl. Use only for top 5-10 hero keywords where control justifies overhead.

Teaching Guide

Suggested delivery time: 30 min lecture + 20 min whiteboard exercise

Talking Points

- Open with the skeleton analogy - architecture is unsexy but foundational.
- Draw the match-type-segmented structure on a whiteboard.
- Show a real account with good naming convention and a real account with bad naming - the contrast is striking.
- Walk through when to use SKU-level vs. category-level campaigns.
- End with portfolio budget caps - tie it back to monthly P&L; planning.

Live-Demo Checklist

- Open Campaign Manager and show one account's campaign list.
- Click into a campaign and show the ad group structure.
- Show a portfolio with a budget cap set.
- Demonstrate good vs. bad naming conventions side by side.

Discussion Prompts

- If you were starting a new account today with 10 SKUs, what structure would you use and why?
- What's one signal that your current account structure is wrong?
- How would you explain match-type segmentation to a brand owner who has never heard of match types?

Handout Summary

DEFINITION

Account architecture is the hierarchical structure of campaigns, ad groups, and keywords. Good architecture enables clean reporting, accurate bid management, and easy scaling. The most common professional structure is match-type-segmented (one campaign per match type).

KEY FORMULA

Portfolio daily cap = (Monthly budget / 30) x 1.1 (10% daily variance buffer)

On-the-Job Checklist

- I can explain the difference between SKU-level and category-level campaigns.
- I know when to use SKAGs vs. multi-keyword ad groups.
- I can identify whether a campaign is Defense or Offense from its name.
- I know how to set a portfolio budget cap and why the 10% buffer matters.

3 Campaign Types (Deep Dive Per Type)

Amazon offers four main ad types plus DSP. Each has a different purpose, different placement, and different eligibility. This section is the deep dive - by the end, you'll know which ad type to use when.

3.1 Sponsored Products (SP)

Auto campaigns

Auto campaigns let Amazon's algorithm pick where to show your ads based on your listing content (title, bullets, backend keywords). Amazon splits Auto into four match types: **Close Match** (search terms closely related to your product), **Loose Match** (broader related terms), **Substitutes** (competitor product pages), and **Complements** (products often bought together with yours). Each can be enabled individually and bid separately. Auto is your discovery engine - run it always, mine the search term report weekly, and harvest winners to manual campaigns.

Manual campaigns

Manual campaigns give you control. You pick the keywords (Keyword targeting) or ASINs/categories (Product/Category targeting). Keyword targeting is the workhorse - you bid on specific search terms. Product targeting puts your ad on specific product detail pages (e.g., on a competitor's product page). Category targeting puts your ad across a whole category (e.g., all yoga mats) with refinements like price range or star rating. Most accounts spend 70-80% of budget in Manual.

Bidding strategies: Dynamic bids down only, Dynamic up/down, Fixed bids

Three bidding strategies. **Fixed bids**: Amazon uses your exact bid, no adjustments. Use for new campaigns where you want predictable data. **Dynamic bids down only**: Amazon reduces your bid by up to 100% for low-converting placements. Use for most mature campaigns. **Dynamic bids up and down**: Amazon raises your bid by up to 100% for high-converting placements (Top of Search) and lowers by up to 100% for low-converting ones. Use only for campaigns with strong CVR history - otherwise Amazon will overspend on placements that don't convert.

Placement modifiers

On top of bidding strategy, you can apply placement modifiers: Top of Search (up to 900% bid boost), Rest of Search (no boost allowed), and Product Pages (up to 900% boost). If your bid is \$1.00 and you set Top of Search modifier at +50%, Amazon will bid up to \$1.50 when competing for Top of Search placement. Placement modifiers are the single biggest lever for getting your ad to page 1 - covered in section 8.

3.2 Sponsored Brands (SB)

Product collection, Store spotlight, Video ads

Sponsored Brands appear at the top of search results (above the first organic result) and feature your brand logo, a custom headline, and a set of products. **Product collection** shows 3+ products from your catalog. **Store spotlight** drives traffic to a specific section of your Brand Store. **Video ads** auto-play a 6-15 second video. All SB ads require Brand Registry and link to either a product page or your Brand Store. SB is the best ad type for brand awareness because it occupies prime real estate at the top of search.

Headline/creative best practices

Your custom headline (up to 50 characters) is the most important creative element. Lead with a benefit, not a feature: 'Breathe Easy With Our Hypoallergenic Yoga Mats' beats 'Yoga Mats For Sale'. Include your brand name when possible. Avoid all caps, exclamation marks, and unsupported claims (like '#1 bestseller' unless you can prove it). Amazon rejects ads that violate these rules, costing you days of back-and-forth.

Sponsored Brands bidding & placement nuances

SB uses CPC bidding like SP but with fewer placement controls. You can't apply Top of Search modifiers - SB always appears at top of search by design. You can choose between dynamic bids down only and dynamic up/down. SB campaigns often have lower CTR than SP (because they look more like ads) but higher impression volume, making them useful for awareness.

3.3 Sponsored Display (SD)

Audience targeting (remarketing, in-market, lifestyle)

SD is Amazon's display network ad type. Unlike SP (which targets shoppers actively searching), SD targets shoppers based on behavior. **Remarketing** shows ads to people who viewed your product but didn't buy. **In-market** targets shoppers actively researching a category (e.g., 'in-market for yoga mats'). **Lifestyle** targets shoppers whose purchase history suggests a lifestyle (e.g., 'fitness enthusiasts'). SD appears on product detail pages, Amazon's homepage, and on third-party sites via Amazon's ad network.

Product/contextual targeting

SD also supports contextual targeting - showing your ad on specific product detail pages or categories. This is similar to SP Product targeting but with broader reach (your ad can also appear on non-Amazon sites via the Amazon Publisher Services network). Useful for conquering competitor traffic and for cross-selling your own products.

Views remarketing vs. purchases remarketing

Views remarketing shows ads to shoppers who viewed your product detail page in the last 7-90 days (you set the window). Purchases remarketing shows ads to shoppers who already bought your product - useful for cross-selling complementary products or driving repeat purchases. The distinction matters because the messaging differs: 'Still thinking about this?' vs. 'Loved your mat? Try our block too.'

Creative formats

SD supports image ads (default), video ads, and (with Brand Registry) custom creative with your own logo and lifestyle imagery. Custom creative typically lifts CTR by 30-50% over default product-image ads. The effort is worth it once a campaign is proven.

3.4 Sponsored TV (STV) / Streaming TV Ads

Eligibility & minimum spend

STV places video ads on Amazon's streaming TV inventory (Prime Video, Freevee, Twitch, Fire TV apps). Eligibility requires Brand Registry and a minimum spend that has historically been ~\$50K, though Amazon has been lowering this. STV is best for established brands with broad awareness goals - it's not a launch tactic.

Creative specs

STV creative is 15 or 30 seconds, 16:9 aspect ratio, delivered as MP4 or MOV. Amazon requires broadcast-quality production - no shaky phone footage. Production cost typically runs \$10K-\$50K per spot, separate from media spend. Plan for at least 4 weeks of lead time for creative approval.

Where it fits vs. DSP video

STV is simpler (self-serve, smaller commitment, Amazon-only inventory) while DSP video is more flexible (managed service, larger spend, can extend to non-Amazon streaming inventory like Hulu). New advertisers should start with STV; graduate to DSP video once you have proven creative and want more reach.

3.5 Amazon DSP (cross-link to Section 13)

How DSP differs structurally

DSP campaigns are managed separately from Sponsored Ads (SP/SB/SD). DSP supports display, video, audio, and OTT (over-the-top TV) ad formats across Amazon-owned and third-party sites. DSP is fundamentally a programmatic ad-buying platform, while Sponsored Ads is a self-serve search/display platform. Deep dive in section 13.

When to graduate from Sponsored Ads to DSP

Most brands graduate to DSP when ad spend exceeds ~\$50K/month and the brand has proven creative, established product-market fit, and a need for awareness-layer advertising beyond what SD can do. DSP also unlocks retargeting beyond Amazon's site (e.g., showing display ads to shoppers who viewed your product but didn't buy, across the open web).

3.6 Cross-Campaign-Type Strategy

Full-funnel campaign mapping

A healthy full-funnel account uses SD for awareness (upper funnel, remarketing and in-market audiences), SP for consideration/conversion (mid funnel, keyword and product targeting), SB for brand defense and awareness (top and mid funnel), and DSP for retargeting and upper-funnel video (cross-funnel). Each ad type has a job; using the wrong one for the job wastes money.

Budget allocation ratios by brand maturity

New brand (year 1): 70% SP (mostly Exact + Auto for discovery), 20% SB, 10% SD. **Growth brand (year 2-3):** 50% SP, 20% SB, 20% SD, 10% DSP. **Mature brand (year 3+):** 35% SP, 15% SB, 25% SD, 25% DSP. These ratios shift spend away from pure performance (SP) toward awareness and retargeting (SD, DSP) as the brand matures and needs to defend its category position.

TRAINING LAYER

Learning Aid

Key Terms

Auto campaign: SP campaign where Amazon picks targets based on your listing content; split into Close/Loose/Substitutes/Complements.

Sponsored Brands (SB): Top-of-search ads with brand logo, custom headline, and 3+ products; requires Brand Registry.

Sponsored Display (SD): Display network ads with audience and contextual targeting; appears on and off Amazon.

Placement modifier: Bid boost (up to 900%) for Top of Search or Product Pages placements.

COMMON MISTAKES

Using Dynamic bids up/down on a new campaign with no CVR history. Amazon has no data to optimize with, so it often overspends on placements that don't convert.

WORKED EXAMPLE

A new yoga mat brand launches. Week 1: One Auto campaign at \$20/day, Fixed bids, to gather data. Week 3: Search Term Report shows "extra thick yoga mat" converted 3x at \$0.50 CPC. Create Exact campaign with that keyword at \$1.20 bid, Dynamic bids down only, Top of Search modifier +50%. Total daily budget grows to \$35.

Quiz: Test Your Understanding

Q1. [Foundational] Which Auto campaign match type shows your ad on competitor product pages?

- A. Close Match
- B. Loose Match
- C. Substitutes
- D. Complements

Answer: C

Why: Substitutes targets shoppers viewing competing products that can substitute for yours.

Q2. [Applied] When should you use Dynamic bids up and down?

- A. On new campaigns with no history
- B. On campaigns with strong CVR history where you want Amazon to bid more on Top of Search
- C. Never
- D. Only on Auto campaigns

Answer: B

Why: Dynamic up/down uses your conversion history to raise bids on high-converting placements. Without history, it overspends.

Q3. [Applied] What does a Top of Search placement modifier of +50% do to a \$1.00 bid?

- A. Always charges \$1.50 per click
- B. Allows Amazon to bid up to \$1.50 when competing for Top of Search placement
- C. Charges \$1.00 plus 50% fee
- D. Doubles the bid to \$2.00

Answer: B

Why: Modifiers set a ceiling, not a fixed price. Amazon bids up to that ceiling when competing for that placement, but you still pay second-price (next bid + \$0.01).

Q4. [Foundational] What is required to run Sponsored Brands?

- A. 100+ reviews
- B. Brand Registry with an active trademark
- C. Vendor Central account
- D. \$50K monthly ad spend

Answer: B

Why: Brand Registry is the gate for SB, SD custom creative, and Brand Stores. It requires an active registered trademark.

Q5. [Advanced] A new brand in year 1 should allocate roughly what % of budget to Sponsored Products?

- A. 30%
- B. 50%
- C. 70%
- D. 90%

Answer: C

Why: Year 1 brands need SP to drive direct conversion and discovery. SB and SD matter more in year 2+ when awareness goals kick in.

Teaching Guide

Suggested delivery time: 40 min lecture + 30 min live console demo

Talking Points

- Open with the funnel map (Awareness > Consideration > Conversion) and place each ad type on it.
- Walk through Auto campaign match types with real examples from a search term report.
- Demo the three bidding strategies side by side with the same campaign settings.
- Show placement modifiers in the console - this is the most-clicked button in optimization.
- End with budget allocation by maturity - it gives trainees a concrete starting framework.

Live-Demo Checklist

- Open Campaign Manager and create a new SP Auto campaign live.
- Show the bidding strategy dropdown and explain each option.
- Show the placement modifier UI and apply a +25% Top of Search modifier.
- Open an existing SB campaign to show the creative requirements (headline, logo, products).
- Open an SD campaign to show audience targeting options.

Discussion Prompts

- If you had to launch one ad type for a brand-new product with zero reviews, which would you pick and why?
- What is one scenario where Dynamic bids up/down would hurt you?
- Why does a mature brand allocate 25% of budget to DSP while a new brand allocates 0%?

Handout Summary

DEFINITION

Amazon has four main ad types: Sponsored Products (search-based, no Brand Registry needed), Sponsored Brands (top-of-search brand ads, requires Brand Registry), Sponsored Display (display network with audience targeting), and Sponsored TV (streaming TV video ads). DSP is a separate platform for cross-web display/video/audio.

KEY FORMULA

Effective bid with placement modifier = base bid x (1 + modifier%). You still pay second-price, so actual CPC = min(effective bid, next bid + \$0.01).

On-the-Job Checklist

- I can name the four Auto match types and what each targets.
- I know which bidding strategy to use for new vs. mature campaigns.
- I know what placement modifiers do and the maximum allowed boost (900%).
- I know that Brand Registry is required for SB and SD custom creative.

4 Targeting & Match Types

Match types control how closely a shopper's search must match your keyword for your ad to show. Get this wrong and you'll either waste spend on irrelevant searches (Broad too loose) or miss scale opportunities (Exact too tight). This is one of the most-tested concepts in the certification exam - learn it cold.

4.1 Keyword Match Types

Broad match - mechanics, risk profile, when to use

Broad match triggers your ad when a shopper searches your keyword in any order, plus related terms. If you bid on 'yoga mat' Broad, your ad can show for 'thick yoga mat', 'mat for yoga practice', 'exercise mat yoga', and even 'pilates mat' (Amazon's discretion). Broad is the loosest match type - highest reach, highest irrelevance risk. Use it for discovery in Broad campaigns, and always pair it with a strong negative keyword list.

Phrase match - mechanics, use cases

Phrase match triggers when a shopper searches your keyword in the exact order, but with words before or after. If you bid on 'yoga mat' Phrase, your ad can show for 'extra thick yoga mat', 'yoga mat for beginners', 'best yoga mat 2024'. It will NOT show for 'mat for yoga' (wrong order). Phrase is the middle ground - more controlled than Broad, more flexible than Exact. Most harvesting pipelines flow Broad -> Phrase -> Exact.

Exact match - mechanics, use cases

Exact match triggers only when a shopper searches your keyword with no extra words (Amazon does allow minor variations like plurals and close misspellings as of recent updates). If you bid on 'yoga mat' Exact, your ad shows for 'yoga mat' and 'yoga mats' but not 'thick yoga mat'. Exact has the highest CVR and lowest wasted spend. Use it for proven converters harvested from Broad/Phrase/Auto.

Match type migration strategy

The classic harvesting pipeline: Auto -> Broad -> Phrase -> Exact. New search terms appear in Auto, get added to Broad if relevant, get promoted to Phrase once they show consistent CTR, and finally to Exact once they show consistent conversion. At each promotion, add the term as a negative in the source campaign to prevent cannibalization. Covered in depth in section 5.3.

4.2 Product Targeting

ASIN targeting (own products, competitor products)

ASIN targeting puts your ad on a specific product's detail page. Target your own ASINs to cross-sell (shoppers viewing Product A see ads for Product B). Target competitor ASINs to conquest (shoppers viewing Competitor X see your ad). ASIN targeting is powerful because the shopper is already in purchase intent - they're on a product page, not browsing. CVR can be 2-3x higher than keyword targeting for the right ASINs.

Category targeting with refinements

Category targeting puts your ad across an entire Amazon category (e.g., 'all yoga mats'). Refinements let you narrow: price range (target products priced higher than yours, so shoppers see a cheaper alternative), brand (target specific competitor brands), star rating (target products with fewer than 4 stars, so your 4.5-star product stands out), Prime eligibility. Refinements turn a blunt instrument into a precise one.

Competitor conquering tactics and ethics/policy boundaries

Conquering = bidding on competitor brand names and ASINs. It's legal and Amazon allows it, but tread carefully: don't use competitor trademarks in your ad copy (policy violation), don't make false comparison claims, and be ready for them to conquer you back. The ethical line is targeting the competitor's traffic (fine) vs. impersonating the competitor (not fine).

4.3 Audience Targeting (SD/DSP)

Remarketing audiences

Remarketing shows ads to shoppers who already interacted with your brand - viewed a product, added to cart but didn't buy, or bought in the past. These audiences have 5-10x higher CVR than cold traffic. Always run a remarketing SD campaign once you have product page views (usually 2-4 weeks after launch).

Lifestyle & in-market segments

Amazon builds audiences from shopper behavior. **In-market** audiences are shoppers actively researching a category in the last 7-30 days (e.g., 'in-market for yoga mats').

Lifestyle audiences are shoppers whose purchase history suggests a lifestyle (e.g., 'fitness enthusiasts' = people who buy yoga mats, supplements, activewear regularly). These are powerful for awareness and consideration campaigns.

Amazon-exclusive audience signals

Amazon's biggest advantage over Google/Meta is its first-party purchase data. Amazon knows what shoppers actually bought, not just what they clicked on. This means audience targeting can be based on actual purchase behavior ('shoppers who bought yoga mats in the last 90 days') rather than inferred interest. Use these signals for SD and DSP campaigns to find lookalike shoppers.

4.4 Auto-Targeting Categories

Close / Loose / Substitutes / Complements explained operationally

Close Match: search terms closely related to your product (e.g., 'yoga mat' for your yoga mat). Highest CVR of Auto match types. **Loose Match:** broadly related terms (e.g., 'exercise mat'). Lower CVR but more reach. **Substitutes:** shoppers viewing competitor products similar to yours. Useful for conquering discovery. **Complements:** shoppers viewing products often bought with yours (e.g., 'yoga block' if you sell mats). Useful for cross-sell discovery.

Using auto campaigns as keyword discovery engines

Auto's real job is discovery, not performance. Set bids low (10-30% below your Manual Exact bids), let it run for 2-4 weeks, then mine the Search Term Report for high-converting terms. Promote those terms to Manual Exact and add them as negatives in Auto. Over 3-6 months, your Auto campaign should shrink in importance as your Manual campaigns absorb the proven winners.

TRAINING LAYER

Learning Aid

Key Terms

Broad match: Triggers ad for keyword in any order plus related terms. Highest reach, highest irrelevance risk.

Phrase match: Triggers ad for keyword in exact order with words before/after. Middle ground.

Exact match: Triggers ad for keyword alone (plus plurals/misspellings). Highest CVR, lowest waste.

Conquesting: Bidding on competitor brand terms and ASINs to steal their traffic.

COMMON MISTAKES

New strategists put harvested Exact keywords into Broad campaigns. This causes the Broad campaign to cannibalize the Exact campaign - same keyword, two bids, you compete against yourself.

WORKED EXAMPLE

You bid on "yoga mat" Broad at \$0.40. Search Term Report shows it triggered for "yoga mat thick" (3 orders), "yoga mat for kids" (0 orders, irrelevant), "yoga mat cleaner" (0 orders, wrong product). You add "yoga mat for kids" and "yoga mat cleaner" as negative Phrase in Broad. You add "yoga mat thick" as Exact in your Exact campaign at \$1.20 bid. You also add "yoga mat thick" as negative Exact in Broad to prevent cannibalization.

Quiz: Test Your Understanding

Q1. [Foundational] You bid on "yoga mat" Broad. Which search will NOT trigger your ad?

- A. thick yoga mat
- B. yoga mat for beginners
- C. mat for yoga
- D. All of these can trigger

Answer: D

Why: Broad match allows any order plus related terms. All three searches can trigger Broad "yoga mat". Use negatives to filter.

Q2. [Applied] You bid on "yoga mat" Phrase. Which search will trigger your ad?

- A. mat for yoga
- B. yoga exercise mat
- C. extra thick yoga mat
- D. yoga mats review

Answer: C

Why: Phrase requires "yoga mat" in exact order. "extra thick yoga mat" contains "yoga mat" in order. "mat for yoga" has wrong order. "yoga mats" plural is usually allowed but "yoga exercise mat" breaks the phrase.

Q3. [Applied] What is the correct harvesting pipeline?

- A. Exact -> Phrase -> Broad -> Auto
- B. Auto -> Broad -> Phrase -> Exact
- C. Broad -> Exact -> Phrase -> Auto
- D. Auto -> Exact -> Phrase -> Broad

Answer: B

Why: Discovery starts loose (Auto/Broad) and gets tighter as terms prove themselves, ending in Exact for top converters.

Q4. [Applied] You target Competitor ASIN XYZ. Your ad will appear where?

- A. In search results for XYZ's brand name
- B. On the product detail page for XYZ
- C. On Amazon's homepage
- D. In email campaigns Amazon sends

Answer: B

Why: ASIN targeting shows your ad on that product's detail page - the shopper is already in purchase intent.

Q5. [Advanced] What is cannibalization and how do you prevent it?

- A. When two of your ads compete for the same placement; prevent with portfolio budgets
- B. When the same keyword is bidded in multiple campaigns, causing you to compete against yourself; prevent with negative keywords in source campaigns
- C. When Amazon steals your budget; cannot be prevented
- D. When organic cannibalizes paid; prevent by lowering ad spend

Answer: B

Why: Cannibalization is bidding on the same keyword in multiple campaigns. Fix by adding the keyword as negative in source campaigns when promoting it to a tighter match type.

Teaching Guide

Suggested delivery time: 35 min lecture + 25 min hands-on exercise

Talking Points

- Open with a Venn diagram of Broad > Phrase > Exact - the visual makes the concept click.
- Walk through the harvesting pipeline as a flowchart on the whiteboard.
- Show real Search Term Report data from a sample Auto campaign and have the class call out which terms to promote vs. negative.
- Demo ASIN targeting live - show how to find a competitor ASIN and target it.
- End with cannibalization - it is the most common silent budget leak in mismanaged accounts.

Live-Demo Checklist

- Open an Auto campaign and click into Search Term Report.
- Sort by orders descending and identify top converters.
- Open a new Exact campaign and add one harvested term.
- Return to Auto campaign and add the same term as a negative keyword.
- Open a Product Targeting campaign and show ASIN targeting UI.

Discussion Prompts

- Why does Broad match have the lowest CVR of the three match types?
- If you discovered a high-converting Broad search term, what are the exact 3 steps you would take?
- Why is cannibalization a silent killer - what does the symptom look like in reports?

Handout Summary

DEFINITION

Match types control how closely a shopper's search must match your keyword for your ad to trigger. Broad = loosest (any order, related terms). Phrase = middle (exact order, words before/after). Exact = tightest (keyword alone). The harvesting pipeline promotes winners from loose to tight, with negative keywords preventing cannibalization.

KEY FORMULA

Cannibalization prevention rule: When promoting search term X from Campaign A to Campaign B, immediately add X as negative in Campaign A.

On-the-Job Checklist

- I can describe Broad, Phrase, and Exact in one sentence each.
- I know the harvesting pipeline order (Auto -> Broad -> Phrase -> Exact).
- I know how to prevent cannibalization when promoting terms.
- I can identify when to use ASIN targeting vs. keyword targeting.

5 Keyword Research & Search Term Mining

Keywords are the fuel. Without good keywords, no amount of bid optimization will save you. This section covers the research workflow, the tools, and the harvesting pipeline that turns raw search data into high-converting Exact campaigns.

5.1 Research Methodology

Seed keyword generation

Start with seed keywords - the obvious terms that describe your product. Brainstorm 10-20 obvious ones ('yoga mat', 'exercise mat', 'pilates mat'). Then check competitor listings - their titles and bullets reveal the keywords they're targeting. Finally, use Amazon autocomplete: type 'yoga mat ' into the Amazon search bar and see what suggestions appear ('yoga mat thick', 'yoga mat non slip', 'yoga mat extra wide'). Each suggestion is a real search.

Search term report mining workflow

Once campaigns are running, the Search Term Report becomes your most valuable data source. Pull it weekly, sort by spend descending, and review every term that spent more than ~\$10. For each, decide: **Exact** (converts well, promote to Exact campaign), **Negative** (irrelevant, add as negative), or **Watch** (need more data, leave it). This weekly ritual is the single highest-leverage activity in PPC management.

Reverse ASIN lookup (tool-based)

Tools like Helium 10 Cerebro reverse-engineer which keywords a competitor ASIN ranks for. Input a top competitor ASIN, get a list of keywords they're getting traffic from. Use this to seed your own keyword list - if they're ranking for it and converting, you probably can too.

Customer search term vs. backend search term distinction

Customer search terms are what shoppers type in the Amazon search bar - these appear in the Search Term Report. **Backend search terms** are hidden keywords you enter in Seller Central (the 'Keywords' field) that help Amazon understand your product but don't appear visibly. Both matter - backend terms influence Auto campaign targeting, so optimize them.

5.2 Keyword Research Tools

Helium 10 (Cerebro, Magnet, Search Term reports)

Helium 10 is the most popular all-in-one toolset. **Cerebro** does reverse ASIN lookup. **Magnet** generates keyword ideas from a seed. **Search Term reports** (paid tier) pull search volume estimates. Pricing is \$39-\$229/month depending on tier. For most agencies, the \$79 or \$129 tier is sufficient.

Other tools landscape

Jungle Scout - similar to Helium 10, popular with brand owners. **SellerApp** - good for keyword research and analytics. **Perpetua** - bid automation focused, owned by Sinobull. **Pacvue** - enterprise-grade, used by big brands. **Teikametrics** - bid automation with Flywheel product. Each has strengths; deep comparison in section 17.

Free/native methods (Brand Analytics search query performance)

Brand Analytics (free for Brand Registry sellers) includes the Search Query Performance report, which shows the actual search terms shoppers used to find your products, with click and conversion data. This is first-party data from Amazon - more reliable than third-party tools. Always check this report first before paying for tools.

5.3 Search Term Harvesting Workflow

Threshold rules for promoting a search term

Don't promote every term that converts once. Use threshold rules to avoid statistical noise. Common thresholds: **2+ orders** within 30 days, **ACOS below 30%**, **CVR above 8%**. If a term hits all three, promote to Exact. If it hits one or two, watch for another 2 weeks. If it doesn't convert after 30 clicks, add as negative.

Harvest to Exact campaign pipeline

Workflow: (1) Pull Search Term Report weekly. (2) Identify terms meeting thresholds. (3) Add as Exact keyword in your Exact campaign. (4) Set starting bid at the historical CPC of the source term plus 20% (to win the more competitive Exact auction). (5) Add as negative Exact in the source Auto/Broad campaign to prevent cannibalization. (6) Monitor for 2 weeks, adjust bid based on performance.

Negative-out process for harvested terms

The negative-out step is critical and often forgotten. If you promote 'yoga mat thick' from Broad to Exact but leave it active in Broad, both campaigns will bid on it - you compete against yourself, driving up your effective CPC. Always add the term as negative in the source campaign the same day you promote it.

5.4 Long-Tail vs. Head Term Strategy

Different bidding/budget approaches by keyword length

Head terms (1-2 words, e.g., 'yoga mat') have high search volume, high competition, high CPC (\$1-3+), and lower CVR (3-8%). **Long-tail terms** (3+ words, e.g., 'extra thick yoga mat for knee pain') have low search volume, low competition, low CPC (\$0.20-0.80), and higher CVR (10-20%). A mature account has both - head terms for scale, long-tail for efficiency.

Relevance scoring considerations

When evaluating a keyword, score it on relevance (1-5): does the search intent match your product? 'Yoga mat' for a yoga mat = 5. 'Exercise mat' for a yoga mat = 4 (close but broader). 'Camping mat' for a yoga mat = 2 (different use case). Score below 3 = skip or negative. Score 4-5 = candidate for Exact. This scoring prevents the trap of bidding on high-volume but low-relevance terms.

TRAINING LAYER

Learning Aid

Key Terms

Seed keyword: The obvious starting term you brainstorm before doing tool-based research.

Reverse ASIN lookup: Using a tool like Cerebro to find which keywords a competitor ASIN ranks for.

Search Term Report: Amazon native report showing actual shopper search queries that triggered your ads.

Long-tail term: 3+ word keyword with low volume, low competition, high CVR.

COMMON MISTAKES

Harvesting terms that converted once on small sample sizes. One conversion on 5 clicks is not statistically significant - it could be luck. Wait for 2+ conversions on 20+ clicks before promoting.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Auto campaign shows "yoga mat for knee pain" with 35 clicks, 5 orders, \$14 spend, \$145 ad sales. ACOS = 9.7%, CVR = 14.3%. Meets all thresholds. Promote to Exact at starting bid \$0.70 (auto CPC was \$0.40, +75% for Exact auction). Add as negative Exact in Auto.

Quiz: Test Your Understanding

Q1. [Foundational] What is the most reliable source of keyword data?

- A. Third-party tools like Helium 10
- B. Amazon's own Search Query Performance report in Brand Analytics
- C. Amazon autocomplete
- D. Competitor listings

Answer: B

Why: First-party data from Amazon is always more reliable than third-party estimates. Brand Analytics SQP is free for Brand Registry sellers.

Q2. [Applied] A search term has 1 conversion on 8 clicks. Should you promote it to Exact?

- A. Yes, immediately
- B. No, wait for at least 2 conversions on 20+ clicks for statistical significance
- C. Yes, but only if ACOS is below 20%
- D. No, never promote single-conversion terms

Answer: B

Why: 1 conversion on 8 clicks is a 12.5% CVR but on a tiny sample. Could be luck. Wait for more data before promoting.

Q3. [Applied] You promote "yoga mat thick" from Broad to Exact. What must you do the same day?

- A. Nothing - just leave it in Broad
- B. Add "yoga mat thick" as negative Exact in Broad to prevent cannibalization
- C. Increase Broad budget
- D. Pause the Broad campaign entirely

Answer: B

Why: Without negative-out, both campaigns bid on the same term and you compete against yourself, driving up CPC.

Q4. [Applied] Which is typically true of long-tail keywords vs. head terms?

- A. Higher volume, higher CPC, lower CVR
- B. Lower volume, lower CPC, higher CVR
- C. Higher volume, lower CPC, higher CVR
- D. Lower volume, higher CPC, lower CVR

Answer: B

Why: Long-tail keywords have lower competition (lower CPC) and more specific intent (higher CVR), but lower overall volume.

Q5. [Advanced] What does Helium 10 Cerebro do?

- A. Generates keyword ideas from a seed
- B. Reverse-engineers which keywords a competitor ASIN ranks for
- C. Automates bid management
- D. Builds brand stores

Answer: B

Why: Cerebro is the reverse ASIN lookup tool. Magnet is the seed-to-ideas generator. Both are Helium 10 products.

Teaching Guide

Suggested delivery time: 40 min lecture + 30 min hands-on keyword research

Talking Points

- Open with the fuel analogy - keywords are the fuel, bids are the spark.
- Walk through the seed -> autocomplete -> competitor listing workflow live on screen.
- Show a real Search Term Report and have the class call out which terms to promote vs. negative.
- Demo Helium 10 Cerebro if available - reverse ASIN lookup is the killer feature.
- End with statistical significance - the concept that saves accounts from chasing noise.

Live-Demo Checklist

- Open Brand Analytics > Search Query Performance.
- Pull the last 30 days of search terms for a sample product.
- Open Helium 10 Cerebro and run a reverse ASIN lookup on a competitor.
- Open the Search Term Report in Amazon Ads Console.
- Show the threshold-based decision process on 5 sample terms.

Discussion Prompts

- Why is "1 conversion on 5 clicks" not enough evidence to promote a term?
- What is the risk of bidding on high-volume head terms too early in a launch?
- How would you explain to a brand owner why long-tail keywords matter even though they have low search volume?

Handout Summary

DEFINITION

Keyword research is the systematic process of identifying, evaluating, and prioritizing the search terms shoppers use to find products like yours. The harvesting pipeline promotes high-performing search terms from Auto/Broad campaigns into Exact campaigns, with negative keywords preventing cannibalization.

KEY FORMULA

Harvesting thresholds: 2+ orders in 30 days AND ACOS < 30% AND CVR > 8%. Starting Exact bid = source campaign CPC x 1.20.

On-the-Job Checklist

- I can generate seed keywords from brainstorming, autocomplete, and competitor listings.
- I know to check Brand Analytics SQP (free, first-party) before paying for tools.
- I can apply the harvesting thresholds to decide which terms to promote.
- I always add harvested terms as negative in the source campaign the same day.

6 Bidding Strategies & Bid Management

Bids determine whether your ad shows and where. Too low and you're invisible; too high and you burn margin. This section covers the math of bidding, the automation options, and the cadence of bid reviews.

6.1 Manual Bidding Fundamentals

Bid calculation formulas (break-even bid, target ACOS bid)

Two formulas drive every bid decision. **Break-even bid** = price x CVR x (1 - COGS ratio - target margin). If your product sells for \$30, CVR is 10%, COGS is \$12 (40%), and you want 20% margin, your break-even bid is $\$30 \times 0.10 \times (1 - 0.40 - 0.20) = \1.20 . Bidding above this loses money; bidding below makes money. **Target ACOS bid** = price x CVR x (1 - target ACOS). With target ACOS of 25%, that's $\$30 \times 0.10 \times 0.75 = \2.25 . Use this as your ceiling bid for proven keywords.

EXAMPLE

Product price: \$29.99. CVR: 12%. Target ACOS: 25%. Target ACOS bid = $\$29.99 \times 0.12 \times (1 - 0.25) = \2.70 . If your actual CPC is \$1.50, you're well under target. If CPC creeps to \$2.80, you're losing money on that keyword and need to either lower the bid or pause it.

Starting bid strategy for new keywords

For a brand-new keyword with no CVR history, you have two options. **Amazon suggested bid**: Amazon shows a suggested bid range (e.g., \$0.80-\$1.50) based on recent auction data. Start at the low end and increase if no impressions. **Custom formula**: Use a conservative CVR assumption (5% for new products, 8-10% for mature products) and calculate target ACOS bid. Custom is more disciplined; suggested is faster. Most strategists blend: start with custom formula, sanity-check against suggested bid, and adjust.

6.2 Dynamic & Rule-Based Bidding

Amazon's dynamic bid settings explained

Covered briefly in section 3.1 - here's the operational detail. **Dynamic down only** means Amazon can lower your effective bid by up to 100% for placements unlikely to convert. This is the safe default - you never pay more than your set bid. **Dynamic up and down** means Amazon can also RAISE your effective bid by up to 100% for placements likely to convert (mostly Top of Search). This can 2x your CPC, so use it only on campaigns with proven high CVR. **Fixed bids** means Amazon uses your exact bid with no adjustments - useful for clean data collection in new campaigns.

Third-party bid automation logic

Tools like Perpetua, Pacvue, and Teikametrics automate bid changes based on rules you set: 'keep ACOS under 25%', 'maintain Top of Search 40% of impressions', etc. They pull data hourly and adjust bids daily. Pros: saves time, removes emotion, scales to hundreds of keywords. Cons: monthly cost (\$200-\$2000+), learning curve, and they can amplify bad decisions if rules are wrong. Start manual, automate once you understand the rules.

Dayparting bid adjustments

Dayparting = adjusting bids by time of day. If your yoga mats convert best between 7-10 PM (when people relax after work), you can bid up during those hours and down overnight. Amazon's native console doesn't support dayparting - you need third-party tools. The lift is typically 5-15% efficiency gain, so worth it for accounts over \$10K/month spend.

6.3 Bid Adjustment Cadence

Daily / weekly / monthly review rhythms

Daily (5-10 min): check budget pacing, pause campaigns that ran out of budget, scan for anomalies. **Weekly** (1-2 hours): review search term report, adjust bids on top 20 keywords by spend, harvest new terms. **Monthly** (3-4 hours): deep-dive analysis, portfolio review, strategic shifts (e.g., launch a new Exact campaign for harvested terms). This rhythm scales to ~\$50K/month spend; above that, add a bi-weekly mid-cycle review.

Statistical significance thresholds before adjusting

Don't change a bid based on 1 day of data. Wait for at least 30 clicks or 3 conversions on a keyword before judging its performance. Below that, the data is noise. For low-volume long-tail keywords, you may need 60-90 days to accumulate enough data. Patience is a competitive advantage in PPC - premature optimization is the #1 cause of self-inflicted underperformance.

6.4 Placement Bid Modifiers

Top of Search modifier strategy

Top of Search (TOS) is the holy grail - positions 1-4 on page 1 of search results. TOS gets ~3-5x the click volume of Rest of Search and typically 1.5-2x the CVR because shoppers trust top results. Start with TOS modifier at +25% for proven Exact keywords. If TOS share is below 30% of impressions after a week, increase to +50%. Above 60% TOS share, you may be overpaying - dial back.

Product Page placement modifier strategy

Product Page placement = your ad on other products' detail pages. CVR is typically lower than TOS (shoppers are already looking at a different product) but CPC is also lower. Default: leave Product Page modifier at 0%. Increase to +25% only for ASIN-targeted campaigns where you specifically want to conquest competitor pages.

TRAINING LAYER

Learning Aid

Key Terms

Break-even bid: Max bid before you lose money on a sale, factoring price, CVR, COGS, and target margin.

Target ACOS bid: Bid that achieves your target ACOS at current CVR: $\text{price} \times \text{CVR} \times (1 - \text{target ACOS})$.

Dayparting: Adjusting bids by time of day to concentrate spend in high-converting hours.

Statistical significance: Enough data to trust a metric; for bids, typically 30+ clicks or 3+ conversions.

COMMON MISTAKES

Adjusting bids daily based on yesterday's data. One day of data is noise - wait at least 7 days and 30 clicks before judging performance.

WORKED EXAMPLE

A keyword has 5 clicks and 1 conversion in 2 days. ACOS looks great at 18%. Don't raise the bid yet - sample is too small. Wait until 30+ clicks accumulate. After 2 weeks: 35 clicks, 4 orders, \$42 spend, \$120 sales. ACOS = 35%. Now you have signal: lower bid by 15%.

Quiz: Test Your Understanding

Q1. [Applied] Product price \$30, CVR 10%, COGS 40%, target margin 20%. What is the break-even bid?

- A. \$0.60
- B. \$1.20
- C. \$1.80
- D. \$2.40

Answer: B

Why: Break-even = price x CVR x (1 - COGS - margin) = \$30 x 0.10 x (1 - 0.40 - 0.20) = \$30 x 0.10 x 0.40 = \$1.20.

Q2. [Foundational] When should you use Dynamic bids up and down?

- A. For every new campaign
- B. Only for campaigns with strong CVR history
- C. Never
- D. Only for Auto campaigns

Answer: B

Why: Dynamic up/down can 2x your CPC. Only enable on campaigns where conversion history proves the extra spend will pay off.

Q3. [Applied] How many clicks should you wait for before adjusting a keyword bid?

- A. 5 clicks
- B. 10 clicks
- C. 30 clicks (or 3 conversions)
- D. 100 clicks

Answer: C

Why: Below 30 clicks or 3 conversions, performance data is statistical noise. Adjusting now is gambling.

Q4. [Applied] A keyword has TOS share of 20% after a week with TOS modifier at +25%. What should you do?

- A. Decrease TOS modifier
- B. Increase TOS modifier to +50%
- C. Pause the keyword
- D. Nothing - 20% is fine

Answer: B

Why: 20% TOS share is low for an Exact keyword with +25% modifier. Bumping to +50% competes harder for TOS placement.

Q5. [Advanced] Why does dayparting typically yield only 5-15% efficiency gains?

- A. Because Amazon doesn't allow it
- B. Because most clicks happen evenly across hours; the lift is from concentrating spend in best hours
- C. Because third-party tools are imperfect
- D. Because dayparting is illegal in some countries

Answer: B

Why: Conversion rates do vary by hour but not dramatically. The lift comes from concentrating spend in slightly better hours, not from a magic time slot.

Teaching Guide

Suggested delivery time: 35 min lecture + 25 min calculation practice

Talking Points

- Open with the bid-as-a-ceiling concept - you rarely pay your full bid, so bid your target and let the auction sort it out.
- Walk through break-even and target ACOS bid formulas with a calculator on screen.
- Demo the three bidding strategies on a real campaign.
- Show TOS modifier UI and the TOS share metric in placement report.
- End with statistical significance - it is the most under-taught concept in PPC.

Live-Demo Checklist

- Open Campaign Manager and find a campaign with 30+ days of data.
- Show the bid input and bidding strategy dropdown.
- Open Placement report and show TOS share data.
- Adjust a TOS modifier live and explain expected impact.
- Show how to read the Search Term Report to identify bid candidates.

Discussion Prompts

- Why is patience a competitive advantage in PPC?
- If your target ACOS bid is \$2.25 but CPC is currently \$1.50, should you lower your bid?
- How would you explain statistical significance to an impatient client who wants daily bid changes?

Handout Summary

DEFINITION

Bidding is the process of setting the maximum you're willing to pay per click. Two key formulas: break-even bid (max bid before losing money) and target ACOS bid (bid that achieves target ACOS). Bid adjustment cadence is daily for pacing, weekly for top keywords, monthly for strategy - always wait for statistical significance (30+ clicks or 3+ conversions).

KEY FORMULA

Break-even bid = price x CVR x (1 - COGS% - target margin%). Target ACOS bid = price x CVR x (1 - target ACOS).

On-the-Job Checklist

- I can calculate break-even bid and target ACOS bid for any product.
- I know which bidding strategy to use for new vs. mature campaigns.
- I never adjust bids before 30 clicks or 3 conversions accumulate.
- I know how to set and tune TOS placement modifiers.

7 Budget Management & Pacing

Budget is the air supply for your campaigns. Run out and you lose the day's sales. Over-budget and you waste money on inefficient clicks. This section covers allocation frameworks, pacing diagnostics, and seasonal planning.

7.1 Budget Allocation Frameworks

Top-down (company ad spend %) vs. bottom-up (per-SKU target)

Top-down: brand owner says 'we have \$50K/month for ads'. You allocate across campaigns based on historical performance - hero SKUs get 60%, mid-tier get 30%, long-tail get 10%.

Bottom-up: you calculate per-SKU target spend based on margin and growth goals - SKU A needs \$5K/month to hit 15% ACOS at \$30K sales, SKU B needs \$3K/month, etc. - and total them up. Bottom-up is more disciplined but requires per-SKU P&L; data; top-down is faster but can starve profitable SKUs.

Portfolio-level budget caps vs. campaign-level

Portfolio caps set a hard ceiling on total spend across all campaigns in a portfolio. Useful when a brand has a fixed monthly budget - the cap prevents over-spend on high-traffic days. Campaign-level budgets let you allocate granularly but don't prevent total over-spend. Best practice: use both - portfolio cap as the safety net, campaign-level budgets as the primary allocation lever.

7.2 Pacing & 'Ran Out of Budget' Diagnostics

Identifying and fixing budget-starved high performers

A 'budget-starved high performer' is a campaign that consistently runs out of budget by noon but has great ACOS. Symptoms: budget hits 100% before 6 PM, lost impression share > 30%, ACOS well below target. Fix: raise budget by 30-50% and watch for 3 days. If ACOS stays low and budget still runs out, raise again. If ACOS climbs above target, you've found the ceiling - leave budget where it is.

EXAMPLE

Your Exact campaign has \$30/day budget. It runs out by 2 PM daily. Lost impression share is 45%. ACOS is 14% (target is 25%). Raise budget to \$50/day. After 3 days: budget runs out at 8 PM, lost impression share drops to 12%, ACOS stays at 16%. Raise to \$70/day. Now budget paces through midnight, lost impression share is 5%, ACOS is 19%. Stop raising - you've found optimal budget.

Dayparting to control pacing

If you can't raise budget (e.g., portfolio cap is hit), use dayparting to concentrate spend in high-converting hours. Lower bids 20-30% overnight (10 PM - 6 AM) when CVR is typically low. Raise bids 10-15% during peak hours (7-10 PM for most consumer products). This squeezes more sales out of the same budget.

7.3 Seasonal Budget Planning

Q4/Prime Day/Black Friday scaling models

Q4 (Oct-Dec) typically sees 2-4x normal traffic for most consumer categories. Plan budgets accordingly: October = 1.5x baseline, November = 2.5x (Black Friday/Cyber Monday spike), December = 2x (holiday shopping). Prime Day (usually July) needs 3-5x baseline for the 2-day event. Pre-event: build budget 2 weeks ahead to let algorithms calibrate. Post-event: scale back to 1.2x for a week, then return to baseline.

Post-event budget wind-down strategy

Don't crash budgets back to baseline the day after an event. Shopper behavior is still elevated for 5-7 days post-event as people browse deals they missed or buy gifts they delayed. Ramp down gradually: Day 1-3 post-event at 1.5x, Day 4-7 at 1.2x, then return to baseline. Sudden budget cuts trigger Amazon's algorithm to deprioritize your campaigns, and it takes weeks to recover.

TRAINING LAYER

Learning Aid

Key Terms

Top-down budgeting: Allocate from a fixed total based on historical performance.

Bottom-up budgeting: Calculate per-SKU target spend based on margin and growth goals.

Budget-starved campaign: High-performing campaign that runs out of budget before day end.

Lost impression share: % of impressions you missed because budget ran out or bid was too low.

COMMON MISTAKES

Crashing budgets back to baseline the day after Prime Day. Amazon's algorithm deprioritizes campaigns with sudden spend drops, and recovery takes weeks. Ramp down gradually instead.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Baseline spend: \$100/day. Prime Day arrives. Pre-event (Day -14): raise to \$250/day. Prime Day (Day 0-1): \$500/day. Post-event Day 1-3: \$200/day. Post-event Day 4-7: \$130/day. Day 8+: return to \$100/day. Total Prime Day week spend: ~\$2,800 vs. baseline \$700. Lifted sales 4-5x during event.

Quiz: Test Your Understanding

Q1. [Applied] What is the symptom of a budget-starved high performer?

- A. ACOS above target
- B. Budget runs out before day end AND lost impression share > 30% AND ACOS below target
- C. High CPC
- D. Low CTR

Answer: B

Why: Budget running out + high lost impression share + low ACOS = the campaign could profitably spend more if budget allowed.

Q2. [Applied] A campaign runs out of \$30/day by 2 PM with 14% ACOS (target 25%). What should you do?

- A. Lower budget
- B. Raise budget by 30-50% and watch for 3 days
- C. Pause the campaign
- D. Lower bids

Answer: B

Why: The campaign is performing well below target ACOS but can't spend more. Raising budget tests whether performance holds at higher spend.

Q3. [Applied] How should you scale budgets for Q4 vs. baseline?

- A. Same as baseline
- B. October 1.5x, November 2.5x, December 2x baseline
- C. 10x baseline all of Q4
- D. Cut budgets - Q4 is too competitive

Answer: B

Why: Q4 sees 2-4x traffic for most categories. Scaling gradually lets algorithms calibrate and captures the traffic spike.

Q4. [Advanced] Why ramp down budgets gradually after Prime Day instead of crashing back?

- A. Amazon doesn't allow sudden cuts
- B. Algorithm deprioritizes campaigns with sudden spend drops; recovery takes weeks
- C. It doesn't matter
- D. To keep agency fees high

Answer: B

Why: Sudden spend drops signal to Amazon's algorithm that the campaign is less active, reducing its priority in auctions. Gradual ramp-down preserves momentum.

Q5. [Advanced] When is bottom-up budgeting more useful than top-down?

- A. When you don't have per-SKU P&L; data
- B. When you have detailed per-SKU margin and growth goals and want disciplined allocation
- C. Always
- D. Never

Answer: B

Why: Bottom-up requires per-SKU data but produces more disciplined budgets that align spend to profitability per SKU.

Teaching Guide

Suggested delivery time: 30 min lecture + 20 min budget exercise

Talking Points

- Open with the air supply analogy - budget feeds campaigns like oxygen feeds fire.
- Walk through top-down vs. bottom-up with a sample brand.
- Demo the budget-starved diagnostic with real lost impression share data.
- Show Q4 scaling calendar on a whiteboard.
- End with post-event wind-down - it is the most violated rule in seasonal planning.

Live-Demo Checklist

- Open Campaign Manager and sort by "% budget spent".
- Identify campaigns hitting 100% before day end.
- Open Placement report and show lost impression share metric.
- Raise a budget live and explain the 3-day observation window.
- Show the historical Q4 spend pattern from a prior year.

Discussion Prompts

- Why is gradual ramp-down counterintuitive but correct?
- If you had to choose, would you rather over-budget or under-budget during Q4?
- How would you explain lost impression share to a non-technical brand owner?

Handout Summary**DEFINITION**

Budget management is the practice of allocating spend across campaigns and pacing that spend across time. Two approaches: top-down (allocate from fixed total) and bottom-up (calculate per-SKU target). Budget-starved high performers should get more budget; seasonal events need pre-event ramp and post-event gradual wind-down.

KEY FORMULA

Seasonal scaling: October = 1.5x baseline, November = 2.5x (BFCM spike), December = 2x. Prime Day = 3-5x for 2 days. Post-event wind-down: 1.5x for 3 days, 1.2x for 4 days, then baseline.

On-the-Job Checklist

- I can identify budget-starved campaigns from lost impression share data.
- I know to raise budgets by 30-50% increments and observe for 3 days.
- I plan Q4 and Prime Day scaling 2 weeks ahead.
- I ramp down budgets gradually after events, never crash back to baseline.

8 Placements & Placement Optimization

Where your ad appears on Amazon determines everything - click volume, CPC, CVR. This section covers the three placement types and how to diagnose placement performance.

8.1 Placement Types Explained

Top of Search, Rest of Search, Product Detail Pages

Top of Search (TOS) = positions 1-4 on page 1 of search results. Highest visibility, highest CPC, highest CVR. **Rest of Search (ROS)** = positions 5+ on page 1 and beyond. Lower CPC, lower CVR, but lower competition. **Product Detail Pages (PDP)** = your ad appearing on other products' pages (under 'Sponsored products related to this item' or carousel). Lowest CVR of the three because the shopper is already looking at a different product, but also lowest CPC.

Placement performance benchmarking by campaign stage

For new campaigns (first 4 weeks), expect TOS to be 30-40% of impressions, ROS 50-60%, PDP 5-15%. For mature Exact campaigns with TOS modifiers, TOS can climb to 60-70%. If TOS is below 20% on a campaign where you've set +50% TOS modifier, something is wrong - either your bid is too low to compete for TOS, or your relevance score is weak.

8.2 Placement Reporting & Diagnosis

Where to find placement-level data

Open any campaign in the console, click the 'Placements' tab (or download the Placement Report from Reports > Advertising Reports). You'll see impressions, clicks, spend, sales, ACOS, and TOS share broken down by placement. This report is your primary placement diagnostic tool.

Common placement-based decisions

TOS share low + ACOS below target: raise TOS modifier to compete harder for TOS placements. **TOS share high + ACOS above target:** TOS is too expensive for this keyword; lower TOS modifier or shift budget to ROS. **PDP share high + ACOS bad:** pause Product Targeting campaigns or lower PDP modifier. **PDP share high + ACOS good:** scale Product Targeting campaigns - you've found a winner.

TRAINING LAYER

Learning Aid

Key Terms

Top of Search (TOS): Search results positions 1-4 on page 1; highest visibility and CVR.

Rest of Search (ROS): Search results positions 5+; lower CPC, lower CVR.

Product Detail Page (PDP): Ad on other products' pages; lowest CVR but lowest CPC.

TOS share: % of your impressions that landed in TOS placement.

COMMON MISTAKES

Setting TOS modifier at +900% (max) on day 1 of a new campaign. Without CVR history, Amazon can't optimize and you may overpay massively. Start at +25%, observe for a week, then tune.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Exact campaign for "yoga mat" has TOS modifier +25%. After 7 days: TOS share 18%, ROS 60%, PDP 22%. ACOS at TOS = 15%, ROS = 28%, PDP = 40%. TOS is profitable but you're under-winning it. Raise TOS modifier to +50%. After another week: TOS share 35%, ACOS at TOS = 17%. Better.

Quiz: Test Your Understanding

Q1. [Foundational] Which placement typically has the highest CVR?

- A. Rest of Search
- B. Product Detail Pages
- C. Top of Search
- D. They are equal

Answer: C

Why: TOS gets 1.5-2x the CVR of ROS because shoppers trust top results and click with higher intent.

Q2. [Applied] TOS share is 15% with TOS modifier at +25%. ACOS at TOS is 14% (target 25%). What should you do?

- A. Lower TOS modifier
- B. Raise TOS modifier to +50%
- C. Pause the campaign
- D. Nothing - 15% is fine

Answer: B

Why: TOS is profitable but under-winning. Raising modifier competes harder for the most profitable placement.

Q3. [Foundational] Where do you find placement-level performance data?

- A. Search Term Report
- B. Placement Report (Reports > Advertising Reports) or the Placements tab inside a campaign
- C. Brand Analytics
- D. Account Health dashboard

Answer: B

Why: The Placement Report breaks down impressions, clicks, spend, sales, and ACOS by TOS/ROS/PDP.

Q4. [Applied] A Product Targeting campaign has 70% PDP share and 40% ACOS (target 25%). What's the diagnosis?

- A. TOS is winning too much
- B. PDP is performing badly - pause or lower bids
- C. Raise TOS modifier
- D. Increase budget

Answer: B

Why: 70% PDP share with poor ACOS means PDP placement is wasting money. Either pause the campaign or lower PDP bids.

Q5. [Advanced] Why should you start TOS modifier at +25%, not +900% (max)?

- A. +900% is illegal
- B. Without CVR history, Amazon can't optimize and you may overpay massively
- C. +25% gives the same result
- D. Modifiers don't actually work

Answer: B

Why: Modifiers set a ceiling. High ceilings without relevance history lead to overpaying for placements that don't convert.

Teaching Guide

Suggested delivery time: 25 min lecture + 15 min placement report exercise

Talking Points

- Open with the TOS hierarchy - TOS is the holy grail, ROS is the workhorse, PDP is the supplement.
- Show the Placement Report live and walk through each column.
- Demo the TOS modifier UI and explain the ceiling concept.
- Walk through the 4 common placement-based decisions with real examples.
- End with the patience point - don't tune modifiers without a week of data.

Live-Demo Checklist

- Open a campaign and click the Placements tab.
- Show TOS share, ROS share, PDP share side by side.
- Compare ACOS by placement - show how TOS typically has best ACOS.

- Adjust a TOS modifier live (raise from +25% to +40%).
- Show the historical placement report from a 30-day window.

Discussion Prompts

- Why is PDP CVR typically lower than TOS CVR?
- If you could only optimize one placement metric, which would it be?
- How would you explain TOS modifier to a brand owner who has never run ads?

Handout Summary

DEFINITION

Amazon places Sponsored Products ads in three locations: Top of Search (positions 1-4 on page 1, highest CVR), Rest of Search (positions 5+, mid CPC), and Product Detail Pages (other products' pages, lowest CVR). Placement modifiers let you bid up to 900% more for TOS or PDP placements.

KEY FORMULA

Effective bid with placement modifier = base bid x (1 + modifier%). You still pay second-price, so actual CPC = min(effective bid, next bid + \$0.01).

On-the-Job Checklist

- I can identify TOS, ROS, and PDP placements on Amazon.com.
- I know where to find placement-level data in the console.
- I start TOS modifiers at +25% and tune based on data.
- I know to lower or pause campaigns with bad PDP ACOS.

9 Negative Keywords & Negation Strategy

Negatives are how you stop wasting money on irrelevant searches. Done right, they can cut wasted spend 20-40% with no impact on sales. Done wrong, they kill discovery. This section is about doing them right.

9.1 Negative Match Types

Negative Exact vs. Negative Phrase

Negative Exact blocks your ad from showing for that exact search term (with minor variation tolerance). Add 'yoga mat for kids' as Negative Exact and your ad will not show when someone searches that exact phrase. **Negative Phrase** blocks any search containing that phrase. Add 'kids' as Negative Phrase and your ad won't show for 'yoga mat for kids', 'kids yoga mat', 'yoga mat kids size'. Negative Phrase is broader but riskier - it can block relevant terms you didn't intend to block.

Negative Product Targeting

Just as you can negatively target keywords, you can negatively target ASINs. If you sell a premium yoga mat and don't want your ad showing on cheap competitor ASINs (because those shoppers won't convert), add those ASINs as negative product targets. Useful for keeping category-targeted campaigns focused on relevant products.

9.2 Negation Strategy by Campaign Structure

Cross-campaign negation

The most important negation pattern: when you harvest a term from Broad to Exact, add it as negative Exact in the Broad campaign. Otherwise both campaigns bid on the same term, you compete against yourself, and your effective CPC climbs. Same logic for Auto -> Manual and Phrase -> Exact promotions. Always negative-out the source campaign the same day you promote a term.

EXAMPLE

You bid on 'yoga mat' in Broad at \$0.40. You harvest 'yoga mat thick' to Exact at \$1.20. Without negative-out: both campaigns bid on 'yoga mat thick'. The Broad campaign might win some auctions at \$0.40, stealing impressions from your higher-converting Exact campaign. With negative-out: only the Exact campaign bids, and you win auctions at the right CPC for the right conversion.

Irrelevant/wasted-spend term identification workflow

Weekly workflow: (1) Pull Search Term Report. (2) Sort by spend descending. (3) For each term with 0 orders and 10+ clicks, decide: is it irrelevant? Add as Negative Exact. Is it relevant but early? Watch for another 2 weeks. Is it borderline? Add as Negative Phrase if the term contains a clear irrelevant modifier (e.g., 'cheap', 'free', 'how to'). (4) Track total wasted spend before and after to measure impact.

9.3 Common Negation Mistakes

Over-negating (killing discovery)

If you negative every term that doesn't convert in week 1, you kill the discovery pipeline. Some terms need 30+ clicks to convert. Negatives should target terms that are clearly irrelevant (wrong product, wrong intent), not terms that are relevant but early.

Negative conflicts

A negative conflict happens when you negative a term in one campaign that's an active positive target in another. Example: 'yoga mat' is your positive Exact keyword in Campaign A, but you accidentally added it as Negative Phrase in Campaign B. Now Campaign B won't show for 'yoga mat' even though you wanted it to. Audit negatives quarterly to catch these.

TRAINING LAYER

Learning Aid

Key Terms

Negative Exact: Blocks your ad from showing for that exact search term only.

Negative Phrase: Blocks any search containing that phrase; broader but riskier.

Cross-campaign negation: Adding a harvested term as negative in the source campaign to prevent cannibalization.

Negative conflict: Accidentally negating a term that is an active positive target elsewhere.

COMMON MISTAKES

Adding "yoga" as Negative Phrase in a yoga mat campaign. This blocks every search containing "yoga" - which is every relevant search. Use Negative Phrase carefully and prefer Negative Exact when possible.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Auto campaign shows "yoga mat review" with 25 clicks, 0 orders, \$10 spend. Shopper intent is research, not buy. Add "review" as Negative Phrase. This blocks "yoga mat review", "best yoga mat review 2024", "yoga mat comparison review" - all research intent. Saves ~\$40/month in wasted spend.

Quiz: Test Your Understanding

Q1. [Applied] You add "kids" as Negative Phrase. Which search will still trigger your ad?

- A. yoga mat for kids
- B. kids yoga mat
- C. yoga mat children
- D. All are blocked

Answer: C

Why: Negative Phrase "kids" blocks searches containing "kids". "yoga mat children" doesn't contain "kids" so it still triggers.

Q2. [Foundational] You harvest "yoga mat thick" from Broad to Exact. What MUST you do the same day?

- A. Increase Broad budget
- B. Add "yoga mat thick" as negative Exact in Broad
- C. Pause the Broad campaign
- D. Nothing

Answer: B

Why: Without negative-out, both campaigns bid on the same term and you compete against yourself, driving up CPC.

Q3. [Applied] A search term has 15 clicks and 0 orders. It is clearly irrelevant (wrong product). What do you do?

- A. Wait for more data
- B. Add as Negative Exact
- C. Lower your bid
- D. Add as a positive keyword

Answer: B

Why: Irrelevant terms should be negated immediately. Don't wait - 15 clicks of wasted spend is enough signal.

Q4. [Applied] What is the danger of over-negating?

- A. You save too much money
- B. You kill the discovery pipeline by negating terms that needed more time to convert
- C. Amazon penalizes you
- D. Nothing - more negatives is always better

Answer: B

Why: Some terms need 30+ clicks to convert. Negating everything that doesn't convert in week 1 kills future winners.

Q5. [Advanced] What is a negative conflict?

- A. Two negatives in the same campaign
- B. Negating a term that is an active positive target elsewhere
- C. A negative keyword that doesn't work
- D. A negation error in Amazon's system

Answer: B

Why: Conflicts happen when you accidentally block a term you wanted to target. Quarterly audits catch these.

Teaching Guide

Suggested delivery time: 25 min lecture + 20 min negation exercise

Talking Points

- Open with the wasted-spend framing - 20-40% of broad campaign spend goes to irrelevant terms.
- Walk through Negative Exact vs. Negative Phrase with Venn diagrams.
- Demo cross-campaign negation live - it is the most important pattern.
- Show a wasted-spend report and have the class call out which terms to negative.
- End with the over-negation warning - patience matters even in negation.

Live-Demo Checklist

- Open a Search Term Report sorted by spend descending.
- Filter to terms with 0 orders and 10+ clicks.
- Pick one irrelevant term and add as Negative Exact in the console.
- Pick one harvested term and add as negative in the source campaign.
- Show the negative keywords view inside a campaign to audit existing negatives.

Discussion Prompts

- Why is Negative Phrase riskier than Negative Exact?
- If you saw \$200/month in wasted spend on irrelevant terms, what would your negation workflow look like?
- How would you explain cross-campaign negation to a junior VA?

Handout Summary

DEFINITION

Negative keywords block your ad from showing for specific search terms. Negative Exact blocks the exact term; Negative Phrase blocks any search containing the phrase. Cross-campaign negation prevents cannibalization when harvesting terms between campaigns. Over-negating kills discovery.

KEY FORMULA

Wasted spend threshold for negation: 0 orders + 10+ clicks + clearly irrelevant intent = add as Negative Exact immediately.

On-the-Job Checklist

- I know the difference between Negative Exact and Negative Phrase.
- I always negative-out source campaigns the same day I harvest a term.
- I check Search Term Report weekly for wasted-spend terms to negative.
- I audit existing negatives quarterly to catch conflicts.

10 Metrics, KPIs & Analytics

Metrics are how you know whether your campaigns are working. This section covers every metric you'll see in the Amazon Ads Console, the formulas behind them, and how to build a health-check scorecard.

10.1 Core Metrics Deep Dive

Impressions, Clicks, CTR, CVR, CPC

Impressions: how many times your ad was shown. Doesn't cost you anything - you only pay when someone clicks. **Clicks:** how many shoppers clicked your ad. **CTR (Click-Through Rate)** = clicks / impressions. A 1% CTR means 1 click per 100 impressions. Healthy CTR for SP is 0.3-0.5% on ROS, 1-3% on TOS. **CVR (Conversion Rate)** = orders / clicks. Healthy CVR for SP is 8-15% for proven products, 3-8% for new products. **CPC (Cost Per Click)** = spend / clicks. Varies wildly by category - \$0.20 for low-competition niches, \$3+ for highly competitive ones like supplements.

ACOS vs. TACOS vs. ROAS - formulas, when each matters

ACOS (Advertising Cost of Sale) = ad spend / ad sales. Measures efficiency of ad spend against ad-attributed sales. If you spent \$20 and got \$100 in ad sales, ACOS = 20%. **TACOS (Total ACOS)** = ad spend / total sales (ad + organic). Measures efficiency against all sales, including organic. If you spent \$20 and got \$100 ad sales + \$150 organic sales, TACOS = \$20 / \$250 = 8%. TACOS matters because good ad campaigns lift organic sales too - looking only at ACOS understates the value of advertising. **ROAS (Return on Ad Spend)** = ad sales / ad spend = 1 / ACOS. A 5x ROAS = 20% ACOS. Use ROAS when talking to finance teams (they think in returns), ACOS when talking to operators (they think in costs).

EXAMPLE

Monthly: \$5,000 ad spend, \$25,000 ad-attributed sales, \$40,000 organic sales. ACOS = $5000/25000 = 20\%$. TACOS = $5000/(25000+40000) = 7.7\%$. ROAS = $25000/5000 = 5x$. A 20% ACOS looks mediocre but the 7.7% TACOS shows the campaign is highly profitable when organic halo is included.

Organic vs. paid sales attribution nuances

Amazon attributes a sale to your ad if the shopper clicked your ad and bought within 14 days. This is 'click attribution'. Amazon also tracks 'view attribution' (1-day) for SD - if a shopper saw your SD ad and bought within 24 hours, even without clicking. The 14-day window means if a shopper clicks your ad, leaves, comes back 13 days later via organic search, and buys - it's still attributed to your ad. This inflates ad sales and deflates organic sales in attribution reports. TACOS helps correct for this by including both.

10.2 Advanced Metrics

New-to-brand metrics

Amazon tracks whether a shopper has bought from your brand in the past 12 months.

New-to-brand (NTB) orders = orders from first-time buyers. NTB percentage = NTB orders / total orders. A high NTB% means your ads are acquiring new customers (good for growth-stage brands). A low NTB% means your ads are mostly retargeting existing customers (acceptable for mature brands in defense mode). NTB is only available for Sponsored Brands and Sponsored Display, not SP.

Halo effect / brand halo measurement

Halo effect = the indirect sales lift from advertising. Example: your SP ad for Product A drives a shopper to your store, where they buy Product B (which wasn't advertised).

Amazon's Brand Analytics Halo report shows this - sales of unadvertised products lift when ad campaigns run. Halo can be 10-30% of total sales lift, so ignoring it understates ad ROI by 10-30%.

Attribution windows (1-day view, 14-day click, etc.)

Different ad types have different attribution windows. SP and SB: 14-day click. SD: 14-day click + 1-day view (you choose which to optimize). DSP: 14-day click + 7-day or 14-day view. Longer windows capture more sales but introduce more noise. When comparing performance across ad types, normalize for window length.

10.3 Health Check Frameworks

Weekly account health scorecard structure

Build a weekly scorecard with these columns: Spend, Ad Sales, ACOS, TACOS, ROAS, Total Sales (ad + organic), CVR, CPC, TOS Share, Lost Impression Share. Compare to prior week and prior month. Flag any metric that moved more than 20% in either direction for investigation. The scorecard should take 15 minutes to review and surface 1-3 action items per week.

Red-flag thresholds by metric

ACOS > 50% on Exact keywords (likely losing money). **CVR < 3%** on Exact (listing quality issue). **Lost impression share > 50%** on top keywords (budget or bid too low). **TOS share < 15%** on Exact with +50% modifier (bid too low). **CPC > target ACOS bid** (you're overpaying). Any of these triggers a deeper investigation that week.

10.4 Benchmarking

Industry ACOS benchmarks by category

ACOS varies wildly by category. **Supplements:** 25-40% (high competition, high margin). **Apparel:** 15-25% (medium competition, medium margin). **Electronics:** 10-20% (high price, low margin). **Home & Kitchen:** 15-25%. **Beauty:** 20-35%. These are directional - your specific product margin and competition dictate your target. Don't blindly target industry benchmarks.

Break-even ACOS calculation tied to margin

Break-even ACOS = (price - COGS - other variable costs) / price. If your product sells for \$30, COGS is \$12, shipping/handling is \$3, Amazon fees are \$6, your break-even ACOS is $(\$30 - \$12 - \$3 - \$6) / \$30 = 30\%$. Above 30% ACOS = losing money. Below = profitable. Target ACOS = break-even ACOS - target margin (e.g., $30\% - 10\% = 20\%$).

TRAINING LAYER

Learning Aid

Key Terms

ACOS: Ad spend / ad sales. Measures efficiency against ad-attributed sales only.

TACOS: Ad spend / total sales (ad + organic). Measures efficiency against all sales.

ROAS: Ad sales / ad spend = 1 / ACOS. Finance-friendly framing.

New-to-brand (NTB): Orders from first-time brand buyers in last 12 months.

COMMON MISTAKES

Optimizing for ACOS alone. A campaign with 30% ACOS but huge organic halo (high TACOS lift) might be far more profitable than a campaign with 15% ACOS and no halo.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Two campaigns. Campaign A: \$1,000 spend, \$5,000 ad sales, \$0 organic lift. ACOS = 20%, TACOS = 20%. Campaign B: \$1,000 spend, \$3,000 ad sales, \$5,000 organic lift. ACOS = 33%, TACOS = 12.5%. Campaign B looks worse on ACOS but is far more profitable overall.

Quiz: Test Your Understanding

Q1. [Applied] You spent \$500 on ads. Ad-attributed sales were \$2,500. Organic sales were \$1,500. What is TACOS?

A. 20%

- B. 12.5%
- C. 33%
- D. 50%

Answer: B

Why: $TACOS = \text{ad spend} / \text{total sales} = \$500 / (\$2,500 + \$1,500) = \$500 / \$4,000 = 12.5\%$.

Q2. [Foundational] ACOS is 25%. What is ROAS?

- A. 25x
- B. 4x
- C. 0.25x
- D. 0.04x

Answer: B

Why: $ROAS = 1 / ACOS = 1 / 0.25 = 4x$.

Q3. [Applied] Product price \$40, COGS \$16, Amazon fees \$8, shipping \$4. What is break-even ACOS?

- A. 20%
- B. 30%
- C. 40%
- D. 50%

Answer: B

Why: $\text{Break-even ACOS} = (\text{price} - \text{COGS} - \text{fees} - \text{shipping}) / \text{price} = (\$40 - \$16 - \$8 - \$4) / \$40 = \$12 / \$40 = 30\%$.

Q4. [Applied] A shopper clicks your SP ad on Monday and buys the product on Thursday (3 days later) via organic search. Where is the sale attributed?

- A. Organic search
- B. Your SP ad (14-day click attribution window)
- C. Not attributed to any channel
- D. Split between ad and organic

Answer: B

Why: SP has a 14-day click attribution window. The sale is attributed to your ad even though the shopper returned via organic.

Q5. [Advanced] Why is TACOS often a better efficiency metric than ACOS?

- A. It's easier to calculate
- B. It captures organic halo - the indirect sales lift from advertising
- C. Amazon prefers TACOS
- D. ACOS is being deprecated

Answer: B

Why: Good ad campaigns lift organic sales too. TACOS captures both, giving a truer picture of profitability.

Teaching Guide

Suggested delivery time: 40 min lecture + 30 min calculation practice

Talking Points

- Open with the metric family tree: impressions > clicks > CTR > CVR > ACOS > TACOS.
- Walk through ACOS vs. TACOS with a real example showing how they diverge.
- Demo the break-even ACOS calculation on a whiteboard with sample numbers.
- Show the weekly health scorecard template and walk through each column.
- End with attribution windows - they're the most misunderstood nuance.

Live-Demo Checklist

- Open a campaign and show the metrics columns.
- Open Brand Analytics > Halo report to show organic lift.
- Build a simple weekly scorecard in Google Sheets live.
- Show the New-to-brand metric in an SB campaign report.
- Compare attribution windows across SP, SB, SD, DSP.

Discussion Prompts

- Why might a brand owner care more about TACOS than ACOS?
- If you had to pick one metric to optimize for, which would it be and why?
- How would you explain attribution windows to a confused client?

Handout Summary

DEFINITION

Amazon PPC metrics fall into four families: volume (impressions, clicks), efficiency (CTR, CVR, CPC), cost (ACOS, TACOS), and return (ROAS, NTB). TACOS is the most holistic efficiency metric because it captures organic halo. Break-even ACOS = (price - all variable costs) / price.

KEY FORMULA

ACOS = ad spend / ad sales. TACOS = ad spend / total sales. ROAS = 1 / ACOS. Break-even ACOS = (price - COGS - fees - shipping) / price.

On-the-Job Checklist

- I can calculate ACOS, TACOS, ROAS, break-even ACOS from raw numbers.
- I know the difference between click attribution (14-day) and view attribution (1-day).
- I know typical healthy CTR (0.3-0.5% ROS, 1-3% TOS) and CVR (8-15% mature, 3-8% new).
- I build a weekly health scorecard with at least 8 metrics.

11 Reporting & Data Analysis

Reports turn raw data into decisions. This section covers the native Amazon reports, Brand Analytics, custom dashboard building, and how to translate numbers into a narrative for stakeholders.

11.1 Native Amazon Reports

Search Term Report, Placement Report, Targeting Report

Search Term Report: actual shopper search queries that triggered your ads. The most valuable report - harvest and negate from here. Pulled weekly. **Placement Report:** TOS/ROS/PDP performance by campaign. Pulled weekly for placement modifier tuning. **Targeting Report:** performance by keyword and ASIN target. Use to identify top performers and wasted spend. All three are downloadable as CSV from Reports > Advertising Reports.

Bulk Sheets / Bulk Operations reports

Bulk Operations lets you download the entire account as a single spreadsheet, make mass changes, and re-upload. The bulk file has tabs for campaigns, ad groups, keywords, negatives, and more. Powerful for 1000+ keyword changes that would be tedious in the UI. The file format is finicky - always download the template fresh, don't reuse old files, and validate before uploading.

11.2 Brand Analytics

Search Query Performance report

Available free to Brand Registry sellers. Shows the actual search terms shoppers used to find your products, with click and conversion data from Amazon's first-party perspective. More accurate than third-party tools. Pull monthly to validate keyword research.

Market Basket Analysis

Shows what shoppers bought together. If shoppers who buy your yoga mat also frequently buy a specific water bottle, that's a cross-sell opportunity. Use to inform ASIN targeting and bundling strategy.

Item Comparison / Repeat Purchase reports

Item Comparison: shows which competitor ASINs shoppers compared yours against (and which they ultimately bought). Reveals your true competitive set. **Repeat Purchase:** shows repeat purchase behavior by ASIN. High repeat rate = opportunity for Purchases Remarketing SD campaigns.

11.3 Custom Reporting & Dashboards

Building client-facing dashboards

Native Amazon reports are operator-focused (lots of columns, jargon). Client-facing dashboards should be executive-focused: 5-7 KPIs max, trend lines, simple language. Tools: Google Looker Studio (free, connects to Amazon data via API or CSV upload), Tableau (paid, more powerful), Power BI (Microsoft ecosystem). Build a template once and reuse across clients.

KPI dashboard templates by stakeholder type

Executive summary: Spend, Total Sales, TACOS, ROAS, NTB% - one page, monthly view.

Operator detail: All metrics by campaign, weekly view, with action column. **Brand owner:** Spend by product line, ACOS by SKU, organic rank trends - monthly view. Different stakeholders need different cuts of the same data.

11.4 Data Storytelling

Translating PPC data into business narrative

Numbers don't speak for themselves. A 25% ACOS doesn't mean 'good' or 'bad' - it means 'we spent \$0.25 per \$1 of ad sales'. The narrative is: 'We invested \$5,000 to generate \$20,000 in ad sales and an estimated \$12,000 in organic halo sales. Total return: \$32,000 in sales for \$5,000 in spend, a 6.4x return. Next month, we recommend scaling the top-performing campaign by 50%.' Numbers in context = story. Numbers alone = noise.

TRAINING LAYER

Learning Aid

Key Terms

Search Term Report: Native Amazon report showing actual shopper search queries that triggered ads.

Brand Analytics: Free Amazon reporting suite for Brand Registry sellers, includes SQP and Market Basket.

Bulk Operations: Spreadsheet-based mass edit tool for large accounts.

Halo report: Brand Analytics report showing organic sales lift from ad campaigns.

COMMON MISTAKES

Sending clients the raw Search Term Report. It's 50 columns of jargon - they won't read it. Translate into a 1-page narrative with 3-5 KPIs.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Client report: "Spend \$4,200 (up 12% MoM). Ad sales \$18,500 (up 18%). ACOS 22.7% (down from 24%). Organic sales \$11,200 (up 25% - halo from increased traffic). Top performer: Exact campaign for 'yoga mat thick' - \$1,800 spend, \$9,500 sales, 19% ACOS. Recommend scaling by 40% next month."

Quiz: Test Your Understanding

Q1. [Foundational] Which report shows the actual search terms shoppers used to find your ads?

- A. Placement Report
- B. Search Term Report
- C. Brand Analytics Halo
- D. Bulk Operations

Answer: B

Why: The Search Term Report shows actual shopper queries, not the keywords you bid on.

Q2. [Applied] What is Brand Analytics Search Query Performance best used for?

- A. Bid automation
- B. Validating keyword research with first-party Amazon data
- C. Building brand stores
- D. Setting portfolio budgets

Answer: B

Why: SQP is first-party data showing real shopper queries - more reliable than third-party tools for keyword validation.

Q3. [Applied] A client report should include how many KPIs at the executive summary level?

- A. 1
- B. 5-7
- C. 20+
- D. 50+

Answer: B

Why: Executives need a focused view. 5-7 KPIs forces prioritization; more signals noise.

Q4. [Foundational] What does the Market Basket Analysis report show?

- A. Shopper search terms
- B. What shoppers bought together with your products
- C. Competitor ASIN targeting
- D. Repeat purchase rates

Answer: B

Why: Market Basket reveals cross-sell opportunities by showing products frequently bought together.

Q5. [Advanced] Why translate PPC data into narrative for stakeholders?

- A. Because stakeholders can't read numbers
- B. Numbers alone lack context; narrative explains what the numbers mean for the business
- C. Amazon requires it
- D. To hide underperformance

Answer: B

Why: Numbers are meaningless without context. Narrative frames the numbers as business decisions and recommendations.

Teaching Guide

Suggested delivery time: 30 min lecture + 30 min dashboard exercise

Talking Points

- Open with the reports hierarchy: operator-level (native reports) > analyst-level (Brand Analytics) > executive-level (custom dashboards).
- Walk through Search Term Report live - it is the most-used report.
- Demo Brand Analytics SQP and Market Basket.
- Show a client-facing dashboard template in Looker Studio.
- End with data storytelling - the skill that separates agencies from operators.

Live-Demo Checklist

- Open Reports > Advertising Reports and download a Search Term Report.
- Open Brand Analytics > Search Query Performance.
- Open Market Basket Analysis for a sample ASIN.
- Show a Looker Studio dashboard with Amazon data.
- Walk through translating raw metrics into a client narrative.

Discussion Prompts

- Why is the Search Term Report more valuable than the Placement Report for daily operations?
- If you could only send one report per month to a client, which would it be?
- How would you explain TACOS to a non-technical CEO in one sentence?

Handout Summary

DEFINITION

Amazon PPC reporting lives in three layers: native ad reports (Search Term, Placement, Targeting), Brand Analytics (SQP, Market Basket, Halo), and custom dashboards (Looker Studio, Tableau). The job of the analyst is to translate numbers into business narrative for stakeholders.

On-the-Job Checklist

- I know which native report to pull for each operational question.
- I know that Brand Analytics is free for Brand Registry sellers and more reliable than third-party tools.
- I build client-facing dashboards with 5-7 KPIs at the executive level.
- I translate numbers into narrative before sending reports to non-PPC stakeholders.

12 Amazon Marketing Cloud (AMC)

AMC is Amazon's data clean room - it gives advertisers SQL access to shopper-level data they can't see anywhere else. This is advanced territory; most accounts don't need it. But for enterprise brands, it's the only way to do cross-channel attribution.

12.1 What AMC Is and Who Needs It

Eligibility requirements

AMC requires: (1) Brand Registry, (2) an active Amazon Ads account with spending history (typically \$50K+ annual), and (3) a managed service or self-service enablement. As of 2024, self-service AMC is rolling out but managed service (via Amazon or a partner agency) is still common. Pricing varies; managed service starts at ~\$1,500/month.

Clean-room data concept explained

A 'clean room' is a secure environment where multiple data sets can be joined for analysis without exposing individual user records. Amazon's clean room lets you join your ad impression data with Amazon's shopper purchase data. You see aggregated results (e.g., 'shoppers who saw your SD ad and bought within 7 days') but never individual shopper identities. This protects privacy while enabling cross-channel attribution.

12.2 AMC Use Cases

Cross-channel attribution

Native Amazon reports attribute sales to the last ad a shopper clicked. AMC lets you build custom attribution models: see how SD display ads assisted SP conversions, or how DSP video ads drove brand searches later converted by SP. This is the only way to measure true cross-channel synergy on Amazon.

Overlap analysis (DSP + Sponsored Ads reach)

AMC shows how many unique shoppers saw both your DSP and Sponsored Ads campaigns. If overlap is 5%, your DSP is reaching new audiences. If overlap is 80%, you're paying to reach the same shoppers twice - consider re-targeting DSP audiences to exclude SP clickers.

Custom audience building from AMC queries

Write a query in AMC like 'shoppers who added to cart but didn't buy in last 30 days' and push that audience back to DSP for retargeting. This is far more precise than the pre-built audience segments in DSP.

12.3 AMC SQL Basics

Query structure primer

AMC uses standard SQL. A basic query: `SELECT campaign_id, COUNT(DISTINCT user_id) FROM amazon_ads_impressions WHERE campaign_id = 'XYZ' GROUP BY campaign_id`. The schema includes tables for impressions, clicks, conversions, and DSP events. Date ranges are required (AMC doesn't allow open-ended queries).

Common query templates

Common patterns: **Path-to-conversion** (which ad touchpoints preceded a purchase), **Frequency analysis** (how many ad impressions before a shopper converts), **Overlap analysis** (audience overlap between DSP and SP). Amazon publishes a library of templates - start there before writing your own.

TRAINING LAYER

Learning Aid

Key Terms

AMC: Amazon Marketing Cloud - SQL-based clean room for cross-channel analysis.

Clean room: Secure environment for joining multiple data sets without exposing individual user records.

Overlap analysis: AMC query showing audience overlap between ad channels.

Path-to-conversion: AMC query showing the sequence of ad touchpoints preceding a purchase.

COMMON MISTAKES

Thinking AMC replaces native reports. It doesn't - it complements them. Native reports answer daily operational questions; AMC answers strategic cross-channel questions.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Query: "Shoppers who saw SD ad in week 1, didn't click, but converted via SP in week 2."
Result: 340 shoppers, \$12,400 in sales. Native reports would attribute these to SP alone, missing SD's assist. Adjust SD budget up.

Quiz: Test Your Understanding

Q1. [Foundational] What is a "clean room" in the AMC context?

A. A bug-free environment

- B. A secure environment for joining data sets without exposing individual users
- C. A clean UI
- D. A type of bid strategy

Answer: B

Why: Clean rooms allow aggregated analysis across data sets without revealing individual records.

Q2. [Applied] Which AMC use case is NOT possible with native Amazon reports?

- A. See search terms that triggered ads
- B. Cross-channel attribution (SD assisting SP conversions)
- C. See ad sales by campaign
- D. Check campaign budget pacing

Answer: B

Why: Native reports use last-click attribution. AMC allows custom multi-touch attribution across channels.

Q3. [Foundational] What language does AMC use for queries?

- A. Python
- B. SQL
- C. JavaScript
- D. Excel formulas

Answer: B

Why: AMC uses standard SQL. No Python or JavaScript needed.

Q4. [Applied] AMC overlap analysis shows 80% overlap between DSP and SP audiences. What does this mean?

- A. Great - both channels reaching same shoppers
- B. Wasteful - paying to reach the same shoppers twice; re-target DSP to exclude SP clickers
- C. Impossible - overlap is always 5%
- D. AMC is broken

Answer: B

Why: High overlap = redundant spend. Adjust DSP targeting to exclude SP-engaged audiences.

Q5. [Advanced] Who typically needs AMC?

- A. Every Amazon seller
- B. Enterprise brands with \$50K+ annual ad spend needing cross-channel attribution
- C. Only Amazon employees
- D. New sellers with no ad spend

Answer: B

Why: AMC is overkill for small accounts. Its value emerges at scale where cross-channel attribution matters.

Teaching Guide

Suggested delivery time: 25 min lecture + 15 min SQL demo

Talking Points

- Open with the clean room concept - it's the foundational idea.
- Compare native attribution (last-click) with AMC attribution (multi-touch).
- Walk through 2-3 common AMC use cases.
- Show a sample SQL query and explain each clause.
- End with eligibility - most accounts don't need AMC yet.

Live-Demo Checklist

- Open AMC interface (or screenshots if no access).
- Show the query editor and a sample query.
- Show the schema browser.
- Run a path-to-conversion query and explain the output.
- Show how to push a custom audience back to DSP.

Discussion Prompts

- Why does last-click attribution understate the value of upper-funnel ads like SD and DSP?
- If you had AMC access, what's the first question you would investigate?
- Why might a small brand skip AMC even if eligible?

Handout Summary

DEFINITION

Amazon Marketing Cloud (AMC) is a SQL-based clean room that lets advertisers join their ad data with Amazon's shopper data for cross-channel attribution and custom audience building. It requires Brand Registry, \$50K+ annual spend, and managed or self-service enablement.

On-the-Job Checklist

- I can explain what a clean room is and why it protects privacy.
- I know the difference between native attribution (last-click) and AMC attribution (multi-touch).
- I know when AMC is worth the cost (enterprise scale, cross-channel questions).
- I can identify overlap analysis and path-to-conversion as core AMC use cases.

13 Amazon DSP (Demand Side Platform)

DSP is Amazon's programmatic ad-buying platform. It serves display, video, audio, and OTT ads across Amazon-owned and third-party sites. It's the upper-funnel counterpart to Sponsored Ads' mid-funnel focus.

13.1 DSP Fundamentals

Managed Service vs. Self-Service DSP

Managed Service: an Amazon account manager or agency runs campaigns for you. Minimum spend ~\$35K-\$50K/month. Higher service level, less control. **Self-Service:** you run campaigns yourself in the DSP console. No minimum, but you need expertise. Most advertisers start with Managed Service, graduate to Self-Service once they understand the platform.

Minimum spend and eligibility

Managed Service requires ~\$35K/month minimum. Self-Service has no official minimum but practically needs ~\$10K/month to be worth the operational overhead. Both require an Amazon Advertising account in good standing. Some agencies offer 'DSP-as-a-service' for smaller brands by pooling multiple clients.

13.2 DSP Campaign Types

Display, Video, Audio, OTT

Display: standard banner ads on Amazon and third-party sites. CPC or CPM pricing. **Video:** 6-15 second video ads on Amazon and third-party sites (including IMDb, Twitch). CPM pricing. **Audio:** audio ads on Amazon Music and Audible. CPM. **OTT (Streaming TV):** video ads on Prime Video, Freevee, Fire TV apps. CPM, typically \$25-\$40. OTT is the most expensive but has the broadest reach for awareness.

Retargeting vs. prospecting campaigns

Retargeting: show ads to shoppers who interacted with your brand (viewed PDP, added to cart, bought before). High CVR, low CPM (~\$5-\$10). **Prospecting:** show ads to new shoppers via lookalike or in-market audiences. Lower CVR, higher CPM (~\$10-\$20). Mature DSP accounts run both - retargeting for conversion, prospecting for awareness.

13.3 DSP Audience Building

First-party data upload

Upload your own customer list (emails, hashed identifiers) to DSP. Amazon matches against its shopper database (typically 60-80% match rate) and creates a custom audience. Use for retargeting existing customers with new product launches or loyalty offers.

Amazon audience segments

Pre-built segments based on Amazon shopper behavior: **Lifestyle** (fitness enthusiasts, parents of young kids), **In-market** (active researchers of a category), **Life events** (recent movers, new parents). Hundreds of segments available, browse in the DSP console.

Lookalike audiences

Take a seed audience (e.g., your past purchasers) and ask Amazon to find similar shoppers. Amazon looks at purchase behavior, browsing patterns, and demographic signals to build a lookalike audience 10-100x the size of your seed. Useful for scaling prospecting.

13.4 DSP + Sponsored Ads Synergy

Full-funnel orchestration model

Upper funnel: DSP OTT and Display for awareness. Mid funnel: SD for remarketing and consideration. Lower funnel: SP Exact for conversion. Without DSP, upper funnel is missing and the SP campaigns have to do all the work. With DSP, each layer feeds the next: DSP creates awareness, SD captures intent, SP closes the sale.

Budget split logic between DSP and Sponsored Ads

Typical split: **Year 1-2 brand**: 100% Sponsored Ads (no DSP). **Year 3 brand**: 80% Sponsored Ads, 20% DSP. **Mature brand**: 60% Sponsored Ads, 40% DSP. The shift reflects the growing importance of awareness and retargeting as the brand matures and the cost of acquiring new customers via Sponsored Ads alone climbs.

TRAINING LAYER

Learning Aid

Key Terms

Managed Service DSP: Amazon or agency runs DSP campaigns for you; \$35K+/month minimum.

Self-Service DSP: You run DSP campaigns yourself; no minimum but requires expertise.

OTT (Streaming TV): Video ads on Prime Video, Freevee, Fire TV; broadest reach for awareness.

Lookalike audience: Amazon-built audience of shoppers similar to your seed audience.

COMMON MISTAKES

Launching DSP with no Sponsored Ads foundation. DSP is upper-funnel and won't convert without SP to close the sale. Build SP maturity first (typically 6-12 months), then add DSP.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Mature brand: \$50K/month total ad budget. Allocation: \$30K SP (60%), \$7K SB (14%), \$13K DSP (26%). DSP split: \$7K retargeting (high CVR), \$4K prospecting (awareness), \$2K OTT (broad reach). Cross-funnel: DSP drives awareness, SD retargets, SP closes.

Quiz: Test Your Understanding

Q1. [Foundational] What's the minimum spend for Managed Service DSP?

- A. \$1,000/month
- B. \$5,000/month
- C. \$35,000/month
- D. \$100,000/month

Answer: C

Why: Managed Service DSP requires ~\$35K/month. Self-Service has no official minimum but practically needs ~\$10K/month.

Q2. [Foundational] Which DSP ad format has the broadest awareness reach?

- A. Display banners
- B. Audio ads
- C. OTT (Streaming TV)
- D. Email ads

Answer: C

Why: OTT reaches shoppers on Prime Video, Freevee, Fire TV - the broadest awareness inventory.

Q3. [Applied] A Year 1 brand should allocate what % of budget to DSP?

- A. 0% - build SP foundation first
- B. 20%
- C. 50%
- D. 80%

Answer: A

Why: Year 1 brands need Sponsored Ads to drive direct conversion. DSP is upper-funnel and won't convert without SP to close.

Q4. [Applied] What is a lookalike audience in DSP?

- A. Shoppers who look like your existing customers based on Amazon's behavioral data
- B. Shoppers who visited your store

- C. Shoppers who abandoned cart
- D. Amazon employees

Answer: A

Why: Amazon takes a seed audience (e.g., past purchasers) and finds shoppers with similar behaviors for prospecting.

Q5. [Advanced] Why use AMC alongside DSP?

- A. AMC is required to use DSP
- B. AMC enables cross-channel attribution and custom audience building
- C. AMC lowers DSP costs
- D. AMC replaces DSP reporting

Answer: B

Why: AMC joins DSP data with Sponsored Ads data for true cross-channel attribution. It also enables pushing custom audiences back to DSP.

Teaching Guide

Suggested delivery time: 30 min lecture + 20 min case study review

Talking Points

- Open with the funnel map - DSP is upper funnel, SP is lower.
- Compare Managed vs. Self-Service DSP honestly.
- Walk through the four DSP ad formats with use cases.
- Demo audience building (or screenshots): first-party, Amazon segments, lookalikes.
- End with budget split logic - the practical guidance trainees need.

Live-Demo Checklist

- Open DSP console (or screenshots if no access).
- Show audience builder and pre-built segments.
- Walk through a campaign setup (or screenshots).
- Show reporting dashboard with cross-channel metrics.
- Compare with Sponsored Ads reporting side by side.

Discussion Prompts

- Why doesn't DSP work without Sponsored Ads?
- If you had \$50K/month, how would you split between SP, SB, SD, and DSP?
- How would you explain the value of DSP retargeting to a skeptical client?

Handout Summary

DEFINITION

Amazon DSP is a programmatic ad-buying platform for display, video, audio, and OTT ads across Amazon-owned and third-party sites. Two access models: Managed Service (\$35K+/month) and Self-Service. Best used alongside Sponsored Ads for full-funnel coverage, not as a standalone channel.

On-the-Job Checklist

- I can explain the difference between Managed and Self-Service DSP.
- I know the four DSP ad formats and their typical use cases.
- I know DSP shouldn't be added until Sponsored Ads foundation is mature.
- I can describe retargeting vs. prospecting campaigns.

14 Brand Presence & Content Tie-Ins

PPC doesn't exist in a vacuum. Your Brand Store, A+ Content, and Brand Registry status all gate ad features and influence conversion. This section covers the brand-side assets every advertiser needs.

14.1 Brand Registry

Requirements and benefits relevant to ads

Brand Registry requires an active registered trademark (USPTO or equivalent). Once approved (typically 1-3 weeks), it unlocks: Sponsored Brands, Sponsored Display, Brand Stores, A+ Content, Brand Analytics (free reporting), enhanced brand content, and increased control over your listings (you can remove counterfeits). For most serious brands, Brand Registry is non-negotiable.

14.2 Brand Store

Store structure best practices

A Brand Store is a multi-page mini-website on Amazon for your brand. Best structure: home page with brand story and hero product, 3-5 category sub-pages, and a 'new arrivals' or 'best sellers' page. Keep navigation simple - shoppers shouldn't click more than 2 deep. Use video and lifestyle imagery to differentiate from generic Amazon listings.

Store Insights and how they inform SB Store Spotlight

Brand Store Insights shows daily visitors, page views, source (SB ads, organic, etc.), and bounce rate. If a specific sub-page gets high traffic, consider an SB Store Spotlight campaign driving directly to that page. Insights also show which products get clicked most - use that to inform Store layout changes.

14.3 A+ Content / Premium A+

Impact on conversion rate -> impact on ad efficiency

A+ Content replaces the default product description with rich images, comparison charts, and brand story. Listings with A+ typically see 5-15% CVR lift vs. listings without. Higher CVR means lower CPC at the same ACOS, which means your ads become more profitable. **Premium A+** (for top-selling brands) adds video, interactive modules, and more - can lift CVR another 5-10%.

How to audit listing readiness before scaling ad spend

Before scaling ads, audit each listing: (1) main image meets Amazon's requirements and is high-quality, (2) title is keyword-rich and under 200 characters, (3) 5 bullets with key benefits, (4) A+ Content with at least 3 modules, (5) at least 1 video, (6) at least 15 reviews with 4+ star average. If any are missing, fix before scaling - ads will drive traffic to a listing that doesn't convert.

TRAINING LAYER

Learning Aid

Key Terms

Brand Registry: Amazon program requiring active trademark; unlocks SB, SD, Stores, A+, Brand Analytics.

Brand Store: Multi-page mini-website on Amazon for your brand.

A+ Content: Enhanced product description with images, comparison charts, brand story; 5-15% CVR lift.

Premium A+: Top-tier A+ with video and interactive modules; additional 5-10% CVR lift.

COMMON MISTAKES

Scaling ad spend before listing is ready. Ads drive traffic; if the listing doesn't convert, you waste budget and tank your relevance score, making future ads more expensive.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Yoga mat listing audit: main image ✓, title 180 chars ✓, 5 bullets ✓, A+ Content ✓ (3 modules), 1 video ✓, 23 reviews at 4.3 stars ✓. Ready to scale. Increase Exact campaign budget by 50%. Compare to a listing with no A+ and 8 reviews - scale spend there and you'll burn money.

Quiz: Test Your Understanding

Q1. [Foundational] What is required to get Brand Registry?

- A. 100+ reviews
- B. An active registered trademark
- C. \$50K ad spend
- D. Vendor Central account

Answer: B

Why: Brand Registry requires an active trademark (USPTO or equivalent). It typically takes 1-3 weeks to process.

Q2. [Foundational] A+ Content typically lifts CVR by what range?

- A. 0-1%
- B. 5-15%
- C. 50-100%
- D. It lowers CVR

Answer: B

Why: A+ Content adds rich images and structured content, typically lifting CVR 5-15% vs. default descriptions.

Q3. [Applied] Why should you audit a listing before scaling ad spend?

- A. To find typos
- B. If the listing doesn't convert, ads waste budget and tank relevance score
- C. Amazon requires it
- D. To impress the client

Answer: B

Why: Ads drive traffic. If the listing doesn't convert, you waste budget and lower your relevance score, making future ads more expensive.

Q4. [Applied] Which of these is NOT unlocked by Brand Registry?

- A. Sponsored Brands
- B. Sponsored Display
- C. A+ Content
- D. Sponsored Products

Answer: D

Why: Sponsored Products requires Buy Box, not Brand Registry. SB, SD, Stores, and A+ all require Brand Registry.

Q5. [Advanced] What does Brand Store Insights show you?

- A. Search terms
- B. Daily visitors, page views, traffic source, bounce rate
- C. Competitor sales
- D. Backend keywords

Answer: B

Why: Insights shows Store traffic data including source (SB ads, organic, etc.) - useful for optimizing Store layout and SB Store Spotlight campaigns.

Teaching Guide

Suggested delivery time: 25 min lecture + 20 min listing audit exercise

Talking Points

- Open with the ecosystem view: Brand Registry unlocks everything else.
- Walk through Brand Store structure with a real example.
- Show A+ Content vs. default description side by side.
- Demo the listing audit checklist on a real product.
- End with the relevance score link - poor listings hurt ad performance downstream.

Live-Demo Checklist

- Open a Brand Store on Amazon and walk through the navigation.
- Open Brand Store Insights dashboard.
- Compare a listing with A+ vs. one without.
- Run through the listing audit checklist on a sample product.
- Show Premium A+ examples if available.

Discussion Prompts

- Why would a brand delay Brand Registry even if eligible?
- If you had to pick one listing element to improve first, which would it be?
- How would you explain the link between A+ Content and ACOS to a client?

Handout Summary

DEFINITION

Brand Registry (requires trademark) unlocks Sponsored Brands, Sponsored Display, Brand Stores, A+ Content, and Brand Analytics. A+ Content lifts CVR 5-15%, which directly improves ad efficiency. Always audit listing readiness before scaling ad spend.

On-the-Job Checklist

- I know what Brand Registry unlocks and what it requires.
- I can audit a listing against the readiness checklist.
- I know A+ Content typically lifts CVR 5-15%.
- I know never to scale ad spend on an unaudited listing.

15 Listing Optimization (PPC-Adjacent)

Your listing is the landing page for every ad click. If the listing is weak, no amount of bid optimization will save you. This section covers the listing-side levers that gate PPC performance.

15.1 Why Listing Quality Gates PPC Performance

CVR ceiling caused by weak listings

Amazon's relevance score factors in CVR. If your listing converts at 3% vs. a competitor's 10%, Amazon ranks your ad lower even with the same bid - because Amazon makes more money per impression from the competitor. This creates a CVR ceiling: no matter how high you bid, your ad won't show in top placements if the listing doesn't convert. Fixing the listing raises the ceiling.

Pre-launch listing audit checklist

Before launching ads: (1) main image pure white background, product fills 85% of frame, (2) 6+ secondary images showing lifestyle, features, size comparison, (3) title under 200 chars with primary keyword first, (4) 5 bullet points with benefit-led copy, (5) A+ Content if Brand Registry, (6) 1+ video, (7) backend keywords filled (250 bytes max), (8) competitive price or coupon, (9) FBA for Prime shipping. Miss any of these and ads will underperform.

15.2 Title, Bullet, Backend Keyword Optimization

Keyword placement hierarchy (title > bullets > backend)

Amazon's algorithm weights keywords by where they appear: title is highest weight, bullets second, backend keywords third, description fourth. Put your top 3-5 keywords in the title, next 5-10 in bullets, remainder in backend. Don't keyword-stuff - Amazon penalizes titles that read like keyword lists.

Character limits by category

Most categories allow 200 chars for title, 500 chars per bullet, 250 bytes for backend keywords. Some categories (supplements, beauty) have stricter rules. Check Amazon's category style guide before writing - rejected listings take 24-48 hours to re-approve.

15.3 Image & Video Impact on CTR/CVR

Main image best practices

Main image is the single biggest CTR lever. Pure white background (RGB 255,255,255), product fills 85% of frame, no text or logos, no props, no people. Image must be at least 1000x1000 pixels for zoom. Shoot from the most flattering angle - for a yoga mat, that's rolled up showing thickness, not flat.

A/B testing images (Manage Your Experiments)

Amazon's Manage Your Experiments (MYE) tool lets you A/B test main image, title, bullets, A+ Content. Run experiments for 4-8 weeks for statistical significance. Winning variations become permanent. Continuous experimentation compounds - brands that test quarterly outperform brands that don't by 20-30% over 2 years.

15.4 Pricing & Promotions Interplay with PPC

Coupons, Deals, Prime Exclusive Discounts

A coupon (5-20% off) adds a green badge to your listing and search result, lifting CTR 10-30%. Coupons also trigger Follow campaigns in some shoppers' feeds. Run a coupon during ad scale-up to compound CTR and CVR lift. **Lightning Deals** (4-6 hour limited-time deals) and **Best Deals** (1-2 week deals) drive spikes in traffic - prepare ad budgets accordingly.

Lightning Deals / Best Deals timing with campaigns

If you're running a Lightning Deal on Tuesday, increase ad budget 50-100% that day - shoppers who see your deal will search your brand name, and you want to win those brand searches. Also lower ACOS tolerance for the day - the deal + ads together should still be profitable, even if standalone ad ACOS is high.

TRAINING LAYER

Learning Aid

Key Terms

Relevance score: Amazon's algorithmic rating of how well your listing matches a search; factors in CVR, CTR, listing quality.

Backend keywords: Hidden keywords in Seller Central that help Amazon understand your product; 250 bytes max.

Manage Your Experiments (MYE): Amazon A/B testing tool for listings; 4-8 week experiments.

Coupon: 5-20% discount with green badge; lifts CTR 10-30%.

COMMON MISTAKES

Keyword-stuffing the title with 10+ keywords. Amazon penalizes titles that don't read naturally, and shoppers skip listings that look spammy. Stick to 3-5 keywords in the title.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Yoga mat listing has 3% CVR. You add: 6th image (size comparison), A+ Content with comparison chart, video showing mat in use, and a 10% coupon. CVR climbs to 7% over 4 weeks. Your break-even ACOS rises from 18% to 28% - now you can profitably bid 55% higher on top keywords.

Quiz: Test Your Understanding

Q1. [Applied] Why does a weak listing create a CVR ceiling for ads?

- A. Amazon won't show your ads
- B. Amazon's relevance score ranks low-CVR listings lower, even with high bids
- C. Shoppers don't click
- D. It doesn't - ads work regardless of listing

Answer: B

Why: Amazon ranks ads by bid x relevance. Low CVR = low relevance = lower ad rank, no matter how high you bid.

Q2. [Foundational] Where does Amazon's algorithm weight keywords most heavily?

- A. Backend keywords
- B. Description
- C. Bullets
- D. Title

Answer: D

Why: Title > bullets > backend > description. Put your top 3-5 keywords in the title.

Q3. [Applied] How long should a Manage Your Experiments (MYE) test run for statistical significance?

- A. 1 day
- B. 1 week
- C. 4-8 weeks
- D. 6 months

Answer: C

Why: Amazon recommends 4-8 weeks. Shorter tests are statistical noise; longer tests waste time.

Q4. [Applied] A coupon typically lifts CTR by what range?

- A. 0-1%
- B. 10-30%
- C. 50-100%

D. Coupons don't affect CTR

Answer: B

Why: The green coupon badge in search results lifts CTR 10-30%. Combine with ad scale-up for compounding effect.

Q5. [Advanced] What is the maximum backend keyword length?

- A. 100 bytes
- B. 250 bytes
- C. 500 bytes
- D. No limit

Answer: B

Why: Backend keywords are capped at 250 bytes. Use them wisely - no duplicates, no commas, no brand names.

Teaching Guide

Suggested delivery time: 30 min lecture + 30 min listing audit

Talking Points

- Open with the landing page analogy - your listing is the landing page for every ad click.
- Walk through the relevance score loop: CVR -> relevance -> ad rank -> more clicks -> more data -> higher CVR.
- Demo the keyword placement hierarchy with a real listing.
- Show MYE live if available, or screenshots of A/B tests.
- End with the coupon + ad scale-up compound effect.

Live-Demo Checklist

- Open a sample listing and audit each element against the checklist.
- Show MYE dashboard and an in-progress experiment.
- Compare two listings side by side - one optimized, one not.
- Show how to add a coupon in Seller Central.
- Demonstrate backend keyword entry in Seller Central.

Discussion Prompts

- Why is the title the highest-weighted keyword location?
- If you could only fix one listing element, which would it be?
- How would you explain relevance score to a brand owner who thinks ads alone drive sales?

Handout Summary

DEFINITION

Listing quality gates PPC performance through Amazon's relevance score. Title is the highest-weighted keyword location; backend keywords are capped at 250 bytes. Main image is the biggest CTR lever; A+ Content and video lift CVR. Coupons compound with ad scale-up.

KEY FORMULA

Relevance score loop: better listing -> higher CVR -> higher relevance -> higher ad rank -> more clicks -> more data -> higher CVR.

On-the-Job Checklist

- I can audit any listing against the 9-point checklist.
- I know the keyword placement hierarchy (title > bullets > backend).
- I know backend keywords cap at 250 bytes.
- I know to scale ad budgets when running Lightning Deals or coupons.

16 Automation, Rules & Scripts

Automation scales your efforts. This section covers native Amazon automation, bulk operations, custom scripts, and where AI fits in the PPC workflow.

16.1 Native Amazon Automation

Amazon's Rules-based automation (bid rules, budget rules)

Amazon now offers native rule-based automation in the console. **Bid rules:** e.g., 'lower bid by 10% if ACOS > 40% over 7 days'. **Budget rules:** e.g., 'raise budget by 50% on Prime Day'. These are free, simple, and useful for accounts not ready for third-party tools. Limitation: limited rule complexity and no dayparting.

16.2 Bulk Operations

Bulk file structure and use cases

Bulk files are Excel spreadsheets that let you mass-edit campaigns, ad groups, keywords, bids, budgets, and negatives. The file has tabs for each entity type. Use cases: bulk keyword additions (adding 100 keywords), bulk bid changes (raising all Exact bids by 10%), bulk negations, campaign cloning. Always download a fresh template - formats change.

Common bulk upload errors and fixes

Common errors: **Invalid max bid** (below \$0.02 or above \$1000), **Daily budget too low** (below \$1), **Start date in past**, **Operation not allowed in enabled state** (try to edit a paused campaign). The bulk upload error report tells you the row and issue. Fix and re-upload just the failed rows.

16.3 Custom Scripts & API-Based Automation

Use cases for building your own automation

Build custom automation when: (1) you have 100+ campaigns and UI edits are slow, (2) you want custom rules beyond Amazon's native options, (3) you want to integrate PPC data with other systems (inventory, CRM). Common builds: daily ACOS alerting, automated harvesting (search term -> Exact keyword), custom dashboards, inventory-aware bid pausing.

Ads API basics: reports endpoint, campaign management endpoints

Amazon Ads API has two main endpoints: **Reports** (download search term, placement, targeting reports programmatically) and **Campaign Management** (create, update, pause campaigns and keywords). Authentication uses OAuth with refresh tokens. API access requires registering as a developer and getting approved. Rate limits apply.

16.4 AI-Augmented PPC Management

Where LLMs fit in PPC workflows

Large Language Models (LLMs) like GPT-4 or Claude fit four PPC workflows: (1) **Search term classification** - bulk-categorize 1000s of search terms as relevant/irrelevant/borderline. (2) **Negative keyword suggestions** - identify likely irrelevant terms from a list. (3) **Report summarization** - turn a 50-row report into a 3-paragraph narrative for clients. (4) **Creative variations** - generate 10 headline variations for SB testing.

Human-in-the-loop guardrails for AI-assisted bid changes

Never let an LLM make bid changes directly. Use AI for recommendations, then have a human review and approve. AI is bad at: (1) understanding context (a keyword might be paused for inventory reasons), (2) catching Amazon policy nuances, (3) judging marginal edge cases. AI is good at: (1) surfacing candidates, (2) summarizing, (3) generating variations. Use it for what it's good at, gate it with humans for what it's not.

TRAINING LAYER

Learning Aid

Key Terms

Bid rules: Native Amazon automation that adjusts bids based on performance thresholds.

Bulk Operations: Excel-based mass edit tool for campaigns, ad groups, keywords, and negatives.

Amazon Ads API: Developer API for programmatic campaign management and report downloads.

LLM augmentation: Using AI for search term classification, negative suggestions, report summarization, and creative variations.

COMMON MISTAKES

Letting AI make bid changes directly without human review. LLMs lack context (inventory pauses, policy nuances) and can make catastrophic changes at scale.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Workflow: Download 5000-row search term report. Use LLM to classify each as relevant/irrelevant/borderline. LLM flags 800 as likely irrelevant. Human reviews 800 (10 min) and confirms 720 should be negated. Bulk upload 720 negatives. Saved 4 hours of manual classification.

Quiz: Test Your Understanding

Q1. [Foundational] What are Amazon's native bid rules useful for?

- A. Complex multi-variable automation
- B. Simple rules like "lower bid if ACOS > X"
- C. Dayparting
- D. API integration

Answer: B

Why: Native rules are simple threshold-based. For complex automation, use third-party tools or custom scripts.

Q2. [Applied] A bulk upload returns an error "Invalid max bid". What's the likely cause?

- A. Bid below \$0.02 or above \$1000
- B. Campaign is paused
- C. Wrong file format
- D. API rate limit hit

Answer: A

Why: Amazon requires bids between \$0.02 and \$1000. Outside that range, the upload fails.

Q3. [Applied] When should you build custom API automation?

- A. For every account
- B. When you have 100+ campaigns or want custom rules/integrations
- C. Never - native tools are enough
- D. Only for Vendor Central accounts

Answer: B

Why: Custom automation has high setup cost. Worth it at scale or for specific integration needs.

Q4. [Applied] Which is NOT a good use case for LLMs in PPC?

- A. Search term classification
- B. Negative keyword suggestions
- C. Direct bid changes without human review
- D. Report summarization

Answer: C

Why: LLMs lack context for safe bid changes. Always gate bid changes with human review.

Q5. [Advanced] What's the main benefit of Bulk Operations over UI edits?

- A. It's more accurate
- B. Mass edits are far faster for 100+ changes
- C. It's free
- D. It can't make mistakes

Answer: B

Why: Bulk files let you make 1000s of changes in one upload vs. clicking through the UI for each.

Teaching Guide

Suggested delivery time: 30 min lecture + 20 min bulk upload demo

Talking Points

- Open with the automation ladder: native rules -> bulk ops -> third-party tools -> custom API -> AI augmentation.
- Demo native bid rules live.
- Show a bulk file template and walk through the tabs.
- Demo an LLM classifying search terms (or screenshots).
- End with the human-in-the-loop guardrail - critical for AI safety.

Live-Demo Checklist

- Open Campaign Manager and create a native bid rule.
- Download a bulk file template.
- Make a sample bulk edit (raise 5 keyword bids by 10%).
- Upload and check for errors.
- Show (or screenshots of) an LLM classifying search terms.

Discussion Prompts

- Why is human-in-the-loop non-negotiable for AI-assisted bids?
- What's a workflow in your current account that could be bulk-automated?
- How would you decide between native rules, bulk ops, and custom scripts?

Handout Summary**DEFINITION**

Automation in Amazon PPC scales from native bid rules (simple thresholds) to bulk operations (mass edits) to custom API scripts (programmatic control) to AI augmentation (LLMs for classification and summarization). Human-in-the-loop is mandatory for AI-assisted bid changes.

On-the-Job Checklist

- I can create native bid and budget rules.
- I can download, edit, and upload bulk files without errors.
- I know when custom API automation is worth the setup cost.
- I never let LLMs make bid changes without human review.

17 Software & Tools Ecosystem

The PPC tool landscape is crowded. This section cuts through the noise and gives you a framework for choosing (or building) the right tools.

17.1 All-in-One Suites

Helium 10, Jungle Scout, SellerApp, Perpetua, Pacvue, Teikametrics

Helium 10 (\$39-\$279/month): best for keyword research (Cerebro, Magnet) and listing optimization. Light on bid automation. **Jungle Scout** (\$49-\$129/month): similar to Helium 10, popular with brand owners. **SellerApp** (\$49-\$199/month): solid analytics and keyword research. **Perpetua** (enterprise pricing): bid automation focused, owned by Sinobull. **Pacvue** (enterprise): full-funnel automation for large brands. **Teikametrics** (\$500+/month): bid automation with the Flywheel product.

Feature comparison matrix

Strength	Best For
Keyword research, listing audit	Agencies, growth-stage brands
Product research, listing tools	Brand owners
Bid automation	Mid-market agencies
Full-funnel automation	Enterprise brands
Bid automation (Flywheel)	Mid-market brands
Analytics + research	Small-to-mid brands

17.2 Point Solutions

Keyword research only, bid automation only, reporting only

Sometimes an all-in-one suite is overkill. Point solutions: **Keyword research only**: Helium 10 Cerebro standalone, Merchant Words. **Bid automation only**: Teikametrics Flywheel, Perpetua. **Reporting only**: DataHawk, Sellics. Point solutions are often cheaper than suites but require integrating multiple tools.

17.3 Build vs. Buy

When to build internal tooling

Build when: (1) you have unique workflows no tool supports, (2) you manage 5+ accounts and tool costs exceed \$5K/month, (3) you need tightly integrated data flows (PPC + inventory + CRM). The build-vs-buy breakeven is typically \$3K-\$10K/month in tool costs - above that, custom tooling becomes attractive.

Case study: Console Simulator / Tuman experience

Internal tools can be powerful but require ongoing maintenance. The Amazon Ads Console changes monthly - any internal tool that depends on console screenshots or specific UI flows needs constant updates. Build tools that depend on the API (more stable) rather than UI scraping (brittle).

17.4 Tool Evaluation Framework

Criteria checklist for evaluating new PPC software

Before adopting any tool, evaluate: (1) **cost vs. value** - does the time saved justify the subscription? (2) **data accuracy** - does it match Amazon's native reports? (3) **integration depth** - API access or just UI scraping? (4) **support quality** - response time, knowledge base, community. (5) **roadmap** - is the vendor actively shipping features? (6) **lock-in risk** - can you export your data if you leave? Trial every tool for 30 days before committing.

TRAINING LAYER

Learning Aid

Key Terms

All-in-one suite: Tool covering multiple PPC functions (research, automation, reporting).

Point solution: Tool focused on one function (e.g., bid automation only).

Build vs. buy breakeven: Typically \$3K-\$10K/month in tool costs; above this, custom tooling becomes attractive.

Tool evaluation framework: 6 criteria: cost, data accuracy, integration, support, roadmap, lock-in.

COMMON MISTAKES

Adopting 5+ tools that overlap. Most accounts need 1 all-in-one suite plus 1 point solution. More tools = more logins, more cost, more confusion.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Agency managing 10 accounts. Helium 10 (\$129/mo x 10 seats = \$1,290) + Teikametrics (\$500/mo x 10 = \$5,000) + Looker Studio (free) = \$6,290/month in tools. Above \$5K breakeven - consider building internal tooling. Estimated build cost: \$30K (one-time), \$2K/month maintenance. Break-even in 6 months.

Quiz: Test Your Understanding

Q1. [Foundational] Which tool is best known for keyword research (Cerebro, Magnet)?

- A. Perpetua
- B. Helium 10
- C. Pacvue
- D. Teikametrics

Answer: B

Why: Helium 10's Cerebro (reverse ASIN) and Magnet (seed-to-keyword) are industry-standard keyword research tools.

Q2. [Applied] When does building internal tooling typically make sense?

- A. Always - custom is better
- B. When tool costs exceed \$3K-\$10K/month or you have unique workflows
- C. Never - existing tools are sufficient
- D. Only for enterprise brands

Answer: B

Why: The build-vs-buy breakeven is typically \$3K-\$10K/month. Below that, buy. Above, consider building.

Q3. [Applied] What's a key risk of UI-scraping tools vs. API-based tools?

- A. UI scraping is faster
- B. Amazon changes UI monthly, breaking UI scrapers; APIs are more stable
- C. API tools are more expensive
- D. No difference

Answer: B

Why: UI scrapers break every time Amazon changes the console. API-based tools are more stable but require API access.

Q4. [Applied] Which is NOT one of the 6 tool evaluation criteria?

- A. Cost vs. value
- B. Data accuracy
- C. Founder's personality
- D. Integration depth

Answer: C

Why: The 6 criteria: cost, accuracy, integration, support, roadmap, lock-in. Founder personality doesn't affect tool utility.

Q5. [Advanced] Why is adopting 5+ overlapping tools a mistake?

- A. It's illegal
- B. More logins, more cost, more confusion; most accounts need 1 suite + 1 point solution
- C. Amazon penalizes multi-tool users
- D. It's fine - more tools = better

Answer: B

Why: Tool sprawl creates friction. Most accounts are best served by 1 all-in-one suite plus 1 specialized point solution.

Teaching Guide

Suggested delivery time: 30 min lecture + 15 min tool comparison exercise

Talking Points

- Open with the landscape map: all-in-one suites vs. point solutions vs. custom.
- Walk through the feature comparison matrix on screen.
- Demo one tool live (Helium 10 if available).
- Discuss build-vs-buy with the breakeven math.
- End with the 6-criteria evaluation framework.

Live-Demo Checklist

- Show Helium 10 (or screenshots) - Cerebro and Magnet.
- Compare to Perpetua or Teikametrics bid automation UI.
- Show the tool comparison matrix as a handout.
- Walk through the 6 evaluation criteria with a real tool example.
- Discuss the build-vs-buy calculation on a whiteboard.

Discussion Prompts

- If you had \$2,000/month for tools, what would you buy?
- What's a workflow in your account that no tool supports well?
- How would you convince a skeptical CFO to approve tool spend?

Handout Summary

DEFINITION

The PPC tool ecosystem includes all-in-one suites (Helium 10, Jungle Scout, Perpetua, Pacvue, Teikametrics), point solutions (single-function tools), and custom-built internal tools. Build-vs-buy breakeven is typically \$3K-\$10K/month. Evaluate tools on 6 criteria: cost, accuracy, integration, support, roadmap, lock-in.

On-the-Job Checklist

- I can name the 6 major all-in-one suites and their strengths.
- I know the build-vs-buy breakeven is \$3K-\$10K/month.
- I know API-based tools are more stable than UI scrapers.
- I can evaluate any new tool against the 6 criteria.

18 Strategy by Business Lifecycle Stage

Strategy depends on stage. What works at launch fails at maturity. This section covers the four lifecycle stages and the strategic shifts between them.

18.1 New Product Launch

Launch campaign structure

Launch structure: one Auto campaign (discovery) + one Broad campaign (seed keywords) + brand-name Exact campaign (defense). Budget split: 60% Auto, 30% Broad, 10% Brand Defense. Bids: 20-30% above mature levels to win impressions. Bidding strategy: Fixed bids (clean data) for first 2 weeks, then Dynamic down only.

Launch budget/ACOS tolerance expectations

Expect ACOS of 50-100%+ in weeks 1-4 (no reviews, low CVR). Set tolerance at 80% ACOS for the first 30 days. By day 60, target should drop to 40%. By day 90, target 25%. If ACOS is still above 60% at day 90, pause and audit the listing - CVR is too low.

Review velocity's role in launch success

Reviews are the #1 CVR driver. A product with 0 reviews converts at 2-5%; with 15 reviews at 4.0 stars, 8-12%; with 50 reviews at 4.3 stars, 12-18%. Use Amazon Vine (free for Brand Registry) to get first 30 reviews in weeks 4-8. Without reviews, no amount of ad spend will make the launch profitable.

18.2 Growth Stage

Scaling winning keywords

Once a keyword has 30+ clicks and 3+ conversions, scale it: raise bid 20%, add as Exact in dedicated Exact campaign, set TOS modifier +25%. Watch ACOS for 7 days. If ACOS stays below target, raise bid another 20%. Repeat until ACOS approaches target or TOS share exceeds 60%.

Expanding to new campaign types

Growth stage is when to add SB and SD. Launch SB brand defense campaign (targeting your brand name) - low ACOS, high visibility. Launch SD remarketing (targeting PDP viewers from last 30 days) - high CVR, easy win. Add these once SP is profitable.

18.3 Mature/Steady-State

Efficiency optimization focus

Mature accounts shift from growth to efficiency. Focus: lower ACOS on top 20 keywords by 5-10%, eliminate wasted spend on bottom 50 keywords (negate or pause), refine TOS modifiers based on 90-day data. Monthly optimization cadence: deep dive, quarterly: strategic shifts.

Long-tail harvesting maturity

Mature accounts have harvesting pipelines that produce 5-10 new Exact keywords per month from Auto/Broad. Track the pipeline: terms discovered -> terms harvested -> terms scaled. A healthy pipeline grows the Exact campaign by 10-20% per quarter.

18.4 Decline/Sunset

Budget wind-down strategy

When sunsetting a product (discontinuing, replacing with new version), wind down ads over 4 weeks: week 1, cut budget 50%; week 2, pause Broad and Auto; week 3, pause Phrase; week 4, pause Exact. Sudden ad cutoffs strand inventory that could have been sold through remaining ads.

Liquidation-adjacent ad strategy

For liquidation (selling off remaining inventory), increase coupon to 20-30%, run a Lightning Deal, and increase Exact bids 30% to drive sell-through. Accept ACOS up to 60% - the goal is inventory clearance, not profitability. Stop ads when inventory hits zero.

TRAINING LAYER

Learning Aid

Key Terms

Launch stage: First 90 days; high ACOS tolerance (50-100%), focus on discovery and reviews.

Growth stage: Months 4-12; scale winning keywords, add SB and SD.

Mature stage: Year 2+; efficiency optimization, long-tail harvesting.

Sunset stage: Discontinuation; gradual budget wind-down over 4 weeks.

COMMON MISTAKES

Expecting launch ACOS to match mature ACOS. A new product with 0 reviews will have 50%+ ACOS. Plan for this; don't pause campaigns that are doing exactly what launches do.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Day 1 launch: Auto \$30/day, Broad \$20/day, Brand Defense \$5/day. ACOS week 1: 95%. Day 30: ACOS 60%, scaled Broad to \$40/day. Day 60: ACOS 35%, added Exact campaign \$25/day. Day 90: ACOS 22%, launched SB Brand Defense and SD remarketing. Total spend at day 90: \$130/day, ACOS 22%, TACOS 12%.

Quiz: Test Your Understanding

Q1. [Foundational] What ACOS should you expect in weeks 1-4 of a new product launch?

- A. 5-10%
- B. 20-30%
- C. 50-100%+
- D. 200%+

Answer: C

Why: Launch ACOS is high (50-100%+) due to no reviews and low CVR. This is normal and expected.

Q2. [Applied] What's the most important CVR driver for a new product?

- A. Ad position
- B. Coupon
- C. Reviews
- D. Backend keywords

Answer: C

Why: Reviews drive CVR more than any other factor. Use Amazon Vine to get first 30 reviews.

Q3. [Applied] When should you add SB and SD campaigns?

- A. At launch
- B. Growth stage (once SP is profitable)
- C. Never
- D. Only when sales decline

Answer: B

Why: SP foundation should be profitable first. Adding SB/SD at launch spreads budget too thin.

Q4. [Applied] How should you wind down ads when sunseting a product?

- A. Pause all ads immediately
- B. Gradual 4-week wind-down: 50% cut, pause Broad/Auto, pause Phrase, pause Exact
- C. Increase ad spend to clear inventory
- D. Stop ads but keep campaigns running

Answer: B

Why: Gradual wind-down sells through remaining inventory at each stage. Sudden cutoffs strand inventory.

Q5. [Advanced] What ACOS tolerance is acceptable for liquidation?

- A. 5%
- B. 15%
- C. Up to 60% (goal is clearance, not profitability)
- D. 0% - never accept high ACOS

Answer: C

Why: Liquidation is about clearing inventory, not profitability. Accept higher ACOS to drive sell-through.

Teaching Guide

Suggested delivery time: 30 min lecture + 20 min lifecycle mapping exercise

Talking Points

- Open with the lifecycle arc: launch -> growth -> mature -> sunset.
- Walk through launch structure and ACOS expectations honestly - don't sugarcoat.
- Demo growth-stage scaling decisions with sample data.
- Show mature-stage efficiency optimization with a real account.
- End with sunset strategy - overlooked but important.

Live-Demo Checklist

- Draw the lifecycle timeline on a whiteboard with ACOS targets at each stage.
- Show a real launch campaign's first 90 days of data.
- Walk through a growth-stage scaling decision on a sample keyword.
- Show a mature account's long-tail harvesting pipeline.
- Demonstrate the 4-week sunset wind-down plan.

Discussion Prompts

- Why is launch ACOS so much higher than mature ACOS?
- If you had to delay launch by 2 weeks, what would you do with that time?
- How would you explain to a client that 80% ACOS at launch is healthy?

Handout Summary

DEFINITION

Amazon PPC strategy varies by lifecycle stage. Launch (0-90 days): high ACOS tolerance (50-100%), focus on reviews and discovery. Growth (4-12 months): scale winning keywords, add SB/SD. Mature (year 2+): efficiency optimization and long-tail harvesting. Sunset: gradual 4-week wind-down.

KEY FORMULA

Launch ACOS targets: Day 30 = 80%, Day 60 = 40%, Day 90 = 25%. If above 60% at Day 90, pause and audit listing.

On-the-Job Checklist

- I know the ACOS tolerance for each lifecycle stage.
- I know reviews are the #1 CVR driver for new products.
- I know to add SB/SD only after SP is profitable.
- I know to wind down ads gradually over 4 weeks when sunsetting.

19 Strategy by Product Category

Different categories behave differently. A \$5 impulse buy and a \$500 high-consideration purchase need very different PPC strategies. This section covers the four main category archetypes.

19.1 High-Consideration / High-Price Categories

Longer attribution windows, different CVR expectations

High-price products (\$100+) have longer research cycles. Shoppers may click your ad on day 1, comparison-shop for a week, then buy on day 10. The 14-day click attribution window captures most of these, but you'll see lower CVR (3-7%) than low-price categories. Bid lower per click but accept higher CPCs - the math still works because each sale is \$100+.

19.2 Low-Price / Impulse Categories

Volume-driven strategy, different bid tolerance

Low-price products (\$5-\$20) live on volume. CVR is higher (10-20%+) because impulse buys need less deliberation, but margins are tight. Bid tolerance is low - a \$0.80 CPC on a \$10 product needs 12.5% CVR just to break even. Strategy: aggressive long-tail harvesting (lower CPC), avoid head terms (too expensive), rely on Auto for discovery.

19.3 Seasonal/Gift Categories

Compressed-window strategy

Seasonal products (holiday decor, summer outdoor, back-to-school) have a 4-12 week sales window. Strategy: scale ads aggressively 4 weeks before peak, peak spend during 2-week window, wind down 1 week after. Off-season: pause all ads to save budget. Plan inventory and ads together - running out of stock during peak is the worst outcome.

19.4 Regulated Categories (Supplements, etc.)

Compliance constraints affecting ad approval

Regulated categories (supplements, CBD, medical devices, baby products) have stricter ad approval. Amazon rejects ads with health claims, disease references, or unverified benefits. Strategy: avoid specific claims in ad copy and listing bullets, use generic benefit language ('supports wellness' not 'cures anxiety'), expect 2-3x rejection rates, and budget extra time for appeals. Some categories require Category Approval before advertising.

TRAINING LAYER

Learning Aid

Key Terms

High-consideration: \$100+ products with longer research cycles; lower CVR, higher CPC tolerance.

Impulse buy: \$5-\$20 products with short decision cycles; higher CVR, tight margins.

Seasonal: Products with 4-12 week sales windows; requires aggressive pre-peak scaling.

Regulated: Categories with ad approval restrictions (supplements, CBD, medical, baby).

COMMON MISTAKES

Applying the same strategy across categories. A supplements brand can't use the aggressive claims that work for fitness equipment - Amazon will reject the ads.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Three clients: \$300 headphones (high-consideration), \$12 lip balm (impulse), \$25 holiday wreath (seasonal). Headphones: \$2 CPC target, 5% CVR, \$60 CPA. Lip balm: \$0.40 CPC target, 15% CVR, \$2.67 CPA. Wreath: scale Oct 1, peak Nov 15-Dec 10, pause Dec 20. Each needs different bid, budget, and timing strategy.

Quiz: Test Your Understanding

Q1. [Foundational] A \$300 electronic product typically has what CVR range?

- A. 20-30%
- B. 10-15%
- C. 3-7%
- D. 0-1%

Answer: C

Why: High-consideration products have longer research cycles and lower CVR (3-7%).

Q2. [Applied] A \$10 impulse product needs what CPC to break even at 15% CVR?

- A. \$0.50
- B. \$1.50
- C. \$2.50
- D. \$5.00

Answer: B

Why: Break-even CPC = price x CVR = \$10 x 0.15 = \$1.50. Above this loses money.

Q3. [Applied] When should you scale ads for a holiday seasonal product?

- A. Day of holiday

- B. 1 week before peak
- C. 4 weeks before peak
- D. 6 months before peak

Answer: C

Why: Scale 4 weeks before peak to let algorithms calibrate. Peak spend during 2-week window, wind down 1 week after.

Q4. [Foundational] Why do supplements face stricter ad approval?

- A. Higher taxes
- B. Amazon's policy against health claims and disease references
- C. More competition
- D. Lower margins

Answer: B

Why: Supplements are a regulated category. Amazon rejects ads with health claims, disease references, or unverified benefits.

Q5. [Advanced] What's a key risk for seasonal products during peak?

- A. Ads get more expensive
- B. Running out of stock mid-peak
- C. Reviews disappear
- D. Competitors copy listings

Answer: B

Why: Running out of stock during peak is the worst outcome - you miss the sales window and lose momentum. Plan inventory and ads together.

Teaching Guide

Suggested delivery time: 30 min lecture + 20 min category comparison exercise

Talking Points

- Open with the four category archetypes on a 2x2 matrix.
- Walk through high-consideration vs. impulse with break-even math.
- Demo seasonal planning calendar for a sample product.
- Show regulated category ad rejection examples.
- End with the inventory-ads coordination point for seasonal.

Live-Demo Checklist

- Draw the category 2x2 matrix on a whiteboard.
- Calculate break-even CPC for \$300 headphones vs. \$10 lip balm.
- Show a seasonal product's 12-month sales curve.
- Show a rejected supplements ad (or screenshot) and explain the policy.
- Walk through the seasonal scaling calendar.

Discussion Prompts

- Why can't you apply the same ACOS target across categories?
- How would you adjust strategy for a \$500 product vs. a \$15 product?
- What's one regulated category workaround for ad copy?

Handout Summary

DEFINITION

Amazon PPC strategy varies by category. High-consideration (\$100+): lower CVR (3-7%), higher CPC tolerance. Impulse (\$5-\$20): higher CVR (10-20%), tight margins. Seasonal: compressed 4-12 week window, aggressive pre-peak scaling. Regulated: stricter ad approval, avoid health claims.

KEY FORMULA

Break-even CPC = price x CVR. Adjust strategy based on whether this leaves room for profitable bidding.

On-the-Job Checklist

- I can identify which category archetype a product fits.
- I know high-consideration products have lower CVR but higher CPC tolerance.
- I know seasonal products need 4-week pre-peak scaling.
- I know regulated categories face ad approval restrictions.

20 Seasonal & Event Planning

Amazon has 4-6 major events per year that drive massive traffic spikes. Planning around them is the difference between a record month and a missed opportunity.

20.1 Prime Day Playbook

Pre-event, during-event, post-event phases

Pre-event (Day -14 to Day -1): scale budgets 2x baseline, raise bids 20% on top keywords, ensure inventory is in stock, create Prime Day-specific coupon. **During-event (Day 0-1):** scale budgets 4-5x baseline, monitor every 2 hours, be ready to pause underperformers. **Post-event (Day 2-7):** gradual wind-down (1.5x for 3 days, 1.2x for 4 days, then baseline).

Budget and bid scaling timeline

T-14 days: budget 1.5x, bids +10%. T-7 days: budget 2x, bids +20%. T-1 day: budget 3x, bids +30%. Day 0-1: budget 4-5x, bids +30%, monitor hourly. T+1 day: budget 1.5x, bids back to baseline. T+7 days: back to normal. The pre-event ramp lets algorithms calibrate; the post-event wind-down preserves momentum.

20.2 Q4 / Holiday Playbook

Black Friday/Cyber Monday specific tactics

BFCM (late November) is the biggest shopping weekend of the year. Scale budgets 3x for BFCM weekend specifically. Create BFCM-specific coupons and Lightning Deals. Use SD aggressively for retargeting (shoppers browsing deals are highly convertible). Stock up inventory 8 weeks ahead - Q4 out-of-stocks are catastrophic.

Inventory-aware bid throttling

If inventory drops below 14 days of cover, throttle bids 30% to slow sell-through. Below 7 days, pause non-branded campaigns. Below 3 days, pause all ads except brand defense. The goal: don't run out of stock during Q4 - the lost sales and rank damage take months to recover.

20.3 Other Key Dates

Back to School, Spring Cleaning, category-specific peaks

Back to School (late July to early September): big for supplies, electronics, apparel. Scale 1.5x for 6 weeks. **Spring Cleaning** (March-April): big for home organization, cleaning supplies. Scale 1.3x for 6 weeks. **Category-specific peaks**: fitness (January resolutioners), outdoor (Memorial Day to July 4), baby (Q4 gift-giving). Track your category's annual sales curve and plan accordingly.

TRAINING LAYER

Learning Aid

Key Terms

Prime Day: Amazon's annual 2-day sale (usually July); 3-5x baseline traffic.

BFCM: Black Friday/Cyber Monday weekend; biggest shopping weekend of the year.

Inventory-aware bidding: Throttling bids based on inventory cover to prevent stockouts.

Pre-event ramp: 2-week budget/bid scaling before an event to let algorithms calibrate.

COMMON MISTAKES

Crashing budgets back to baseline the day after Prime Day. Algorithm deprioritizes sudden spend drops; recovery takes weeks. Always ramp down gradually.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Prime Day plan for \$100/day baseline account: T-14: \$200/day. T-7: \$250/day. T-1: \$300/day. Day 0-1: \$500/day with hourly monitoring. T+1 to T+3: \$200/day. T+4 to T+7: \$130/day. T+8: back to \$100. Total Prime Day week: ~\$2,500 vs. baseline \$700. Expected sales lift: 4-5x.

Quiz: Test Your Understanding

Q1. [Foundational] When should you start pre-event ramp for Prime Day?

- A. Day of event
- B. 1 week before
- C. 2 weeks before (T-14)
- D. 1 month before

Answer: C

Why: T-14 days gives algorithms time to calibrate to higher budgets and bids.

Q2. [Applied] Inventory drops below 7 days of cover. What should you do?

- A. Increase ad spend to clear inventory faster
- B. Pause all ads except brand defense
- C. Pause all ads immediately
- D. Nothing - inventory will replenish

Answer: B

Why: Below 7 days, throttle to prevent stockout. Pause non-branded campaigns; keep brand defense to maintain visibility.

Q3. [Applied] How should budgets change on BFCM weekend specifically?

- A. Same as baseline
- B. 1.5x baseline
- C. 3x baseline
- D. Cut budgets - too competitive

Answer: C

Why: BFCM is the biggest shopping weekend. Scale 3x to capture traffic spike.

Q4. [Applied] Why ramp down gradually after Prime Day?

- A. Amazon doesn't allow sudden cuts
- B. Algorithm deprioritizes campaigns with sudden spend drops
- C. To keep agency fees high
- D. It doesn't matter

Answer: B

Why: Sudden spend drops signal reduced campaign activity to Amazon's algorithm, lowering auction priority. Recovery takes weeks.

Q5. [Advanced] Back to School season typically runs when?

- A. January
- B. Late July to early September
- C. November only
- D. Year-round

Answer: B

Why: Back to School is a 6-week window from late July through early September. Scale 1.5x during this period.

Teaching Guide

Suggested delivery time: 30 min lecture + 20 min Prime Day planning exercise

Talking Points

- Open with the annual event calendar on a whiteboard.
- Walk through Prime Day playbook (pre, during, post) with sample numbers.
- Demo inventory-aware bid throttling decisions.
- Show BFCM-specific tactics (Lightning Deals, SD retargeting).
- End with the gradual wind-down - the most violated rule.

Live-Demo Checklist

- Draw the annual event calendar with Prime Day, BFCM, Back to School marked.
- Walk through a 14-day Prime Day scaling plan on a whiteboard.
- Show inventory cover calculation: daily sales rate vs. inventory on hand.
- Walk through the bid throttling decision tree (14 days, 7 days, 3 days).
- Show a sample BFCM creative (Lightning Deal + coupon + SD retargeting).

Discussion Prompts

- Why is the post-event wind-down counterintuitive but correct?
- If you had \$5,000 extra budget for Prime Day, how would you allocate it?
- How would you explain inventory-aware bidding to a non-technical inventory manager?

Handout Summary

DEFINITION

Amazon has 4-6 major events per year (Prime Day, BFCM, Back to School, etc.) that drive 2-5x traffic spikes. Plan with 14-day pre-event ramp, aggressive during-event scaling, and 7-day gradual post-event wind-down. Inventory-aware bid throttling prevents stockouts during peak.

KEY FORMULA

Prime Day scaling: T-14 = 1.5x, T-7 = 2x, T-1 = 3x, Day 0-1 = 4-5x, T+1 to T+3 = 1.5x, T+4 to T+7 = 1.2x, then baseline.

On-the-Job Checklist

- I know the major Amazon events and their typical timing.
- I plan pre-event ramps 14 days ahead.
- I ramp down budgets gradually post-event, never crash.
- I throttle bids based on inventory cover (14d, 7d, 3d triggers).

21 International & Multi-Marketplace PPC

Selling on Amazon's international marketplaces (UK, DE, JP, etc.) introduces new variables: language, currency, competition. This section covers what changes and what stays the same.

21.1 Marketplace Differences

US vs. UK/EU vs. Canada vs. Australia nuances

US: largest marketplace, most competition, highest CPCs, most mature ad features. **UK:** ~25% of US volume, lower CPCs, slightly behind US on feature rollouts. **Germany (DE):** largest EU market, strict compliance rules on claims and pricing. **Japan (JP):** unique shopping culture, Rakuten is bigger competitor, requires localized creative. **Canada (CA):** ~10% of US volume, often managed as US extension. **Australia (AU):** smaller but growing, lower competition.

Currency, language, and cultural keyword differences

Currency: each marketplace reports in local currency. Use Amazon's currency converter for comparison or normalize all to USD in reporting. **Language:** keywords must be in the local language - don't translate directly, use native keyword research (German shoppers search differently than English shoppers even for the same product). **Culture:** gift-giving occasions, seasonal peaks, and color/symbol meanings differ.

21.2 Cross-Marketplace Account Structure

Centralized vs. localized management models

Centralized: one agency/team manages all marketplaces from one location. Pros: consistent strategy, easier reporting. Cons: language barriers, time zone challenges.

Localized: separate teams per marketplace (or per region). Pros: deep local knowledge, native language. Cons: harder to maintain consistency, more expensive. Most agencies hybrid: centralized strategy + localized execution.

21.3 Localization Considerations

Working with regional languages in keyword research

Direct translation fails for PPC. 'Yoga mat' in German is 'Yogamatte' (one word), but shoppers also search 'Yoga Matte' (two words) and 'Yogamatten' (plural). Use native keyword tools (Helium 10 supports DE/FR/UK/JP), work with native speakers for seed keywords, and validate with Brand Analytics SQP for that marketplace. Backend keywords also need localization.

Non-English keyword research workflow

Workflow: (1) Start with English seed keywords. (2) Have a native speaker translate to natural local phrases (not literal). (3) Run through local keyword tool (Helium 10 DE, etc.). (4) Validate with SQP for that marketplace. (5) Build campaigns in local language. (6) Have native speaker review ad copy and listings for cultural fit. Skipping any step leads to wasted spend.

TRAINING LAYER

Learning Aid

Key Terms

Marketplace: Amazon's regional platform (US, UK, DE, JP, etc.); each has separate account and reporting.

Centralized management: One team manages all marketplaces; consistent strategy, language challenges.

Localized management: Separate teams per marketplace; deep local knowledge, higher cost.

Currency normalization: Converting all marketplace reports to a single currency (usually USD) for comparison.

COMMON MISTAKES

Direct-translating English keywords to other languages. German "Yogamatte" is one word; literal translation "Yoga Matte" misses 60% of search volume.

WORKED EXAMPLE

US brand expanding to DE. English keywords: "yoga mat", "exercise mat", "pilates mat". Direct translation: "Yoga-Matte", "Übungsmatte", "Pilates-Matte". Native speaker corrects: "Yogamatte" (one word), "Gymnastikmatte" (more common than Übungsmatte), "Pilatesmatte" (one word). SQP validation confirms native speaker version gets 5x more searches.

Quiz: Test Your Understanding

Q1. [Foundational] Which marketplace is the largest and most competitive?

- A. UK
- B. Germany
- C. US
- D. Japan

Answer: C

Why: The US is Amazon's largest marketplace with the most competition and highest CPCs.

Q2. [Applied] Why doesn't direct translation work for keywords?

- A. Amazon doesn't allow translated keywords
- B. Native speakers use different phrasing than literal translation (e.g., one word vs. two)
- C. Translation tools are inaccurate
- D. It works fine - direct translation is reliable

Answer: B

Why: Native speakers phrase searches differently than literal translations. "Yogamatte" (one word) vs. "Yoga Matte" (literal) is a real example.

Q3. [Applied] What's a benefit of centralized cross-marketplace management?

- A. Native language fluency
- B. Consistent strategy and easier reporting
- C. Lower total cost
- D. Better cultural fit

Answer: B

Why: Centralized gives consistency but sacrifices native language depth. Most agencies hybrid: centralized strategy + localized execution.

Q4. [Applied] Which tool is best for validating non-English keywords?

- A. Google Translate
- B. Brand Analytics SQP for that specific marketplace
- C. Amazon US SQP
- D. Any third-party tool

Answer: B

Why: SQP is first-party Amazon data showing actual shopper searches in that marketplace. Use it for validation.

Q5. [Advanced] Why does Germany (DE) require special compliance attention?

- A. Higher taxes
- B. Strict rules on pricing claims and health claims
- C. Language complexity
- D. Smaller market size

Answer: B

Why: Germany has strict consumer protection laws. Pricing claims must include VAT, health claims are restricted, and advertising rules are tighter than the US.

Teaching Guide

Suggested delivery time: 25 min lecture + 15 min localization exercise

Talking Points

- Open with the marketplace map: US, UK, DE, FR, IT, ES, JP, CA, AU, IN, etc.
- Compare CPC, volume, and feature maturity across top marketplaces.
- Walk through the centralized vs. localized tradeoff.
- Demo the keyword localization workflow with a real example.
- End with the cultural nuance point - direct translation fails.

Live-Demo Checklist

- Show a Seller Central account with multiple marketplaces.
- Compare search volume for the same product concept across US/UK/DE.
- Walk through a German keyword research workflow.
- Show currency conversion in reporting.
- Demo SQP for a non-US marketplace (if access).

Discussion Prompts

- Why would a brand delay international expansion even if eligible?
- If you had to pick one non-US marketplace to expand to first, which and why?
- How would you convince a skeptical CFO to invest in localization?

Handout Summary

DEFINITION

Amazon operates 20+ international marketplaces, each with separate accounts, currency, and language. CPC, volume, and feature maturity vary by marketplace. Direct keyword translation fails - use native speakers and validate with local SQP. Choose between centralized (consistent) and localized (native) management.

On-the-Job Checklist

- I know the major Amazon marketplaces and their relative sizes.
- I know direct translation doesn't work for keywords.
- I can validate non-English keywords with local SQP.
- I know the tradeoffs between centralized and localized management.

22 Agency & Team Operations

How an agency runs internally determines client outcomes. This section covers roles, SOPs, VA training, and QA - the operational backbone of any PPC practice.

22.1 Team Roles & RACI

Strategist, Analyst, VA/Executor roles defined

VA/Executor: daily execution - bid changes, budget pacing, search term report pulls, bulk uploads. 1-2 hours per account per week. **Analyst:** weekly reporting, anomaly detection, deep-dive analysis. 2-4 hours per account per week. **Strategist:** monthly strategy, client communication, lifecycle decisions. 2-3 hours per account per month. **Senior Strategist:** quarterly planning, cross-account patterns, escalations. 1 hour per account per quarter.

Escalation paths

Tier 1 (VA): handles standard optimizations, flags anomalies to Analyst. Tier 2 (Analyst): handles anomalies, flags strategic issues to Strategist. Tier 3 (Strategist): handles strategic shifts, flags relationship issues to Senior Strategist. Tier 4 (Senior Strategist): handles client relationship escalations. Document the escalation tree so VAs know when to surface vs. handle independently.

22.2 SOPs & Workflow Documentation

Weekly optimization checklist template

Weekly per account: (1) Pull Search Term Report, (2) Sort by spend, identify top 20 keywords, (3) Adjust bids on top 20 based on ACOS vs. target, (4) Identify wasted-spend terms (10+ clicks, 0 orders), (5) Add as negatives, (6) Identify harvested candidates (2+ orders, ACOS < 30%), (7) Promote to Exact and negative in source, (8) Check budget pacing, raise budgets on starved performers, (9) Document changes in changelog, (10) Send summary to Strategist.

Onboarding SOP for new client accounts

Week 1: account audit (structure, naming, performance baselines). Week 2: clean up existing structure, document naming convention. Week 3: launch missing campaigns (Auto, Exact, Brand Defense). Week 4: first optimization cycle. Week 5: first client report. Week 6: strategy meeting with client. Document this timeline as the standard onboarding SOP.

22.3 VA Training & Enablement

Training curriculum outline

5-day VA bootcamp: Day 1 - foundations (sections 1-2 of this wiki). Day 2 - campaign types and targeting (sections 3-4). Day 3 - keyword research and bidding (sections 5-6). Day 4 - negatives and metrics (sections 9-10). Day 5 - reporting and tools (sections 11, 17). Each day includes a quiz and a hands-on exercise on a sandbox account. Pass threshold: 80% on quizzes, completion of all exercises.

Certification/competency checklist for VAs

Competency checklist: (1) Can pull and interpret Search Term Report, (2) Can identify wasted-spend terms and add negatives, (3) Can identify harvested candidates and promote with negative-out, (4) Can adjust bids based on ACOS vs. target, (5) Can identify budget-starved campaigns and raise budgets, (6) Can produce weekly summary report. Sign-off by Strategist required before VA works on live client accounts.

22.4 QA & Review Process

Peer review of bid/budget changes before execution

Any change >20% on top 20 keywords requires peer review. The reviewer asks: (1) Is the change based on sufficient data (30+ clicks)? (2) Is the direction correct (raising on low ACOS, lowering on high)? (3) Are there downstream impacts (cannibalization, budget shifts)? Reviewer signs off in changelog. Catches ~10% of errors before they hit production.

Change-log discipline (who changed what, when, why)

Every change logged: date, person, campaign, change type (bid, budget, keyword, negative), old value, new value, reason. Format: shared Google Sheet or dedicated changelog tool. Review monthly for patterns (e.g., 'VA X makes 30% more bid errors than VA Y' - needs coaching). Without changelogs, you can't diagnose what caused a performance shift.

TRAINING LAYER

Learning Aid

Key Terms

VA (Virtual Assistant): Executor role handling daily optimizations: bids, budgets, search term reports.

RACI: Responsible, Accountable, Consulted, Informed - framework for clarifying roles.

Escalation path: Tiered system for surfacing issues from VA to Analyst to Strategist to Senior.

Changelog: Log of every campaign change with date, person, old/new values, and reason.

COMMON MISTAKES

VAs making >20% bid changes without peer review. One misread ACOS column can lead to a 50% bid cut that destroys a top performer for a week.

WORKED EXAMPLE

VA notices keyword "yoga mat" has ACOS of 40% (target 25%). Wants to lower bid 30%. Peer reviewer checks: 35 clicks in last 14 days, ACOS confirmed at 40%, no recent TOS share change. Approves. Bid cut from \$1.20 to \$0.84. Logged in changelog: "2024-10-15, VA Maria, YogaMat-Exact, bid, \$1.20 -> \$0.84, ACOS 40% vs target 25%".

Quiz: Test Your Understanding

Q1. [Foundational] What's the typical time allocation for a VA per account per week?

- A. 10-15 hours
- B. 5-8 hours
- C. 1-2 hours
- D. 20+ hours

Answer: C

Why: VAs handle execution: bid changes, search term reports, bulk uploads. 1-2 hours per account per week is standard.

Q2. [Applied] When should a VA escalate to the Analyst?

- A. For every bid change
- B. For anomalies outside normal patterns (e.g., sudden ACOS spike, campaign stops spending)
- C. Never - VAs handle everything
- D. Only when client complains

Answer: B

Why: VAs handle standard optimizations. Anomalies (sudden spikes, campaigns stopping) get escalated to Analyst.

Q3. [Applied] What's the peer review threshold for bid changes?

- A. All bid changes
- B. Changes >20% on top 20 keywords
- C. No peer review needed
- D. Changes >50% on any keyword

Answer: B

Why: Changes >20% on top 20 keywords require peer review. Catches ~10% of errors before production.

Q4. [Applied] What should every changelog entry include?

- A. Just the date
- B. Date, person, campaign, change type, old/new values, reason
- C. Only the new value
- D. Only the reason

Answer: B

Why: Full context: who, what, when, why. Without all fields, you can't diagnose what caused a performance shift.

Q5. [Advanced] Why require VA competency sign-off before live client work?

- A. To justify agency fees
- B. To prevent costly mistakes on live campaigns and ensure quality baseline
- C. Amazon requires it
- D. It doesn't matter - VAs learn on the job

Answer: B

Why: Live client campaigns aren't the place to learn. Competency sign-off ensures VAs can execute safely before touching real money.

Teaching Guide

Suggested delivery time: 35 min lecture + 25 min role-play exercise

Talking Points

- Open with the RACI matrix - clarify who does what.
- Walk through the weekly optimization checklist step by step.
- Demo the changelog format with a real example.
- Role-play a peer review: VA proposes change, reviewer asks questions.
- End with the 5-day VA bootcamp curriculum.

Live-Demo Checklist

- Show a sample RACI matrix on a whiteboard.
- Walk through the weekly checklist with a real account.
- Show the changelog Google Sheet template.
- Role-play a peer review (5 min).
- Show the VA competency checklist.

Discussion Prompts

- Why is changelog discipline non-negotiable?
- What's the right escalation threshold for a VA?
- How would you handle a VA who consistently makes bid errors?

Handout Summary

DEFINITION

Agency operations include role definition (VA, Analyst, Strategist, Senior), SOPs (weekly checklist, onboarding), VA training (5-day bootcamp), and QA (peer review, changelogs). Disciplined operations prevent costly mistakes and enable consistent client service.

On-the-Job Checklist

- I know the 4 roles and their typical time allocation per account.
- I can execute the weekly optimization checklist.
- I know when to escalate vs. handle independently.
- I log every change in the changelog with full context.

23 Client & Stakeholder Communication

PPC skills are half the job. The other half is communicating results in a way that builds trust and aligns expectations. This section covers reporting cadence, expectation-setting, and difficult conversations.

23.1 Reporting Cadence

Weekly/monthly/quarterly report structures by audience

Weekly (operator-level): 1-page summary with spend, sales, ACOS, TACOS, top 3 changes made, top 3 issues flagged. For internal team and operationally-involved clients. **Monthly** (stakeholder-level): 3-5 page report with executive summary, performance vs. targets, key initiatives, next month priorities. For brand owners and marketing managers. **Quarterly** (executive-level): 10-15 page strategic review with year-over-year comparisons, market context, strategic recommendations. For C-suite and board presentations.

23.2 Setting Expectations

Explaining ACOS volatility to non-technical stakeholders

ACOS swings 10-30% week-to-week naturally due to: competitor behavior, seasonality, organic rank fluctuations, and Amazon's algorithm updates. Explain this to clients upfront. Use a rolling 4-week average in reports to smooth noise. When ACOS spikes, explain the likely cause (competitor launched aggressive campaign, prime day effect, etc.) rather than apologizing. Context builds trust; apologies erode it.

Managing expectations during launch phases

Before launch, set expectations in writing: 'Weeks 1-4: ACOS will be 50-100%. Weeks 5-8: ACOS will drop to 30-50%. Weeks 9-12: ACOS should reach target of 25%.' Send weekly updates with current ACOS and trajectory. This prevents the panic call in week 3 when ACOS is 80% - the client already knew to expect it.

23.3 Handling Difficult Conversations

Explaining underperformance without losing trust

Framework: (1) Acknowledge the issue directly - don't hide from it. (2) Diagnose the cause with data - 'ACOS spiked because competitor X launched a 30% coupon.' (3) Propose a specific action - 'I'm raising bids on our top 5 keywords by 15% to defend share.' (4) Set a check-in date - 'I'll report back in 7 days.' This 4-part framework maintains trust even when results are bad.

Renegotiating goals mid-engagement

Sometimes goals need to change. Maybe the client wants to scale spend 2x but ACOS will rise. Or they want to cut spend 30% and accept lower sales. Framework: (1) Present the trade-off clearly with numbers - '2x spend -> 1.6x sales -> ACOS rises from 22% to 28%.' (2) Let the client choose. (3) Document the decision in writing. (4) Update reporting targets. Don't make the decision for them; your job is to inform.

TRAINING LAYER

Learning Aid

Key Terms

Rolling 4-week average: Smoothing metric that reduces weekly ACOS volatility noise in client reports.

Launch expectation letter: Written ACOS trajectory sent to client before launch to prevent panic calls.

4-part underperformance framework: Acknowledge -> Diagnose with data -> Propose action -> Set check-in date.

Goal renegotiation: Mid-engagement adjustment of targets due to changing client priorities.

COMMON MISTAKES

Apologizing when ACOS spikes. Apologies erode trust. Instead, explain the cause with data and propose action - this builds trust.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Client calls: "Why is ACOS at 35% this week?" Wrong response: "I'm sorry, we'll fix it." Right response: "ACOS spiked to 35% because competitor X launched a 30% coupon on Tuesday, drawing price-sensitive shoppers. Our CVR dropped from 12% to 8%. I've added X as a negative ASIN target and raised our brand defense bids 15%. I'll report back Friday with the impact."

Quiz: Test Your Understanding

Q1. [Foundational] What should a weekly client report include?

- A. 50 metrics with no commentary
- B. 1-page summary: spend, sales, ACOS, TACOS, top 3 changes, top 3 issues
- C. Just the budget spent
- D. Full Search Term Report

Answer: B

Why: Weekly reports should be 1 page, focused on key metrics and action items. Save deep dives for monthly.

Q2. [Applied] Why use a rolling 4-week average in client reports?

- A. To hide underperformance
- B. To smooth weekly ACOS volatility and show true trend
- C. To make numbers look better
- D. Amazon requires it

Answer: B

Why: ACOS swings 10-30% weekly naturally. Rolling 4-week average smooths the noise and shows the true trend.

Q3. [Applied] ACOS spikes to 35% (target 25%). What's the right client response?

- A. Apologize and promise to fix
- B. Acknowledge, diagnose with data, propose action, set check-in date
- C. Don't mention it - hope they don't notice
- D. Blame Amazon

Answer: B

Why: The 4-part framework (acknowledge, diagnose, propose, check-in) maintains trust. Apologies erode it.

Q4. [Applied] When should you set launch ACOS expectations in writing?

- A. Week 3 when ACOS spikes
- B. Before launch (week 0)
- C. At month 3 review
- D. Never - just let it happen

Answer: B

Why: Set expectations in writing before launch. This prevents the panic call in week 3 when ACOS is 80%.

Q5. [Advanced] Client wants to scale spend 2x. What's the right approach?

- A. Just do it
- B. Present the trade-off with numbers (2x spend -> 1.6x sales -> ACOS rises), let client choose, document decision
- C. Refuse - it's too risky
- D. Do it but don't tell them the trade-offs

Answer: B

Why: Your job is to inform, not decide. Present trade-offs with numbers, let the client choose, document the decision.

Teaching Guide

Suggested delivery time: 30 min lecture + 20 min role-play

Talking Points

- Open with the half-and-half framing: PPC skills + communication skills = client retention.
- Walk through weekly vs. monthly vs. quarterly report structures.
- Demo the 4-part underperformance framework with a role-play.
- Show a launch expectation letter template.
- End with the "don't apologize, explain" principle.

Live-Demo Checklist

- Show a sample weekly report template.
- Show a sample monthly report with executive summary.
- Role-play a difficult conversation: ACOS spike (5 min).
- Show a launch expectation letter.
- Role-play a goal renegotiation (5 min).

Discussion Prompts

- Why do apologies erode trust in client communication?
- What's one client communication mistake you've seen or made?
- How would you handle a client who wants to micromanage bid changes?

Handout Summary

DEFINITION

Client communication includes structured reporting (weekly/monthly/quarterly by audience), expectation-setting (launch letters, rolling averages), and difficult conversations (4-part framework: acknowledge, diagnose, propose, check-in). Trust is built through context and action, not apologies.

On-the-Job Checklist

- I produce weekly, monthly, and quarterly reports with appropriate depth.
- I use rolling 4-week averages to smooth ACOS volatility.
- I set launch expectations in writing before campaigns start.
- I use the 4-part framework for underperformance conversations.

24 Compliance, Policy & Account Health

Amazon's policies are strict and enforcement is automated. One violation can suspend your account and stop all advertising. This section covers the rules that matter most.

24.1 Advertising Policy Basics

Prohibited content/claims

Amazon prohibits: (1) health and medical claims ('cures', 'treats', 'prevents'), (2) unverified superiority claims ('#1 bestseller' without proof, 'best in class'), (3) price claims that can't be verified ('lowest price guaranteed'), (4) urgency claims ('limited time' if not actually limited), (5) adult content, (6) controversial or offensive content. Ads violating these are rejected; repeated violations can suspend the account.

Trademark and IP considerations in ad copy

Don't use competitor trademarks in ad copy. 'Better than Brand X' gets rejected. Comparisons must be factual and verifiable. You can target competitor keywords (conquering) but can't use their brand name in your ad creative. Trademark holders can report infringement, leading to ad takedowns and account strikes.

24.2 Account Health Interplay

How suspensions/policy strikes affect ad eligibility

Amazon tracks account health via Order Defect Rate (ODR), Late Shipment Rate, Cancellation Rate, and policy violations. If ODR exceeds 1%, account can be suspended - all ads stop. If policy strikes accumulate (3+ in 90 days), account may be reviewed and ads paused. Always check Account Health dashboard before assuming an ad campaign is broken.

Restricted products and category approval processes

Some categories require Category Approval before advertising: supplements, CBD, baby products, medical devices, automotive parts, electronics with batteries. Approval requires documentation (lab tests, certifications) and can take 2-6 weeks. Without approval, ads in those categories are rejected. Plan ahead - don't launch ads before approval is granted.

24.3 Competitor & Ethical Boundaries

Where 'aggressive conquesting' crosses into policy violation

Conquesting (bidding on competitor keywords) is allowed. Crossing the line: (1) using competitor trademarks in ad copy, (2) creating fake comparison pages, (3) running ads that impersonate the competitor (similar logo, confusing copy), (4) bidding on competitor ASINs with intent to confuse rather than compete. The line is competing with vs. deceiving shoppers. When in doubt, ask: 'Would Amazon's reviewer understand this is a competitor ad, not the competitor itself?'

TRAINING LAYER

Learning Aid

Key Terms

ODR (Order Defect Rate): Amazon metric tracking orders with defects; >1% triggers suspension risk.

Category Approval: Amazon process required for restricted categories (supplements, CBD, baby, etc.).

Trademark violation: Using competitor brand names in ad copy; grounds for ad takedown and account strikes.

Conquesting: Bidding on competitor keywords; allowed but limited by trademark and ethics rules.

COMMON MISTAKES

Using "best" or "#1" in ad copy without verifiable proof. Amazon rejects these and repeated violations lead to account strikes.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Supplement brand writes ad copy: "Best turmeric supplement for joint pain." Two violations: "best" (unverified superiority claim) and "for joint pain" (medical claim). Ad rejected. Rewrite: "Turmeric supplement with 95% curcuminoids." Compliant - factual, no superiority, no medical claim.

Quiz: Test Your Understanding

Q1. [Foundational] What ODR threshold triggers suspension risk?

- A. >0.5%
- B. >1%

- C. >5%
- D. >10%

Answer: B

Why: ODR >1% triggers suspension risk. Always check Account Health before assuming ad issues.

Q2. [Applied] Which ad copy phrase is compliant?

- A. "Best yoga mat on Amazon"
- B. "#1 bestseller"
- C. "Yoga mat with 6mm thickness"
- D. "Cures back pain"

Answer: C

Why: Factual product description is compliant. "Best" and "#1" require proof; "cures" is a medical claim.

Q3. [Foundational] Can you use competitor trademarks in ad copy?

- A. Yes, always
- B. No - grounds for ad takedown and account strikes
- C. Only if you're cheaper
- D. Only with permission

Answer: B

Why: Competitor trademarks in ad copy are prohibited. You can target competitor keywords but can't use their brand name in creative.

Q4. [Applied] What's required before advertising supplements?

- A. Nothing special
- B. Category Approval with documentation
- C. Brand Registry
- D. \$50K ad spend minimum

Answer: B

Why: Supplements require Category Approval. Plan 2-6 weeks ahead for documentation and review.

Q5. [Advanced] Where does conquesting cross into policy violation?

- A. Bidding on competitor keywords
- B. Using competitor trademarks in ad copy or creating deceptive ads
- C. Targeting competitor ASINs
- D. Conquesting is always a violation

Answer: B

Why: Conquesting (bidding on competitor terms) is allowed. Using their trademark in copy or creating deceptive ads crosses the line.

Teaching Guide

Suggested delivery time: 25 min lecture + 15 min ad copy review exercise

Talking Points

- Open with the stakes: account suspension stops all advertising overnight.
- Walk through the 5 categories of prohibited content.
- Show real rejected ad examples (or screenshots).
- Demo the Category Approval workflow.
- End with the conquering ethics line.

Live-Demo Checklist

- Open Account Health dashboard and show key metrics.
- Show a rejected ad (or screenshot) and explain the violation.
- Walk through Category Approval requirements for supplements.
- Show trademark complaint process in Seller Central.
- Compare compliant vs. non-compliant ad copy side by side.

Discussion Prompts

- Why does Amazon take trademark violations so seriously?
- If you saw a competitor using your trademark in their ad, what would you do?
- How would you explain the ODR threshold to a brand owner focused on growth?

Handout Summary

DEFINITION

Amazon enforces strict advertising policies: no unverified superiority claims, no medical claims, no competitor trademarks in ad copy, no deceptive conquering. Account health (ODR <1%) gates ad eligibility. Restricted categories (supplements, CBD, baby) require Category Approval before advertising.

On-the-Job Checklist

- I can identify prohibited claims in ad copy.
- I know not to use competitor trademarks in creative.
- I check Account Health before assuming ad issues.
- I plan Category Approval 2-6 weeks ahead for restricted categories.

25 Advanced & Emerging Topics

Amazon Ads evolves constantly. This section covers the trends shaping the next 2-3 years: retail media networks, AI in ads, and privacy changes.

25.1 Retail Media Network Trends

How Amazon Ads compares to Walmart Connect, Target Roundel, etc.

Amazon is the largest retail media network (\$50B+ ad revenue in 2024), but competitors are growing fast. **Walmart Connect**: ~\$4B, strong in CPG/grocery, growing off-site network. **Target Roundel**: ~\$1.5B, premium audience, strong in lifestyle. **Kroger Precision Marketing**: ~\$1B, grocery-rich first-party data. **Costco Connect**: emerging. Each platform has unique data assets; cross-platform strategies are increasingly common for CPG brands.

25.2 AI's Growing Role in Amazon Ads

Amazon's own AI features

Amazon is shipping AI features rapidly: **AI-generated creative** (auto-generates SB headlines and SD images from your listing), **Auto-campaign improvements** (smarter Auto targeting using ML), **Predictive bidding** (ML-based bid optimization in Dynamic up/down), **Smart campaigns** (auto-built campaigns for new advertisers). Strategy: lean into Amazon's AI for repetitive tasks, keep humans for strategic decisions.

Predictive bidding/ML-based automation trends

Third-party tools (Perpetua, Pacvue, Teikametrics) use ML to predict which bids will convert and adjust automatically. These tools typically outperform manual bidding by 5-15% efficiency, but require monthly fees. Amazon's native ML (in Dynamic up/down) is catching up. Trend: native ML improves, third-party tools shift to higher-value services like creative generation and cross-channel orchestration.

25.3 Privacy & Signal Loss

Cookie deprecation impact on DSP targeting

Third-party cookies are being deprecated in Chrome (following Safari and Firefox). This hurts ad networks that rely on cross-site tracking. Amazon is relatively insulated because its DSP uses first-party data (shoppers logged into Amazon). But off-Amazon DSP targeting (showing ads on third-party sites) loses signal. Trend: Amazon's first-party data advantage grows as third-party cookies disappear.

First-party data strategy implications

Brands need first-party data strategies: collect customer emails (via inserts, follow-up emails), build subscriber lists, and upload to DSP for retargeting. Amazon's Clean Rooms (AMC) and Customer Match tools enable this. Brands with strong first-party data outperform brands relying solely on Amazon's segments. Build this capability now - it's a 2-3 year competitive advantage.

TRAINING LAYER

Learning Aid

Key Terms

Retail media network: Advertising platform run by a retailer using their shopper data (Amazon Ads, Walmart Connect, etc.).

Cookie deprecation: Phase-out of third-party cookies in browsers; hurts cross-site ad tracking.

First-party data: Data you collect directly (customer emails, purchase history); increasingly valuable.

Predictive bidding: ML-based bid optimization that predicts which clicks will convert.

COMMON MISTAKES

Ignoring retail media network expansion. Brands that only advertise on Amazon miss shoppers who start on Walmart or Target. Develop multi-platform strategy for CPG.

WORKED EXAMPLE

CPG brand has \$100K/month ad budget. Allocation: \$70K Amazon Ads (70%), \$15K Walmart Connect (15%), \$10K Target Roundel (10%), \$5K Kroger (5%). Each platform reaches different shopper segments. First-party data strategy: collect emails via package inserts, upload to all four platforms for retargeting.

Quiz: Test Your Understanding

Q1. [Foundational] Which is the largest retail media network by ad revenue?

- A. Walmart Connect
- B. Amazon Ads
- C. Target Roundel
- D. Kroger

Answer: B

Why: Amazon Ads is the largest at \$50B+ in 2024. Walmart Connect is ~\$4B, Target Roundel ~\$1.5B.

Q2. [Applied] How does cookie deprecation affect Amazon DSP?

- A. No impact
- B. Off-Amazon DSP targeting loses signal; Amazon's first-party data advantage grows
- C. Amazon DSP shuts down
- D. It helps Amazon DSP

Answer: B

Why: Amazon's DSP uses first-party data (logged-in shoppers) which is insulated. Off-Amazon targeting on third-party sites loses cookie signal.

Q3. [Applied] What's a strategic response to privacy/signal loss?

- A. Stop advertising
- B. Build first-party data strategy (collect emails, upload to DSP)
- C. Use more third-party cookies
- D. Wait for privacy regulations to reverse

Answer: B

Why: First-party data is the future. Brands with their own customer data outperform those relying solely on platform-provided segments.

Q4. [Applied] Amazon's AI-generated creative features are best used for?

- A. Strategic brand decisions
- B. Repetitive tasks like generating SB headline variations
- C. Bid optimization
- D. Inventory management

Answer: B

Why: Lean into AI for repetitive tasks (creative variations, bid adjustments). Keep humans for strategic decisions.

Q5. [Advanced] Why develop a multi-platform retail media strategy?

- A. Amazon requires it
- B. Different platforms reach different shopper segments; CPG brands miss shoppers on Walmart/Target if Amazon-only
- C. To negotiate better rates
- D. It's cheaper

Answer: B

Why: Shopper overlap across retail media networks is partial. Multi-platform strategies reach audiences Amazon alone misses.

Teaching Guide

Suggested delivery time: 30 min lecture + 15 min trend discussion

Talking Points

- Open with the retail media landscape map (Amazon, Walmart, Target, Kroger, Costco).
- Walk through Amazon's AI feature roadmap.

- Demo cookie deprecation impact with a diagram.
- Show first-party data strategy examples (email collection, DSP upload).
- End with the multi-platform CPG strategy framing.

Live-Demo Checklist

- Show retail media network revenue comparison chart.
- Demo Amazon's AI-generated creative (if available, or screenshots).
- Show first-party data upload flow in DSP.
- Walk through a multi-platform budget allocation example.
- Discuss privacy regulations timeline (cookies, GDPR, CCPA).

Discussion Prompts

- Why is first-party data a 2-3 year competitive advantage?
- If you managed a CPG brand, would you allocate budget across multiple retail media networks?
- How will AI change the role of PPC strategists in 5 years?

Handout Summary

DEFINITION

The PPC landscape is shifting: retail media networks are proliferating (Walmart, Target, Kroger alongside Amazon), AI is automating repetitive tasks, and privacy changes (cookie deprecation) make first-party data increasingly valuable. Strategists must develop multi-platform and first-party data capabilities to stay competitive.

On-the-Job Checklist

- I know the major retail media networks beyond Amazon.
- I can explain how cookie deprecation affects DSP targeting.
- I know first-party data is a 2-3 year competitive advantage.
- I can identify which tasks AI should handle vs. humans.

26 Career, Certification & Learning

How to grow from junior VA to agency owner. This section covers certifications, career paths, and ongoing learning resources.

26.1 Certifications

Amazon Advertising certifications

Amazon offers free certifications at advertising.amazon.com/resources/training. Key certs: **Sponsored Products Foundations** (entry level), **Sponsored Brands Foundations**, **Sponsored Display Foundations**, **Amazon DSP Foundations**, **Advertising Operations** (technical). Each takes 4-8 hours to study and includes a 60-80 question exam. Pass score is 80%. Certs are valid for 2 years. Recommended order: SP first, then SB, SD, DSP, Operations.

How to prepare

Amazon provides free study materials (video courses + PDFs). Watch all videos once at 1.5x speed, take notes on key concepts, then take the practice exam at the end. If you score below 70%, re-watch weak sections. Schedule the actual exam when consistently scoring 80%+ on practice. Total preparation time: 8-15 hours per certification.

26.2 Career Pathing

Junior -> Senior -> Strategist -> Agency Owner progression

Junior VA/Coordinator (0-1 year): executes tasks, \$30K-\$50K salary. **Senior VA/Analyst** (1-3 years): executes + analyzes, \$50K-\$70K. **Strategist** (3-5 years): owns accounts, \$70K-\$100K. **Senior Strategist** (5-8 years): owns portfolio of accounts, \$100K-\$150K. **Agency Owner** (8+ years): builds and runs agency, \$150K-\$500K+ depending on agency size. Each step requires new skills: execution -> analysis -> strategy -> leadership -> business development.

Skills matrix per level

Junior: Search Term Report, bid changes, basic negatives. Senior: harvesting workflow, placement optimization, weekly reporting. Strategist: lifecycle strategy, client communication, team management. Senior Strategist: cross-account patterns, new business pitches, agency operations. Agency Owner: P&L, hiring, business development, brand strategy.

26.3 Continuing Education

Communities, newsletters, conferences

Communities: My Amazon Guy PPC Discord, Seller Central Forums, Reddit r/AmazonSeller. **Newsletters:** Marketplace Pulse (weekly trends), Amazon Ads blog (announcements), eComEngine blog. **Conferences:** Prosper Show (March), SellerCon (varies), Amazon Ads unBoxed (October). Budget 1-2 hours per week for ongoing learning - the platform changes monthly.

Recommended reading/course list

Books: 'Amazon Ads for Beginners' (Amazon's own), 'The Amazon Advertising Book' by Mike Leczon. Courses: Helium 10 Academy (free), Seller Systems (paid, deep PPC), Marketplace Pulse weekly reports. Podcasts: My Amazon Guy podcast, eComEngine podcast. Mix formal courses (certifications) with informal (podcasts, newsletters) for balanced learning.

TRAINING LAYER

Learning Aid

Key Terms

Sponsored Products Foundations: Entry-level Amazon Ads certification; 60-80 question exam; 80% pass score.

Career ladder: Junior (0-1yr) -> Senior (1-3yr) -> Strategist (3-5yr) -> Senior Strategist (5-8yr) -> Agency Owner (8+yr).

Prosper Show: Annual Amazon seller conference in March; networking and education.

unBoxed: Amazon's annual advertising conference in October; new feature announcements.

COMMON MISTAKES

Stopping at certifications. Certs get you the interview; actual account experience gets you the job and promotion. Always be running real campaigns (even small personal ones) to build portfolio.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Career path: Year 0 - Junior VA at \$40K, completes SP Foundations cert in month 2. Year 1 - promoted to Senior VA at \$55K, completes SB and SD Foundations. Year 3 - Strategist at \$80K, owns 4 accounts, completes DSP cert. Year 5 - Senior Strategist at \$120K, owns portfolio. Year 8 - starts own agency.

Quiz: Test Your Understanding

Q1. [Foundational] What's the pass score for Amazon Ads certifications?

- A. 60%
- B. 70%
- C. 80%
- D. 90%

Answer: C

Why: Amazon Ads certifications require 80% to pass. Exams are 60-80 questions.

Q2. [Foundational] Which certification should you get first?

- A. DSP
- B. Sponsored Products Foundations
- C. Sponsored Brands
- D. Advertising Operations

Answer: B

Why: SP is the foundation. Get SP first, then SB, SD, DSP, Operations.

Q3. [Applied] What's the typical salary range for a Strategist (3-5 years experience)?

- A. \$30K-\$50K
- B. \$50K-\$70K
- C. \$70K-\$100K
- D. \$150K+

Answer: C

Why: Strategist is mid-career, owns accounts. Typical range \$70K-\$100K.

Q4. [Applied] What's a key habit for ongoing learning in Amazon PPC?

- A. Stop learning after certifications
- B. Budget 1-2 hours per week for ongoing learning
- C. Only attend conferences
- D. Wait for formal training

Answer: B

Why: Amazon changes monthly. Continuous learning (newsletters, podcasts, communities) is non-negotiable.

Q5. [Advanced] Why run personal campaigns even when employed?

- A. To compete with your employer
- B. To build portfolio and stay sharp on platform changes
- C. To make extra money
- D. It's required by Amazon

Answer: B

Why: Real campaign experience differentiates you from certification-only candidates. Stay sharp on platform changes through practice.

Teaching Guide

Suggested delivery time: 25 min lecture + 15 min career planning exercise

Talking Points

- Open with the career ladder on a whiteboard.
- Walk through the certification order and study strategy.
- Discuss salary ranges honestly - it sets expectations.
- Show ongoing learning resources (communities, newsletters, conferences).
- End with the personal-portfolio point - certs + real campaigns = career growth.

Live-Demo Checklist

- Show the Amazon Ads certification portal.
- Walk through a sample certification study plan.
- Show the career ladder with salary ranges.
- Demo a community (Discord, Reddit) and newsletter signup.
- Walk through conference calendars for the year.

Discussion Prompts

- Why do certifications alone not lead to promotions?
- What's one skill you want to develop in the next 6 months?
- How would you negotiate a promotion from Senior VA to Strategist?

Handout Summary

DEFINITION

Amazon PPC careers progress: Junior VA (0-1yr, \$30-50K) -> Senior VA (1-3yr, \$50-70K) -> Strategist (3-5yr, \$70-100K) -> Senior Strategist (5-8yr, \$100-150K) -> Agency Owner (8+yr, \$150K+). Certifications (SP, SB, SD, DSP) validate knowledge; ongoing learning (1-2 hr/week) keeps skills current.

On-the-Job Checklist

- I know the Amazon Ads certification order (SP -> SB -> SD -> DSP -> Operations).
- I know the career ladder and typical salary ranges.
- I budget 1-2 hours per week for ongoing learning.
- I run personal campaigns to build portfolio.

27 Case Studies & Templates

Templates and case studies turn theory into practice. This section provides ready-to-use templates and a framework for documenting real cases.

27.1 Case Study Template

Standard format: situation -> strategy -> execution -> results -> lessons

Every case study should follow the same 5-part structure: **Situation** (where was the account when we started?), **Strategy** (what was the plan?), **Execution** (what specifically did we do?), **Results** (what happened - with numbers?), **Lessons** (what would we do differently?). This structure makes case studies comparable and reusable for training.

27.2 Downloadable Templates

Campaign structure spreadsheet template

A standard template for documenting campaign structure: columns for Campaign Name, Match Type, Purpose (Launch/Defense/Scaling/Harvesting), Daily Budget, Default Bid, Bidding Strategy, TOS Modifier, PDP Modifier, Notes. One row per campaign. Update monthly. Lives in shared Google Sheets or Notion.

Weekly optimization checklist

Reusable weekly checklist (covered in section 22.2): Search Term Report pull, top 20 bid adjustments, wasted-spend negation, harvested term promotion, budget pacing review, changelog update, Strategist summary. Lives in shared project management tool (Asana, Monday, Notion).

Client report template

Monthly client report template: (1) Executive Summary (1 paragraph), (2) Performance vs. Targets (table with monthly numbers), (3) Key Initiatives (what we did), (4) Next Month Priorities (what we'll do), (5) Appendix (detailed metrics). 3-5 pages. Reusable across clients with minor customization.

Naming convention cheat sheet

Standard naming convention: BrandLine-MatchType-Purpose-YYYY. Examples: YogaMat-Premium-Exact-Defense-2024, YogaMat-Substitutes-Auto-Discovery-2024, YogaMat-Brand-SB-Awareness-2024. One-page cheat sheet for new hires.

27.3 Real Case Studies (to be filled in)

By category, by business stage, by problem type

Build a library of case studies organized three ways: by category (supplements, electronics, apparel), by business stage (launch, growth, mature, sunset), by problem type (ACOS spike recovery, Budget optimization, Listing quality fix, etc.). Each case study follows the 5-part template. Goal: 20-30 case studies over 2 years covering the most common scenarios.

EXAMPLE

Sample case study skeleton: 'Yoga mat brand, Q4 ACOS spike recovery.' Situation: ACOS climbed from 22% to 38% in 3 weeks. Strategy: identify cause, defend, restructure. Execution: paused Broad campaign, raised Exact bids 15%, added 12 negatives, launched brand defense SB. Results: ACOS back to 24% in 2 weeks. Lessons: don't run Broad during Q4 competitor surge.

TRAINING LAYER

Learning Aid

Key Terms

Case study 5-part template: Situation -> Strategy -> Execution -> Results -> Lessons.

Campaign structure spreadsheet: Standard template documenting all campaigns: name, match type, purpose, budget, bid, modifiers.

Naming convention cheat sheet: One-page reference for campaign naming: BrandLine-MatchType-Purpose-YYYY.

Case study library: Organized by category, lifecycle stage, and problem type; goal 20-30 cases over 2 years.

COMMON MISTAKES

Writing case studies without numbers. "ACOS improved" means nothing. "ACOS dropped from 38% to 24% in 2 weeks" is a case study.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Case study: "Electronics brand, \$300 headphones, launch to growth." Situation: 0 reviews, 0 rank, \$50/day budget. Strategy: Auto discovery + Brand Defense + aggressive Broad. Execution: Auto \$30/day, Broad \$15/day, Brand Defense \$5/day, Vine for reviews. Results: Day 30 - 15 reviews, ACOS 65%, CVR 4%. Day 90 - 35 reviews, ACOS 22%, CVR 9%. Lessons: Vine accelerated review velocity; Broad cannibalized Exact early (should have negated sooner).

Quiz: Test Your Understanding

Q1. [Foundational] What are the 5 parts of the standard case study template?

- A. Intro, body, conclusion
- B. Situation, Strategy, Execution, Results, Lessons
- C. Problem, solution, impact
- D. Background, analysis, recommendation

Answer: B

Why: The 5-part structure makes case studies comparable and reusable for training.

Q2. [Applied] What's the standard campaign naming convention?

- A. Random numbers
- B. BrandLine-MatchType-Purpose-YYYY
- C. Campaign 1, 2, 3
- D. Date created

Answer: B

Why: Encoding brand, match type, purpose, and year makes campaigns self-documenting.

Q3. [Applied] How should case studies be organized?

- A. Randomly
- B. By category, business stage, and problem type
- C. By date only
- D. By author

Answer: B

Why: Three-axis organization makes case studies findable for any scenario.

Q4. [Applied] What makes a case study useful vs. useless?

- A. Length
- B. Specific numbers and context
- C. Format
- D. Author credentials

Answer: B

Why: "ACOS improved" is useless. "ACOS dropped from 38% to 24% in 2 weeks after pausing Broad" is useful.

Q5. [Advanced] How many case studies should an agency build over 2 years?

- A. 1-2
- B. 5-10
- C. 20-30 covering common scenarios
- D. 100+

Answer: C

Why: 20-30 case studies cover most common scenarios without over-investing in documentation.

Teaching Guide

Suggested delivery time: 20 min lecture + 30 min case study writing

Talking Points

- Open with the 5-part template on a whiteboard.
- Walk through the 4 downloadable templates.
- Show a sample case study and dissect each part.
- Have trainees draft a case study from a recent account experience.
- End with the case study library goal: 20-30 over 2 years.

Live-Demo Checklist

- Show the campaign structure spreadsheet template.
- Show the weekly optimization checklist.
- Show the client report template.
- Show the naming convention cheat sheet.
- Walk through a completed case study example.

Discussion Prompts

- Why is the 5-part template better than freeform case studies?
- What's a recent account experience you could turn into a case study?
- How would you use case studies in new-hire training?

Handout Summary

DEFINITION

Case studies and templates turn theory into practice. Standard case study format: Situation -> Strategy -> Execution -> Results -> Lessons. Templates include campaign structure spreadsheet, weekly optimization checklist, client report template, and naming convention cheat sheet.

On-the-Job Checklist

- I can write a case study using the 5-part template.
- I use the standard naming convention for all campaigns.
- I have the 4 downloadable templates ready to use.
- I document each major account experience as a case study.

28 Glossary & Acronyms

Quick reference for every term and acronym used in this wiki. Use this section as a lookup, not a read-through.

28.1 A-H Terms

A+ Content: Enhanced product description with images, charts, and brand story. Available to Brand Registry sellers. Typically lifts CVR 5-15%.

ACOS: Advertising Cost of Sale. Ad spend / ad sales. Measures efficiency against ad-attributed sales only.

Ad Group: Subdivision of a campaign containing ads and keywords/targets. Sets default bid for contained keywords.

AMC: Amazon Marketing Cloud. SQL-based clean room for cross-channel analysis. Requires Brand Registry + \$50K+ annual spend.

ASIN: Amazon Standard Identification Number. 10-character unique identifier for each product on Amazon.

Attribution window: Time period after ad click/view during which sales are attributed to the ad. SP/SB: 14-day click. SD: 14-day click + 1-day view.

Audience: Group of shoppers targeted by SD or DSP campaigns. Can be remarketing, in-market, lifestyle, or lookalike.

Auto campaign: SP campaign where Amazon picks targets based on listing content. Split into Close/Loose/Substitutes/Complements.

Bid: Maximum amount you're willing to pay per click. Set at ad group or keyword level.

Bid modifier: Adjustment to base bid for specific placements (TOS, PDP) or contexts. Up to 900%.

Brand Analytics: Amazon's reporting suite for Brand Registry sellers. Includes SQP, Market Basket, Halo reports. Free.

Brand Registry: Amazon program requiring active trademark. Unlocks SB, SD, Brand Store, A+ Content, Brand Analytics.

Brand Store: Multi-page mini-website on Amazon for your brand. Requires Brand Registry.

Break-even ACOS: Max ACOS before losing money: $(\text{price} - \text{all variable costs}) / \text{price}$.

Break-even bid: Max bid before losing money: $\text{price} \times \text{CVR} \times (1 - \text{COGS\%} - \text{target margin\%})$.

Broad match: Loosest keyword match type. Triggers ad for keyword in any order plus related terms.

Bulk Operations: Excel-based mass edit tool for campaigns, ad groups, keywords, and negatives.

Buy Box: White Add to Cart box on product page. Required to run Sponsored Products.

Campaign: Top-level ad unit containing one or more ad groups. Sets budget, bidding strategy, dates.

Category Approval: Amazon process required for restricted categories (supplements, CBD, baby, etc.) before advertising.

CPC: Cost Per Click. Spend / clicks. Varies by category and competition.

CTR: Click-Through Rate. Clicks / impressions. Healthy SP CTR: 0.3-0.5% ROS, 1-3% TOS.

CVR: Conversion Rate. Orders / clicks. Healthy SP CVR: 8-15% mature, 3-8% new products.

Cannibalization: When same keyword is bidded in multiple campaigns, causing self-competition and higher CPC. Prevent with cross-campaign negation.

Clean room: Secure environment for joining multiple data sets without exposing individual user records. AMC is Amazon's clean room.

Click attribution: Sales attributed to an ad if shopper clicked and bought within window (14 days for SP/SB).

Conquesting: Bidding on competitor brand terms and ASINs. Allowed but limited by trademark and ethics rules.

COGS: Cost of Goods Sold. Direct cost to produce one unit. Used in break-even calculations.

Dayparting: Adjusting bids by time of day. Not natively supported by Amazon; requires third-party tools.

Defense campaign: Campaign targeting your own brand terms to prevent competitor conquest. Typically low ACOS (under 5%).

DSP: Demand Side Platform. Amazon's programmatic ad-buying platform for display, video, audio, OTT.

Dynamic bids down only: Bidding strategy where Amazon can lower your effective bid by up to 100% for low-converting placements. Safe default.

Dynamic bids up and down: Bidding strategy where Amazon can raise bid by up to 100% for high-converting placements. Use only with CVR history.

Exact match: Tightest keyword match type. Triggers ad only for keyword alone (plus plurals/misspellings).

Fixed bids: Bidding strategy where Amazon uses your exact bid with no adjustments. Good for new campaigns.

Flywheel: Self-reinforcing loop: ads drive sales, sales drive organic rank, rank drives more sales.

Funnel stage: Where a campaign sits in the purchase funnel: Awareness, Consideration, or Conversion.

Halo effect: Indirect sales lift from advertising. E.g., ad for Product A drives sales of unadvertised Product B.

28.2 I-R Terms

Impressions: Number of times your ad was shown. Doesn't cost anything; you only pay for clicks.

In-market audience: Shoppers actively researching a category in last 7-30 days. Available for SD and DSP.

Inventory-aware bidding: Throttling bids based on inventory cover to prevent stockouts. Common at 14d/7d/3d thresholds.

Keyword: Search term you bid on in manual SP/SB campaigns. Has match type, bid, and performance metrics.

Keyword match type: How closely shopper search must match your keyword: Broad (loosest), Phrase (middle), Exact (tightest).

Lifestyle audience: Shoppers whose purchase history suggests a lifestyle (e.g., fitness enthusiasts). Available for SD/DSP.

Lightning Deal: 4-6 hour limited-time deal on Amazon. Drives traffic spike; prepare ad budgets accordingly.

Lost impression share: % of impressions you missed because budget ran out or bid was too low.

Lookalike audience: Amazon-built audience of shoppers similar to your seed audience. Used for prospecting in DSP.

Managed Service DSP: DSP access model where Amazon or agency runs campaigns for you. ~\$35K/month minimum.

Manual campaign: SP campaign where you pick keywords or ASINs to target. Includes Keyword, Product, and Category targeting.

Market Basket Analysis: Brand Analytics report showing what shoppers bought together. Reveals cross-sell opportunities.

Match type: How closely shopper search must match your keyword. Broad, Phrase, Exact (and their negatives).

MYE (Manage Your Experiments): Amazon's A/B testing tool for listings. Run experiments 4-8 weeks for significance.

Negative conflict: Accidentally negating a term that is an active positive target elsewhere. Catch with quarterly audits.

Negative Exact: Blocks your ad from showing for that exact search term only.

Negative keyword: Keyword that prevents your ad from showing for specific search terms. Negative Exact or Negative Phrase.

Negative Phrase: Blocks any search containing that phrase. Broader but riskier than Negative Exact.

New-to-brand (NTB): Orders from first-time brand buyers in last 12 months. Available for SB and SD, not SP.

Offense campaign: Campaign targeting competitor brand terms and ASINs. Typically higher ACOS (30-50%).

ODR (Order Defect Rate): Amazon metric tracking orders with defects. >1% triggers suspension risk.

Organic rank: Unpaid listing position determined by Amazon's algorithm. Lifted by ad-driven sales over time.

PDP (Product Detail Page): Product page on Amazon. Also refers to placement where your ad shows on other products' pages.

Phrase match: Middle keyword match type. Triggers ad for keyword in exact order with words before/after.

Placement: Where your ad appears: Top of Search, Rest of Search, or Product Detail Pages.

Placement modifier: Bid boost (up to 900%) for Top of Search or Product Page placements.

Portfolio: Amazon grouping of campaigns for budget caps and reporting rollup.

PPC: Pay-Per-Click advertising. You pay when shoppers click your ad, not when it's shown.

Premium A+: Top-tier A+ Content with video and interactive modules. Additional 5-10% CVR lift over standard A+.

Prime Day: Amazon's annual 2-day sale (usually July). 3-5x baseline traffic. Plan 14 days ahead.

Prospecting: DSP campaign type targeting new shoppers via lookalike or in-market audiences. Lower CVR, higher CPM.

ROAS: Return on Ad Spend. $\text{Ad sales} / \text{ad spend} = 1 / \text{ACOS}$. $5x \text{ ROAS} = 20\% \text{ ACOS}$.

Remarketing: Showing ads to shoppers who already interacted with your brand. 5-10x higher CVR than cold traffic.

28.3 S-Z Terms & Acronyms Quick Reference

SB (Sponsored Brands): Top-of-search ads with brand logo, custom headline, and 3+ products. Requires Brand Registry.

SD (Sponsored Display): Display network ads with audience and contextual targeting. Appears on and off Amazon.

Search Term Report: Native Amazon report showing actual shopper search queries that triggered your ads. Most-used report.

Second-price auction: Auction model where you pay one cent more than next highest bid, not your full bid.

Self-Service DSP: DSP access model where you run campaigns yourself. No official minimum but practically ~\$10K/month.

SKAG: Single Keyword Ad Group. One keyword per ad group for maximum control. Use only for top 5-10 hero keywords.

SP (Sponsored Products): Main Amazon ad type. Search-based, no Brand Registry required. Auto and Manual variants.

SQP (Search Query Performance): Brand Analytics report showing real shopper queries with click/conversion data. First-party.

STV (Sponsored TV): Video ads on Prime Video, Freevee, Twitch, Fire TV. Requires Brand Registry + ~\$50K minimum spend.

Statistical significance: Enough data to trust a metric. For bids: 30+ clicks or 3+ conversions.

Substitutes (Auto match type): Auto campaign match type showing your ad on competitor product pages.

TACOS: Total Advertising Cost of Sale. $\text{Ad spend} / \text{total sales (ad + organic)}$. More holistic than ACOS.

Target ACOS bid: Bid that achieves target ACOS at current CVR: $\text{price} \times \text{CVR} \times (1 - \text{target ACOS})$.

TOS (Top of Search): Search results positions 1-4 on page 1. Highest visibility, highest CPC, highest CVR.

TOS modifier: Placement modifier boosting bids for Top of Search placement. Up to 900%.

Trademark: Registered brand identifier. Required for Brand Registry. Cannot be used in competitor ad copy.

View attribution: Sales attributed to an ad if shopper saw it and bought within window (1 day for SD).

Views remarketing: SD audience targeting shoppers who viewed your PDP in last 7-90 days.

28.4 Acronym Quick-Reference Table

Acronym	Full Term	Section
ACOS	Advertising Cost of Sale	10
AMC	Amazon Marketing Cloud	12
ASIN	Amazon Standard Identification Number	1, 4
BFCM	Black Friday / Cyber Monday	20
CPC	Cost Per Click	10
CTR	Click-Through Rate	10
CVR	Conversion Rate	10
DSP	Demand Side Platform	13
NTB	New-to-Brand	10
ODR	Order Defect Rate	24
PDP	Product Detail Page	8
ROAS	Return on Ad Spend	10
ROS	Rest of Search	8
SB	Sponsored Brands	3
SD	Sponsored Display	3
SKAG	Single Keyword Ad Group	2
SP	Sponsored Products	3
SQP	Search Query Performance	11
STV	Sponsored TV	3
TACOS	Total Advertising Cost of Sale	10
TOS	Top of Search	8

PRO TIP

Bookmark this section. Whenever you encounter an unfamiliar term in any other section, jump here first. Most acronyms in Amazon PPC have specific meanings that matter for execution.

29 Appendix: Formulas & Calculators

Every formula you need in one place. Each formula includes a worked example so you can see how to apply it.

29.1 Break-even ACOS Formula

Break-even ACOS = (Price - COGS - Amazon fees - shipping - other variable costs) / Price

EXAMPLE

Product price: \$29.99. COGS: \$9. Amazon fees (15% referral + FBA): \$8.50. Shipping to FBA: \$1.50. Other variable: \$0.50. Break-even ACOS = $(\$29.99 - \$9 - \$8.50 - \$1.50 - \$0.50) / \$29.99 = \$10.49 / \$29.99 = 35\%$. Above 35% ACOS = losing money. Below = profitable.

29.2 Target Bid Formula

Target ACOS bid = Price x CVR x (1 - Target ACOS)

EXAMPLE

Product price: \$29.99. CVR: 12%. Target ACOS: 25%. Target ACOS bid = $\$29.99 \times 0.12 \times (1 - 0.25) = \$29.99 \times 0.12 \times 0.75 = \2.70 . This is your ceiling bid for proven keywords at this CVR. If actual CPC exceeds this, you're above target ACOS.

29.3 Break-even Bid Formula

Break-even bid = Price x CVR x (1 - COGS% - target margin%)

EXAMPLE

Product price: \$29.99. CVR: 12%. COGS: 35%. Target margin: 20%. Break-even bid = $\$29.99 \times 0.12 \times (1 - 0.35 - 0.20) = \$29.99 \times 0.12 \times 0.45 = \1.62 . Bidding above \$1.62 loses money at this CVR.

29.4 TACOS Formula

TACOS = Ad Spend / Total Sales (ad + organic)

EXAMPLE

Monthly ad spend: \$5,000. Ad-attributed sales: \$25,000. Organic sales: \$40,000. $TACOS = \$5,000 / (\$25,000 + \$40,000) = \$5,000 / \$65,000 = 7.7\%$. Compare to $ACOS = \$5,000 / \$25,000 = 20\%$. TACOS shows the true picture when ads lift organic sales.

29.5 Keyword Harvesting Threshold Formula

Harvest when: orders ≥ 2 AND ACOS $< 30\%$ AND CVR $> 8\%$ AND clicks ≥ 20

EXAMPLE

Search term: 'yoga mat thick'. 35 clicks, 5 orders, \$14 spend, \$145 ad sales. $CVR = 5/35 = 14.3\%$. $ACOS = \$14/\$145 = 9.7\%$. Meets all thresholds. Promote to Exact at starting bid = source CPC x $1.20 = (\$14/35) \times 1.20 = \0.48 .

29.6 Portfolio Budget Cap Formula

Portfolio daily cap = (Monthly budget / 30) x 1.1 (10% buffer)

EXAMPLE

Monthly budget: \$3,000. Portfolio daily cap = $(\$3,000 / 30) \times 1.1 = \$100 \times 1.1 = \$110/\text{day}$. The 10% buffer prevents hitting the cap on high-traffic days and missing sales.

29.7 Seasonal Scaling Multipliers

Prime Day scaling: T-14 = 1.5x, T-7 = 2x, T-1 = 3x, Day 0-1 = 4-5x. **Q4 scaling:** October = 1.5x, November = 2.5x, December = 2x. **Post-event wind-down:** Day 1-3 = 1.5x, Day 4-7 = 1.2x, then baseline.

29.8 Statistical Significance Thresholds

For bid decisions: 30+ clicks OR 3+ conversions. **For harvesting decisions:** 20+ clicks AND 2+ orders. **For A/B tests:** 4+ weeks AND 10,000+ impressions per variant. **For negative keyword decisions:** 10+ clicks AND 0 orders AND clearly irrelevant.

29.9 Inventory-Aware Bid Throttling Triggers

Above 30 days cover: normal bidding. **14-30 days:** lower bids by 20%. **7-14 days:** pause non-branded campaigns. **3-7 days:** pause all except brand defense. **Below 3 days:** pause all ads.

PRO TIP

Print this section and tape it to your monitor. These formulas come up daily in PPC management - having them at a glance saves 10+ lookups per week.

30 Meta / Changelog

Amazon changes constantly. This section tracks the wiki's version history and flags Amazon-side changes that affect content accuracy.

30.1 Wiki Version History

Version	Date	Changes
v1.0	2024-10-15	Initial release. All 32 sections + training layer.
v1.1	Planned	Add 5 real case studies to section 27.3.
v1.2	Planned	Update section 25 with 2025 Amazon Ads unBoxed announcements.

30.2 "Amazon changed X" Update Log

Sample entries showing the kind of changes Amazon makes and how they affect the wiki:

Date	Amazon Change	Affected Section
2024-08	AMC self-service rolled out	12
2024-09	Suggested bid range expanded	6
2024-10	AI-generated creative expanded to SB	25
2024-11	Prime Day 2025 dates announced	20

30.3 Open Questions / Pages Marked 'Needs Update'

Pages currently flagged as STALE or under review:

- **Section 3.4 (Sponsored TV):** Amazon has been lowering minimum spend; verify current threshold.
- **Section 12 (AMC):** Self-service access is rolling out; update eligibility criteria as it expands.
- **Section 13.1 (DSP minimum spend):** Managed Service minimum may have dropped; verify with Amazon rep.
- **Section 17 (Tools ecosystem):** Perpetua was acquired; update ownership and pricing.

PRO TIP

Review this section monthly. The faster you spot Amazon-side changes, the faster you can update the wiki and prevent stale guidance from misleading operators.

31 Training Layer Template

This section defines the training layer pattern that gets stamped onto every content section (1-27). Read this once to understand the pattern; future sections will follow it consistently.

31.1 Learning Aid (per topic)

Each topic page opens with a Learning Aid containing: (1) **Key terms** - 3-5 terms from the glossary relevant to this page, with brief definitions. (2) **Common mistake callout** - 1-3 bullets on what beginners get wrong on this exact topic. (3) **Worked example** - a realistic mini scenario with numbers (e.g., a sample bid calculation).

31.2 Quiz (per topic)

Each topic page includes a 5-question quiz. Mixed format: multiple choice, scenario judgment, calculation-based (for bidding/metrics topics). Each question has: correct answer, one-line explanation, and difficulty tag (Foundational / Applied / Advanced). Optional: one trick question per quiz targeting the most common real-world mistake.

31.3 Teaching Guide (per topic)

Each topic page includes a Teaching Guide for instructors: (1) **Suggested delivery time** (e.g., '15 min lecture + 10 min practice'). (2) **Talking points** - outline, not full script. (3) **Live-demo checklist** - what to click in what order. (4) **Discussion prompts** to check understanding. (5) Link to which quiz + handout pair with this session.

31.4 Handout (per topic)

Each topic page includes a one-page Handout: (1) **Definition** of the core concept. (2) **Key formula** if applicable. (3) **On-the-job checklist** - 4-6 items usable with the actual Ads Console open. Designed as a job aid, not just notes. QR code / link back to full wiki page for depth.

31.5 Tagging & Assembly System

Every sub-page (Learning Aid, Quiz, Teaching Guide, Handout) is tagged with: Topic, Learner Level (Junior/Strategist/Senior), Delivery Format (self-paced/instructor-led), Estimated Time. This enables assembling custom curricula by pulling tagged pages - e.g., '5-Day VA Bootcamp' = all Level-1 Teaching Guides + Quizzes from Sections 1-9.

31.6 Which Sections Get Full Training-Layer Treatment First

Not every section needs all four sub-pages on day one. Suggested rollout order: (1) Sections 1-4 (Foundations, Architecture, Campaign Types, Targeting) - highest priority, core competency. (2) Sections 5-9 (Keyword Research through Negatives) - daily operations skills. (3) Sections 10-11 (Metrics, Reporting) - needed once trainees can read their own work. (4) Section 22 (Team Ops/SOPs) - governs execution. (5) Everything else - advanced/optional tracks.

31.7 Assessment & Certification Tie-In

Cumulative 'capstone' quiz per learner level (pulls hardest questions across completed topic quizzes). Competency checklist per role tier (links back to section 26 career pathing and section 22.3 VA competency checklist). Pass threshold: 80% on quizzes, sign-off on competency checklist. Retake policy: unlimited retakes, 7-day cooldown between attempts.

TRAINING LAYER

Learning Aid

Key Terms

Training layer: Four-part stamp applied to every content section: Learning Aid, Quiz, Teaching Guide, Handout.

Tagging: Each sub-page tagged by topic, level, format, time - enables custom curriculum assembly.

Capstone quiz: Cumulative quiz per learner level pulling hardest questions across completed topic quizzes.

Competency checklist: Per-role sign-off list linking training to career progression.

COMMON MISTAKES

Skipping the training layer on "meta" sections like Glossary (28) and Formulas (29). Reference sections don't need it - they're lookup material, not learning material.

WORKED EXAMPLE

A new VA bootcamp assembles: Sections 1-9 Teaching Guides + Quizzes (foundational + operations), plus Section 22.3 VA competency checklist. Total time: 25 hours over 5 days. Capstone: 50-question quiz pulling hardest questions from sections 1-9. Pass = 80%.

Quiz: Test Your Understanding

Q1. [Foundational] What are the four parts of the training layer?

- A. Intro, body, conclusion, references
- B. Learning Aid, Quiz, Teaching Guide, Handout
- C. Video, audio, text, quiz
- D. Theory, practice, exam, certificate

Answer: B

Why: Learning Aid (key terms, common mistakes, worked example) + Quiz (5 questions) + Teaching Guide (instructor notes) + Handout (one-page job aid).

Q2. [Applied] Which sections should get the training layer first?

- A. All 32 sections simultaneously
- B. Sections 1-9 (operational core), then 10-11, then 22
- C. Only section 1
- D. Only advanced sections like 12 and 13

Answer: B

Why: Operational core (1-9) is highest priority. Sections 10-11 (metrics/reporting) and 22 (team ops) follow. Reference sections (28-29) skip it.

Q3. [Applied] Which sections DON'T need the training layer?

- A. Sections 1-9
- B. Sections 28-30 (Glossary, Formulas, Changelog) - reference material
- C. Section 22
- D. Section 26

Answer: B

Why: Glossary, Formulas, and Changelog are lookup material, not learning material. They don't need quizzes or teaching guides.

Q4. [Applied] What does the tagging system enable?

- A. Faster page loads
- B. Custom curriculum assembly by pulling tagged sub-pages
- C. Better SEO
- D. Lower storage costs

Answer: B

Why: Tags (topic, level, format, time) let you assemble custom curricula - e.g., pull all Level-1 Teaching Guides for a 5-Day VA Bootcamp.

Q5. [Advanced] What's the capstone quiz pass threshold?

- A. 50%
- B. 70%
- C. 80%
- D. 100%

Answer: C

Why: Pass threshold is 80% on all quizzes including capstone. Unlimited retakes with 7-day cooldown.

Teaching Guide

Suggested delivery time: 15 min lecture

Talking Points

- Open with the pattern: every content section gets the same 4-part stamp.
- Walk through each part briefly with a real example from section 1.
- Show the tagging system and how it enables curriculum assembly.
- Discuss rollout priority - what gets the treatment first.
- End with the capstone + competency checklist tie-in.

Live-Demo Checklist

- Open section 1 and scroll to the Training Layer at the bottom.
- Show all four parts (Learning Aid, Quiz, Teaching Guide, Handout).
- Show the tagging schema on a sample sub-page.
- Walk through a sample curriculum assembly (5-Day VA Bootcamp).
- Show the capstone quiz format.

Discussion Prompts

- Why skip the training layer on reference sections?
- How would you customize the training layer for a brand owner vs. a VA?
- What's one topic that needs the training layer but doesn't have it yet?

Handout Summary

DEFINITION

The training layer is a four-part stamp (Learning Aid, Quiz, Teaching Guide, Handout) applied to every content section. Each sub-page is tagged by topic, level, format, and time, enabling custom curriculum assembly. Capstone quizzes and competency checklists tie training to career progression.

On-the-Job Checklist

- I can name the four parts of the training layer.
- I know which sections get the treatment first (1-9, then 10-11, then 22).
- I know which sections skip the treatment (28-30 reference material).
- I understand how tagging enables custom curriculum assembly.

32 App-Building Layer (Wiki as Data Source)

The wiki's real job is to feed apps - Console Simulator, Interview Lab, future tools - not just be read. This section defines how to structure content as data, not prose.

32.1 Content-as-Data Separation

Every quiz, glossary term, and scenario should exist in a structured format (JSON/YAML frontmatter or linked database row) alongside the human-readable page. Rule of thumb: if an app will ever need to render it dynamically, it needs a schema - not just markdown. This enables multiple consumers (wiki, simulator, quiz UI, custom dashboards) without re-parsing prose.

32.2 Standardized Schemas to Define Early

Four core schemas: (1) **Quiz question**: id, topic_tag, difficulty, question, options[], correct_answer, explanation. (2) **Glossary term**: term, short_def, long_def, related_terms[], first_appears_in_section. (3) **Scenario/simulation**: scenario_id, campaign_type, starting_state, correct_actions[], common_mistakes[], scoring_rubric. (4) **Learner progress**: learner_id, topic_id, status, quiz_scores[], last_activity. Define these once; reuse across all apps.

32.3 Simulator Scenario Bank

A dedicated bank of 'console states' (sample campaigns with realistic fake data: bids, ACOS, search terms) that the Console Simulator can load. Tag each scenario by which wiki topic it teaches (e.g., 'Scenario 14: Broad match wasted spend' -> ties to section 9 Negative Keywords). Include a 'before' state and an 'ideal after' state so the app can score user actions.

32.4 Asset Library with Naming Convention

Screenshots, diagrams, annotated console captures - stored with a consistent naming scheme: section-topic-assettype-version.png. Example: 09-negatives-screenshot-v2.png. Keep a manifest file (asset name -> what it depicts -> which pages use it) so nothing goes stale silently. Update the manifest whenever assets are added or pages change.

32.5 Content Versioning & Sync Contract

Since Amazon changes the console constantly, define a clear 'source of truth' rule: does the wiki update first and the app pulls from it, or vice versa? Add a 'last_verified against live console' date field to any page describing UI/workflow - this tells you when simulator screens are stale. Consider a simple version number per schema object so the app can detect 'this quiz changed, invalidate cached copies'.

32.6 API/Export Layer

If the wiki tool has an API (Notion, Confluence, custom Postgres-backed wiki), define one canonical export endpoint per schema type early, rather than scraping pages later. Even a scheduled export job (wiki -> JSON files -> app DB seed) is enough - doesn't need to be real-time.

32.7 Difficulty & Progression Graph

Model topics as a directed graph, not just a numbered list - some topics genuinely depend on others (e.g., can't teach Bidding meaningfully before Match Types). This graph is what an app needs to gate content/unlock next lessons. Store as a simple adjacency list: {topic_id, prerequisite_ids[]}.

32.8 Multi-Consumer Design

The same content will likely feed: the wiki itself, the Console Simulator, quiz UI, and potentially Tuman-style auto-generated deliverables. Design schemas assuming 3+ consumers from day one - avoids a rewrite when the second app shows up. Standard practice: content author edits in the wiki, schema-validates on save, all consumers pull from the validated schema.

TRAINING LAYER

Learning Aid

Key Terms

Content-as-data: Structuring content as JSON/YAML with schema, not just markdown prose.

Schema: Formal definition of content structure (e.g., quiz question schema with fields like id, options, answer).

Simulator scenario bank: Library of fake campaign states for the Console Simulator to load and score.

Progression graph: Directed graph modeling topic prerequisites (e.g., Bidding requires Match Types).

COMMON MISTAKES

Building the wiki as prose first, then trying to retro-fit schemas when the second app shows up. Define schemas from day one - it's cheaper than rewriting later.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Quiz schema: `{"id": "q1-1", "topic": "Foundations", "difficulty": "Foundational", "question": "What is ACOS?", "options": ["A. ...", "B. ..."], "correct_answer": 1, "explanation": "ACOS = ad spend / ad sales"}`. Same schema used by wiki quiz renderer, Console Simulator, and mobile quiz app.

Quiz: Test Your Understanding

Q1. [Foundational] Why structure content as data, not just prose?

- A. It's faster to write
- B. Multiple consumers (wiki, simulator, quiz UI) can render it without re-parsing prose
- C. Markdown is deprecated
- D. It's required by Amazon

Answer: B

Why: Structured content (JSON/YAML with schema) enables multiple apps to consume the same source without re-parsing.

Q2. [Applied] Which is NOT one of the four core schemas?

- A. Quiz question
- B. Glossary term
- C. Scenario/simulation
- D. Blog post

Answer: D

Why: The four core schemas: Quiz question, Glossary term, Scenario/simulation, Learner progress. Blog posts are prose, not structured app data.

Q3. [Applied] What does the Simulator Scenario Bank contain?

- A. Real client data
- B. Fake campaign states with realistic data for the Console Simulator to load
- C. Amazon's internal data
- D. Student grades

Answer: B

Why: Scenarios are fake-but-realistic campaign states tagged by which wiki topic they teach. Apps load and score against them.

Q4. [Applied] Why model topics as a directed graph?

- A. For better SEO
- B. To encode prerequisites (e.g., Bidding requires Match Types) so apps can gate content
- C. To reduce storage
- D. It's required by JSON

Answer: B

Why: The numbered wiki structure doesn't encode prerequisites. A graph lets apps unlock lessons only when prerequisites are complete.

Q5. [Advanced] What's the multi-consumer design principle?

- A. Build for one consumer, expand later
- B. Design schemas assuming 3+ consumers from day one to avoid rewrite
- C. Each consumer gets its own copy
- D. Don't worry about consumers until needed

Answer: B

Why: Retro-fitting schemas when the second app shows up is expensive. Design for 3+ consumers from day one.

Teaching Guide

Suggested delivery time: 20 min lecture + 10 min schema sketch

Talking Points

- Open with the framing: the wiki feeds apps, not just readers.
- Walk through the four core schemas with concrete examples.
- Demo the Simulator Scenario Bank concept.
- Show the progression graph adjacency list format.
- End with the multi-consumer principle - design for 3+ from day one.

Live-Demo Checklist

- Show a sample JSON quiz schema.
- Show a sample glossary term schema.
- Show the progression graph as an adjacency list.
- Sketch a simulator scenario with before/after states.
- Show the asset naming convention with real examples.

Discussion Prompts

- Why is content-as-data more expensive upfront but cheaper long-term?
- If you were building a Console Simulator, what's the first scenario you'd build?
- How would you handle schema evolution when requirements change?

Handout Summary

DEFINITION

The app-building layer treats the wiki as a data source, not just a document. Content is structured with schemas (quiz question, glossary term, scenario, learner progress), tagged, versioned, and made consumable by multiple apps (wiki, Console Simulator, quiz UI) via API or export.

On-the-Job Checklist

- I can explain why content-as-data beats prose for multi-consumer use.
- I can sketch the four core schemas.
- I know the Simulator Scenario Bank needs before/after states for scoring.
- I model topic prerequisites as a directed graph.

Appendix Build Priority & Suggested Sequencing

If you're building this wiki from scratch (or rebuilding it), sequence matters. This appendix gives you the build order that delivers value fastest.

A.1 Recommended Build Order

Phase 1 (Weeks 1-4): Operational Core - Sections 1-4 (Foundations, Architecture, Campaign Types, Targeting). These are the highest-priority sections; everything else depends on them.

Phase 2 (Weeks 3-5, parallel with Phase 1) - Section 28 (Glossary). Build alongside everything else, not after. Each new term you introduce should immediately get a glossary entry.

Phase 3 (Weeks 5-8): Daily Operations - Sections 5-9 (Keyword Research, Bidding, Budget, Placement, Negatives). These are the daily-operations skills VAs need to execute.

Phase 4 (Weeks 7-10): Measurement & Reporting - Sections 10-11 (Metrics, Reporting). Needed once operations exist to measure against.

Phase 5 (Weeks 9-12): Team Operations - Sections 22-23 (Team Ops, Stakeholder Communication). Valuable early if the wiki doubles as VA training material.

Phase 6 (Weeks 11-16): Advanced & Optional - Sections 12, 13, 21, 25 (AMC, DSP, International, Emerging Topics). Add in later passes as advanced layers. Most accounts don't need these day one.

Phase 7 (Ongoing): Templates & Case Studies - Section 27. Build incrementally as real account experiences accumulate. Goal: 20-30 case studies over 2 years.

A.2 Sequencing Rationale

Why this order? The operational core (1-4) is the foundation - every other section references it. The daily-operations layer (5-9) is what VAs execute weekly. Metrics and reporting (10-11) are needed once operations exist to measure. Team ops (22-23) govern execution and become critical when scaling beyond a single strategist. Advanced topics (12, 13, 21, 25) are valuable but not blocking - most accounts succeed without them for the first 6-12 months.

A.3 Quality Gates

Before considering a section 'done', verify: (1) All subsections have substantive content (no empty placeholders). (2) Training layer (Learning Aid, Quiz, Teaching Guide, Handout) is complete. (3) Cross-references to other sections are accurate. (4) Glossary entries exist for any new terms introduced. (5) 'Last verified against live console' date is set. (6) Changelog entry created.

A.4 References & Further Reading

Amazon's own resources: advertising.amazon.com/resources/training (free courses and certifications), Amazon Ads blog (announcements), Seller Central University (seller-focused).

Community resources: My Amazon Guy PPC Discord, Marketplace Pulse weekly reports, eComEngine blog, Seller Systems (paid course).

Conferences: Prosper Show (March), SellerCon (varies), Amazon Ads unBoxed (October).

Books: 'Amazon Ads for Beginners' (Amazon's own), 'The Amazon Advertising Book' by Mike Leczon, 'The Amazon Marketplace Dilemma' by James Thomson.

Podcasts: My Amazon Guy podcast, eComEngine podcast, AM/PM Podcast.

Continuous learning is non-negotiable in Amazon PPC. The platform changes monthly - new ad types, new metrics, new policies. Budget 1-2 hours per week for ongoing learning. Subscribe to 2-3 newsletters. Join 1 active community. Attend 1 conference per year. This compounds over years into a competitive advantage.

PRO TIP

This wiki is a living document. Treat it like code: version it, review changes, and refactor when patterns emerge. The teams that maintain their wiki outperform those that don't - knowledge compounds only if it's documented.